

Mus 210 The Great Composers

Numbered Transcript

MUS 210 • Samuel Andreyev

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Lecture 1: Johann Sebastian Bach

At a glance — Johann Sebastian Bach.

- 1.1 I'm going to start with an anecdote today. When I was a kid, my father had this record collection, and he had lots of jazz and classical LPs, and my sisters had lots of pop music, a lot of pop music from the UK, actually. I was combing through this collection of albums. The classical LPs, in particular, had this mountain-like quality. It was this authoritative thing. It was like, this music has always been here, and it will always be here, and it's just permanent. It's a permanent feature of our cultural landscape.
- 1.2 You could look at these liner notes, and they would explain the history of it and the importance of the works. And it was all like, this is just how it is. There's no particular reason to question any of this. You can just sit down and listen to these works and be assured of their continued existence and of their significance. And that's how it presented it to me when I was a kid. But now that I'm a little bit older, I have a different perspective on things. I see things slightly differently, and I'm more aware of the fact that this cultural heritage, these great works, these, these high watermark achievements in this art of music, are actually rather fragile.
- 1.3 And you cannot assume that the works that we esteem now that are being performed, that are part of our cultural consciousness, that they'll always be there. We can't assume that there will always be people to perform them, and we can't assume that there will always be audiences to listen to them. So one of the things that's really informed me in my professional life, and also just oriented my decisions as to what I want to spend my time on, is this increasing realization that this is a fragile thing. It's not necessarily permanent. And we all, as members of our respective societies, I think, can actually make a difference. The easiest way you can make a difference in terms of making sure that this work continues to flourish and exist is to pay attention.
- 1.4 What we're going to try to do in this course is, I'm going to outline a narrative that takes us through eight different composers who are all major figures in the Western musical tradition. We're going to talk about who they are as people. We're going to talk about their lives. We're going to talk about the historical context, about what they were up to, philosophically, aesthetically, technically, to a limited degree, although I'm going to assume no prior knowledge of music in this course. And then we're going to listen to some representative works from these composers.
- 1.5 That's basically the orientation of this course. I've done a previous course for the Peterson Academy, which was a lot more broad in its scope. The previous one that I did was called the History of Western Music, and that basically gave you a 1,000-year vista of the origins of Western music, of notation, the different tuning systems we have, of the different theoretical concepts that have irrigated it through its long history. It was

relatively broad. This course is very, very specifically oriented towards the eight composers that I've selected.

- 1.6 The other thing that I'd like to start out with is just to point out that this is a tiny, tiny selection. The composers that we're looking at today span about 200, 250 years, which in the larger context of the Western musical tradition is absolutely tiny. We've got about at least 1,000 years of repertoire. You could arguably date it earlier than that, depending on what you consider reproducible music notation to be, but about 1,000 years. So this is a little fragment of that. And most of the composers that we're going to be looking at are compressed into an even smaller time period than that.
- 1.7 So, bear in mind that this course does not purport to be authoritative or exhaustive or complete, by any means. And my choices of composers, well, I think there would be no particular dispute as to the importance of any of these figures. Nevertheless, other people would make a different selection. They wouldn't choose the same composers as me. There are extremely important figures that I'm not going to be dealing with in this course for various reasons. It could be that it doesn't allow me to present this narrative in quite the way that I'd like to, or it might simply be that there isn't enough time to deal with certain figures. But they're carefully chosen to give a relatively comprehensive outlook of what is meant by classical music, what is represented by this tradition, and who are some of the key figures that shaped it.
- 1.8 Before we get into that, I'm going to start with a few definitions. This course is called The Great Composers. So there's three words in there that I suppose I have to actually deal with. "The"—so that implies these are the great composers. Well, there are lots of others that, once again, I simply can't deal with all of them. But these really are figures that, where we can make a claim that they have actually significantly altered the course of music history. And there are others as well.
- 1.9 What do I mean by composer, precisely? Well, if you would ask that question in the 18th century, you would have gotten a very simple and straightforward answer. Composer is simply somebody who writes music in the form of a written document, as opposed to performing or improvising or making sound recordings, as is, of course, the case today. But composer is someone primarily creating written documents, which implies that their work can be played multiple times in different countries by different performers. So you have a fixed, what's called a score, which is the document that shows all the notes that the musicians have to play. And that's a reproducible thing. So you can take a piece of music. Anybody in principle who has the technical ability can play that piece or perform it. And so that's what I mean by a composer.
- 1.10 Nowadays, it's a little bit more complicated because a composer can be somebody working on some kind of digital workstation. They can be somebody who never actually writes anything down. It could all be recorded. There are lots of improvisational musical traditions, including jazz, for example, that certainly have composers working within those traditions, although they don't primarily write down what it is that they're doing,

in many instances. But for the sake of this course, I'm going to define a composer as someone who writes music.

- 1.11** And what that involves, really, is taking musical elements—this can be chords, rhythms, melodic ideas—arranging them into a fixed shape or a fixed pattern, and orienting that over time. So a composer doesn't just come up with a tune. It doesn't just come up with a melody or a rhythm or something. But the art of musical composition has to do with the way those elements unfold over time. And that's something I'm going to keep coming back to in this course.
- 1.12** So what do I mean by "great"? What constitutes greatness in a composer? Well, there's a few things. Quality is one obvious criteria. What's actually interesting is, if you look into the more obscure figures of the Baroque and classical traditions, let's say, a second-rate or a third-rate composer who, maybe some of their works have survived, maybe a few scores are still performed from time to time, but the bulk of the output is not particularly distinguished.
- 1.13** What you'll find is that the average level in the Baroque, for example, of quality of musical compositions was not always all that high. There's lots of really banal, bland, uninteresting, uninspired music that was written for a particular occasion, but immediately forgotten afterwards. There are lots of bad, dull, uninspired operas, for example, that are no longer performed. Most of this repertoire is known only to musicologists and specialists, and even there, not that many people are going to be interested in it. The things that we've retained, that we're still talking about today and that we're going to be looking at in this course, it's like the top one-tenth of 1% or even less. It's a tiny, tiny percentage of what was actually written.
- 1.14** So by great, I mean primarily the quality of the output. But by great, I also mean it's something like magnitude. It's something like the scope of a composer's achievement, the power of the music that they wrote, its ability to move us, to fascinate us, even today, even hundreds of years after it was written.
- 1.15** But there's another factor here, which is that great composers, they tend to affect the ones that come after them. There's a trope, which is that the audience is the ultimate arbiter, the ultimate decider of musical quality, the ultimate decider of what remains in the repertoire. If a piece is an audience favorite, then it will be a successful piece, and it will be performed many times, and it will stay in the repertory. It's partly true, but it's also somewhat inaccurate, because if you look at the history of music and how it's unfolded, it's actually largely been other composers who have determined this, who have determined what are the pieces that will continue to have an influence, to continue to have an impact. It's often other composers and music professionals that will decide what pieces get played in the first place.
- 1.16** So, by greatness, I mean certainly quality. I mean the durability of the work, its ability to still have something to say to us 250 years after it was written, which is a remarkable

thing, actually. It's really incredible. And then also the impact that the piece has on successive generations. There's a funny thing about that, which is that the greatness doesn't necessarily equate to popularity. It's not a one-to-one correspondence between those things. There are lots of figures in Western musical tradition that had very little success during their lifetimes or whose work took a long time to reach an audience.

- 1.17** I'll give you an example from the pop music world that I appreciate. There's a band called the Velvet Underground, and they were never commercially successful. They put out, I think, four albums, and the first one, which is quite famous, has a cover by Andy Warhol. Now, that album sold a tiny number of copies when it came out. But there's a line that "everybody who bought that album started a band." So it's like the impact of that album on successive generations of pop musicians was colossal. It actually did change the course of pop music. Even though it didn't sell as many copies as *Thriller*, nevertheless, it had a gigantic impact on the culture. So that's something to bear in mind.
- 1.18** All right. So, this course is going to focus on the Baroque, classical, and Romantic, early Romantic periods. So we're going to start with Bach, and then we're going to end with Schoenberg and Stravinsky. Stravinsky died in 1971, Schoenberg in 1951. So, we're going to get about 250 years, from approximately 1700 to 1950. So that's the time span of this course. So the first half of the course is going to deal with the period 1700 to 1828. So that's from the first mature works of Bach, approximately, to the death of Schubert, 1828. And then the second half is going to cover the Romantics, well, two Romantics, anyway, Chopin and Franz Liszt. And then we're going to look at two modern composers.
- 1.19** Now, that is, once again, a small segment of the classical repertory. If you want to get into this in a broader sense, then you can also have a look at the earlier Peterson Academy course I've done. OK, so, why should anyone bother with this music? What's the reason? We've all got complicated lives. Our attention is constantly being solicited all the time. It's true that classical music does make demands on your time, if you want to engage with it seriously. You can't quite as easily throw it on in the background as you can sometimes with a pop song. You're unlikely to hear it in a bar. You're unlikely to hear it in an airport lounge. You have to actually listen.
- 1.20** You have to make a few steps towards it. And, well, that involves time and that involves concentration. How do you justify taking that time out of your life? Well, there's a few things. The first thing is that this will immeasurably broaden your experience of music, and that will enrich you tremendously. I can make that claim without any difficulty whatsoever. If you make the effort to go towards this music, first of all, you'll have the capacity to share things with your children, make more informed choices as to what music you want to have on in the house. It can actually radiate into all corners of your life in an extremely powerful way.

- 1.21** The other thing is that it's absolutely foundational to our culture. Music was once considered to be a science. It was considered to be one of the four main branches of knowledge. From Plato to the Middle Ages, there was this concept called the quadrivium, which meant that if you were to be an educated person, if you were to have a reasonably broad understanding of the world that you were living in, you would be expected, as a matter of course, to know a little bit about arithmetic, geometry, astronomy, and music. It was one of the four branches. And we've lost that now. It's like the only dimension of music that most people interface with today is the entertainment aspect of it.
- 1.22** Music is a very broad art form. It has many functions. So music can function as a form of entertainment. It can also function certainly as a science, as a fine art. But I think too often our experience of it is a little bit limited. So hopefully this course will allow that to broaden your experience somewhat. But basically, for much of its history, much of this period that we're going to be dealing with in this course, music was considered to be a fundamental component of what it meant to be an educated person. And we are in the midst of potentially losing that. So that's something I want to address here.
- 1.23** So this is obviously an individual matter. Not all of these pieces are going to appeal to you necessarily, but I would encourage you to approach this in an open-minded fashion and not to be too concerned about "I like this or I don't like that." But I'm going to encourage you to adopt a slightly different relationship to art and think in terms of, well, let's try to find out what's going on here, and then we can make judgments afterwards.
- 1.24** OK, so today I'm going to be talking about Bach, Johann Sebastian Bach, who comes relatively late in the history of music. If you consider that it stretches back to the year 800, 900, in terms of notated scores, things that we can actually still perform, Bach comes almost 1,000 years after that. So, why am I starting with him? Well, for many reasons, Bach appears to me to be the summit of the pyramid, in terms of just the magnitude of the achievement, the quality of the work, the importance of him as a historic figure. Bach is absolutely central to this musical tradition, and there's a few reasons for that.
- 1.25** So Bach was born in 1685, died in 1750, and it's no exaggeration to say that, in terms of the breadth of his output, the depth, the profundity, the quality, the sheer number of incomprehensible masterpieces that he produced, I would have to situate him pretty much at the top of that pyramid. Now, he did just about everything it's possible to do as a composer, except for opera. And one of the things that I think is so impressive about him is the fact that his music presents us not only with beautiful music to listen to, but it articulates an entire worldview.
- 1.26** In Bach, you get theology. There's a pedagogical dimension to it. He's trying to teach his listeners. He's trying to teach performers how to play better. He's trying to teach composers how to compose better. He's trying to teach you how to hear music. There's

an entertainment component to it as well. It's very beautiful, it's very lively, it's often very rhythmical in its nature. You can just learn an awful lot from Bach and get a very complete picture of what it's like to be a human being. And he also pushed the music of his time, the musical possibilities, the language of his time, farther than just about any other composer that I can possibly think of. So, pretty much every composer who has come afterwards has had to deal with Bach and his legacy, just the quality of his work, the seemingly unimaginable perfection of it.

- 1.27** So before we get into a discussion of specific works of Bach, I have to make a few more definitions. So we're going to start with some basic things. So in classical music and performed music, music that is primarily written in the form of a score, a lot depends on what size of room the piece is being played in. In other words, you have what's called chamber music. And chamber music is typically music written for a small number of players without a conductor. You have maybe between two and maybe eight players working together, and there's no conductor. They're coordinating amongst themselves. And typically, chamber music is played in a smallish room.
- 1.28** The other thing is that, for much of its history, chamber music, the idea was that you don't necessarily play in front of an audience. You're playing for yourself. You're playing for yourself and for your friends. It's basically a private experience. There's also orchestral music. And orchestral music, obviously, is intended for a much larger body of players. There's no strict definition of exactly what constitutes an orchestra, but it can be anywhere from 20 to 200 performers, depending on the piece. It can be an extremely large late-Romantic orchestra with 8 horns, 12 horns, 4 harps, 8 flutes, and so on. Or you can have a much smaller classical or Baroque orchestra.
- 1.29** But basically, orchestra music is considered to be—it's a grand public statement, if you like. This is not music that's meant to be played privately in somebody's private living room or drawing room, but rather it's meant to be played in public. And traditionally, orchestral music tended to be a little bit more broad stylistically, a little bit simpler, perhaps, in its forms and its structures. And it tended to be much more oriented towards a large audience. And of course, it had to be built and it had to be played in much larger halls as well.
- 1.30** So that's still an important consideration today when a composer writes a piece is, well, what's the context? What size of room is it going to be played in? And how many performers do I need to have? So that's an initial distinction I want to make. And remember that in the Baroque and classical era, there weren't really recitals like we have today of chamber music. So you wouldn't necessarily go to a concert and hear somebody play harpsichord or piano music for 90 minutes, as might be the case today. This music, this repertoire, was written for people to play. And it speaks to performers, whereas, orchestral music speaks to an audience.
- 1.31** So nowadays, of course, it's quite different. There are chamber music festivals, and chamber music is actually quite popular, and it's not only intended for individuals to

play for their own enjoyment. And moreover, we've also lost something, because in the 19th century, for example, in a lot of European countries, the educated middle class, as a matter of course, was expected to play an instrument. So you would be expected to play the piano a little bit, or the violin, and to have the capacity to sight-read music and to perform things. And this was something that was broadly practiced by that sector of society. It's not the case anymore. It's not really considered to be absolutely necessary for somebody to learn to play a keyboard instrument, for example.

- 1.32** OK, so let's talk a little bit about Bach's life and the circles in which he moved and his historical context. So one of the things that fascinates me about Bach is his output is just colossal. It's almost incomprehensible, in fact. There was a period in the 1720s where Bach was required to write a cantata every single week. A cantata is a 15- to 30-minute composition in multiple movements. He did this for years on end, just churning out these pieces one after the other. And it's not like there's anything routine about them. Each one is different. Each one is distinctive. Some of them are extraordinarily remarkable pieces on many levels.
- 1.33** And he had the capacity to just sit and work and work and work and work. And that was a pattern that you see not only in his life, but in the life of a lot of the composers we're going to be looking at today. Now, how did he manage to do this? This is a question that musicologists and historians are always trying to comprehend. How did he manage to write so much music, given the fact that he was not only a composer, he was also a performer. In fact, he was mainly known as a performer and an improviser, an organist, during his lifetime.
- 1.34** And in addition to that, he had many, many professional responsibilities. He was responsible for teaching a large number of students, and he had a complicated family life, to say the least. He had 20 children with two wives, and somehow managed to create this extraordinary body of work. Well, here's a bit of a clue. So I've got up on the screen here a couple of diagrams, if you want to have a look. So this shows you the total extent of where Bach spent his professional life. So the map there on the left shows you the various towns that he lived in, in Germany. So he's born in Eisenach, which is a little town in central Germany. He also lived in Leipzig and Weimar.
- 1.35** And all of these cities and towns that he lived in are squished into a tiny, tiny area, a tiny geography of Germany, which he basically never left. So this is somebody who essentially just stayed at home and wrote his entire life, didn't really travel very much. He took on various positions in that region of central Germany that he lived in, but that was basically his entire world. And we know that he made a few trips outside of that area during his life, but only, I think, three or four. He made a trip to Lübeck in northern Germany. This is actually a famous anecdote about Bach.
- 1.36** He was fascinated by this older composer called Dietrich Buxtehude, who was a northern German composer with a Danish name. And he wanted to go and hear Buxtehude play the organ. Problem was that he lived about 600 kilometers from where

he was, something like that. So he went there on foot. He walks there on foot in order to go hear Buxtehude for a few weeks and then comes back, also on foot. So it was a big deal to travel in those days, I suppose, and probably he had to keep an eye on the family finances, so he decided to do it that way.

- 1.37** He made a few trips like this. Towards the end of his life, he also had a very celebrated trip to Potsdam, which is near Berlin. But beyond that, he didn't really leave that area very much at all. So a very circumscribed existence, living in these towns, just basically keeping his head down and writing all the time.
- 1.38** So here's a few other elements about Bach that I want to present, just to orient us a little bit. So up until Bach, Western music was largely dominated by the concept of polyphony. And polyphony basically just means that you have music that's written in multiple individual voices. So you can think of this as, for example, if you're in a choir, you have different people singing. They all have their own little line that they're singing, and you combine them together, and you get what's called polyphony, or a multiplicity of different voices.
- 1.39** The idea is that these different voices are really independent from each other. So they're independent melodically, they're independent rhythmically. But when you superimpose all these different lines, you get a coherence out of that. It makes sense harmonically, it makes sense musically. And so that's called the polyphonic style. So the idea is that it's predicated upon horizontality. It's predicated upon one note after another, all of these different individual melodic lines that you can add together.
- 1.40** That starts to change during Bach's lifetime, certainly, but even slightly before that, around 1600, with the advent of opera and other styles, other genres. And what starts to change is, instead of being focused on this linear counterpoint of one line against another line, you start to have composers thinking more in terms of chords, more in terms of what you might call vertical sonorities, where notes are piled up on top of each other. You have these things called chords, which are two notes or three notes or four notes played simultaneously. So instead of necessarily always thinking in terms of individual horizontal lines, you're thinking more in terms of a succession of chords.
- 1.41** Now, Bach is a little bit of an anachronism, historically, because this obsession with polyphony, with individual lines, individual voices, continued throughout his life. It continued to the end of his life, even though he lived well into the era of the pre-classicists who were composers who were really starting to move towards a much more streamlined form of expression, much more focused on melody, much more focused on simpler textures. So he was writing in a style that was really more associated with the Renaissance than with the time that he was living in, in many respects. Not in all of his works, but certainly in many of them.
- 1.42** So he's not strictly representative of the time that he's living in necessarily, but he's, in a certain sense, looking backwards, but attempting to take this polyphonic ideal and

push it as far as it can possibly go. And in many respects, Bach represents the fullest development of that polyphonic ideal. So in other words, what can you do with a texture like that when you've got all these different multiple voices? How far can you push that? How far can you push the complexity? Also, how many different voices can you pile up on each other and still have a coherent musical result?

- 1.43** So, in a sense, Bach is neither an instigator nor an innovator, really. He didn't really invent a new style. He didn't really invent a new form or a new genre. But what he does is he represents the fullest flowering of the polyphonic style, the old polyphonic style, which is also referred to as the *stile antico*, the antique style, or the old style, of, again, multiple individual voices, as opposed to the new style that was starting to come in during the latter half of his life that was much more focused on individual melody.
- 1.44** So he clearly had an affection for this, this older style, which is in many respects more abstract than what you get in the high classical style, which we'll be looking at a little bit later. So why is it more abstract? Well, for one thing, this older style is notably lacking in contrast, by which I mean that you have events that are heard simultaneously that might be different from each other. You have a distinct melody here, and then another one on top of it, and another on top of it, and they're independent from each other to a degree, even though they work together harmonically.
- 1.45** But what you don't have a lot of are successive sections in a piece that are contrasting with one another for a dramatic effect. In other words, the overall texture of the music tends to be more continuous, it tends to be a little bit smoother, and it tends to have a little bit less contrast in it than what you get in successive periods. So Bach really relied on this. So it's not especially dramatic or full of contrast, but what you do get is an unbelievably beautiful play of all of these different interlocking voices.
- 1.46** The other thing that starts to happen around the time of Bach is that the language of music, the technical aspect of music, if you like, becomes increasingly codified. So in the era that was preceding him, there were a lot of aspects of harmony, of counterpoint, that were not quite as rigid as they later became, let's say, where there wasn't necessarily a predetermined manner of how do you have this chord follow this other chord, how do you superimpose these two lines. There were treatises, there were technical and theoretical works, of course, that explain these things. But the possibilities of the language of music become, in certain respects, more rigidly defined during the time of Bach.
- 1.47** It becomes more codified. We start to have chords being assigned very specific functions, very specific names, that would limit, in certain respects, the number of sonorities that you could have in a piece, the number of different types of chords, and the way that you would be allowed by the practice of the day to combine all these different elements. But nevertheless, the main essence of Bach's music and esthetic that I want to emphasize here is the fact that there's always a very high degree of integration in it. So instead of the extremely dramatic, contrast-filled dialectical forms

that you'll get in the classical era, you have a music where things unfold simultaneously. Everything is braided together.

- 1.48** What I'm going to suggest we do is listen to one of Bach's pieces, and hopefully this will illustrate better than I can what's going on in his music. Now, I would make the claim that Bach's greatest achievements are all in the domain of vocal music. I think that that's where he's at his strongest. Of course, that's not to imply that the chamber music or the solo pieces or the orchestral suites or any of that is in any manner inferior or less interesting. But I think it's really in the vocal repertoire that you see the most remarkable and distinctive achievements of Bach.
- 1.49** So remember I said at the outset that he was in charge of writing a cycle of liturgical pieces to be played on Sundays when he was in Leipzig in the 1720s? So he had to write several hundred cantatas. And this is what we're going to hear an excerpt from. So, a cantata, just to define that, is primarily a vocal composition as opposed to a piece for instruments. And a cantata typically involves multiple different movements. So by movement, we mean a distinct part of a piece that has its own tempo, its own character, its own characteristic rhythm. A cantata can have anywhere from two movements to 15 movements. It all depends on the composer; it depends on what it is that they're trying to do in their piece.
- 1.50** But a typical Bach cantata is approximately 20 minutes long, and it will have an alternation of what are called chorales, where everybody stands up and sings together, and usually in four parts; recitatives, which are more narrative-driven. They push the story forward, and it's a single singer who comes up and speaks in a quasi-sung, quasi-spoken manner, but it's more similar to speech than to song in many respects. Arias, which are in fact formal songs that have melodies and repeating sections and so on, and they're more developed, typically, than the recitatives. So you have all of these different types of musical texture, different movement types that are alternated in a cantata.
- 1.51** So I'm going to play you an excerpt from one of Bach's cantatas. This was written in 1724, and this is one of my very favorite pieces of everything that Bach wrote. It's called *Wir eilen mit schwachen, doch emsigen Schritten*, which translates to "We hurry on weak but anxious footsteps." And let's start by reading the text for this piece. The texts in these pieces tend to be fairly short. There's a lot of repetition of words. There's a lot of repetition of individual lines. But this is a duo for a soprano and alto, with a basso continuo accompaniment. And a basso continuo simply means that there's a bass line to which various chords are assigned, and the bass line can be played by cello, for example, or a bassoon, or whatever instrument is available. And then you also have an organ part that goes along with that.
- 1.52** So here are the words from this cantata. So, "We hurry with weak yet eager steps, O Jesus, O master, to you to help. You faithfully look for the sick and straying. Ah hear, as we raise our voices to pray for help! May your gracious countenance give us joy!" So

remember, I said earlier that there's something abstract about a lot of Bach's music, this polyphonic style, where it's really about these textures, where you have all these voices braided together and where they go, where they're moving. And this piece is a little bit less abstract.

1.53 And in his cantatas and in his passions and oratorios, these great vistas, these great accomplishments in vocal music, first of all, they're mostly sacred works. And secondly, it gives him an opportunity to really push the emotional expression of the day to its absolute limits. So what you'll see in this piece is there's a very infectious and bouncy rhythm that we keep hearing. And the piece is actually rather joyous in its fundamental expressive orientation. So let's have a listen to this. So this is an excerpt from the cantata Jesu, der du meine Seele, and it's called, "We hurry with weak yet eager steps."

1.54 [musical piece]

1.55 So I think that's just such a beautiful piece. The thing is, it's very rhythmic. It's very rhythmic. You have this continuous rhythmic pattern [singing] in the cello part. You could dance to that. You probably wouldn't dance to it, but it's a kind of sublimated dance in this music, which is to say that it's all based on dance patterns, but it's not actually literally meant for dancing. So the movement in the piece comes both from these rhythmic figures that are repeated almost obsessively over the course of five minutes, but also by the way the music moves, the way it's always heading off somewhere new all the time. And so I think that's just such a beautiful piece.

1.56 OK, so I wanted to also play an excerpt from what you could certainly argue is Bach's greatest work of all, which is the St. Matthew Passion. The St. Matthew Passion is a colossal two-and-a-half-hour-long Passion recounting, but it's not just a Passion, it's an oratorio. It's got a quasi-operatic dimension to it. And of course, it tells the story of the St. Matthew Passion. Now, it's not a particularly narrative-driven piece in a strange sense, because the action, so to speak, of the story is constantly being interrupted by sections of the piece that are more descriptive or philosophical in nature, or where the performers are commenting on what we've heard. So it's an extremely long piece. It doesn't have a lot of forward momentum, dramatically speaking. So that's one of the things that would set it apart from a more traditional opera.

1.57 But nevertheless, what it does have is just an absolutely unbelievable expressive depth. I think this is one of the most beautiful things that Bach ever wrote. So what this section is, is called "Erbarme dich," and this is an aria from the, from the St. Matthew Passion. And what it is, is the plea of forgiveness of Apostle Peter for having denied Christ. And so this basically presents us with a musical illustration of an individual tortured by his own conscience, his own capacity for sin, his own capacity for deception also. And so here are the words from "Erbarme dich", which translates to "Have mercy on me."

- 1.58** "Have mercy, my God, for the sake of my tears. Look here, heart and eyes weep bitterly before you. Have mercy, have mercy!" So Bach turns this into an absolutely exquisite composition for alto, which is the medium-low female voice. It's the lowest of the female voice types. And there's also a violin part that runs through the entire thing. The violin is playing a solo part, which is referred to as an obligato. And the obligato simply means that it's also an important solo part in addition to the solo voice, and it weaves around what the singer is doing. And there's a repeated figure that keeps returning in the violin part. So we have obligato violin, voice, alto voice, and figured bass in this piece, or basso continuo. So here's "Erbarne dich" from the St. Matthew Passion.
- 1.59** In both of these pieces that we've just heard, there's certainly a narrative dimension. There's also an illustrative dimension. He's attempting to illustrate an emotional state or a particular type of movement. In the case of the cantata extract that we heard, the idea of hurried footsteps, which is present throughout the entire piece. And in this one, it's obviously a lament. You can very palpably feel this idea of bitter weeping, bitter tears, in this composition. But a lot of Bach's music is extremely abstract in the sense that it doesn't really tell any kind of explicit story. It doesn't really mean anything in a sense outside of itself, outside of the patterns that are located within the work itself.
- 1.60** And what I want to do now is to play for you an excerpt of one of Bach's certainly most abstract compositions, but really one of the most abstract compositions in the entire Western musical canon, which is a piece that he wrote in the last decade of his life called The Art of Fugue. So first I have to define what that title means. So the Art of Fugue, so a fugue is a musical composition in a polyphonic or contrapuntal style in which you have multiple different voices that all begin with the same motif, the same fugue subject.
- 1.61** And the piece starts with successive entries of these different voices. So you hear a first voice presenting the subject or the little melody that starts the fugue, and then a second voice that answers it, a fifth higher, at the dominant, typically. And then you have a third voice, and then a fourth voice. They all enter successively. And then there's a very abstract conversation between these four voices in the case of this fugue. Not all fugues are four-voice fugues, but this one is.
- 1.62** So the Art of Fugue is a project that Bach undertook, starting in 1742, and I believe it took him to about 1746, maybe a little bit earlier than 1742. But anyway, he worked on it in the last decade of his life. And this was clearly Bach's attempt to summarize the fullest extent of his knowledge of his technique, of his erudition as a musician, and also to see how far he could push all of these incredibly sophisticated compositional techniques that he'd been perfecting over the course of his lifetime.
- 1.63** So in a sense, it's a massive encyclopedia of everything that can be done, combining tones together in different ways, combining multiple themes and subjects together. You can flip them upside down. You can combine them backwards and forwards. You can have one voice that's moving at twice the speed or half the speed of another voice.

It's extraordinarily complex from a technical perspective because he's showing everything that you can do.

- 1.64** And also, Bach had a capacity that I think no other composer has had to quite the same extent, which was that he had an almost computer-like brain. He was able to take any musical subject, theme, rhythm, whatever it was, and imagine, seemingly instantaneously, all of the potential ramifications of that idea, all the way that you could combine it with another theme, all of the ways that you could alter it. It was absolutely extraordinary.
- 1.65** Not only that, not only could he do it in a composition, but he could improvise it at the organ. So Bach actually had the capacity to sit at the keyboard, and if you were to give him a subject, like a short melody, he would then be able to improvise an entire polyphonic composition on the spot in four voices or more in some instances, which defies belief. There are people nowadays who can approximate things like that, but certainly not to the same degree of just absolutely extraordinary mastery that Bach had.
- 1.66** So this is the second, what's called contrapunctus, or the second contrapuntal piece from the Art of the Fugue. And this piece is one I particularly enjoy. It's written in a French-style dotted rhythm, which is to say that rather than an equal rhythm throughout the entire piece, you have a dotted rhythm, which sounds like this [rhythm]. So it's this kind of galloping rhythm. And the other thing I want to just briefly mention here is that although the Art of Fugue is often considered to be the summit of abstraction and erudition and complexity in Bach's output, nevertheless, like the pieces that we heard earlier, the entire thing is based on dance rhythms. So there's no getting away from that.
- 1.67** And there aren't hundreds and hundreds of dance patterns in these pieces, in the pieces of the Baroque and the classical era. There's a relatively limited number of types of rhythms. There are binary and ternary rhythms, rhythms in two beats, rhythms in three beats; there are rhythms in dotted rhythms; there are fast and slow rhythms; but there's a relatively limited repertory of possible rhythmic figures that all of this music is fundamentally predicated upon. So here's the second movement of Bach's massively impressive achievement towards the end of his life, the Art of Fugue.
- 1.68** And this, by the way, another point I'd like to make about this piece before we hear it is that I mentioned that it's very abstract. Well, it's also abstract in the sense that it isn't explicitly stated in the score how this piece is meant to be performed. The score consists of four voices, four staves with different lines on them, and it can be played on organ, it can be played on harpsichord, it can be played, it can be sung by a choir, it can be played on four saxophones, it can be played on four banjos. It doesn't matter, really, in a sense, because the music is not dependent on any instrumental gesture. You can think of it as a very abstract play of different lines against one another. And the

particular excerpt that we're about to hear is performed on a piano. But of course, you can play it on anything. So here it is.

- 1.69** So those are three excerpts from the vast output of Johann Sebastian Bach. Of course, there are many, many other pieces to discover. To get a decent picture of any of these composers, you have to hear a lot more than this, but this is at least a good starting point. The final thing I'll say about this excerpt that we just heard, the Art of Fugue, is that in a lot of Bach's music, even though he may be writing for an instrument, he's always thinking about voices, ultimately, about the human voice. And there are four main human voice types that you see in his music, in the way he's thinking about register, where you place a line. There's the soprano, alto, tenor, and bass. And a lot of his music is articulated, really, in those different registers— a high female voice, a medium female voice, a high male voice, and a low male voice.
- 1.70** And even though he might be writing for recorder or flute or harpsichord or whatever, the pieces are typically set up in such a manner that they could, in fact, be sung. They fit within those vocal ranges a lot of the time. So the Art of the Fugue is an example of that. It doesn't really stray too far outside of the range of the different human voice types. So what you have is this braiding together of all these individual lines. And I find it so fascinating to listen to these pieces because every time you hear them, it's a little bit different. Your experience of listening to it is different because we can't really follow four independent voices simultaneously and think, OK, here's what the alto is doing, here's what the tenor is doing, and so on.
- 1.71** What we hear is a globality, and sometimes our attention will be drawn towards, oh, what's happening in the soprano? Or, what's happening in this middle voice here, what's happening in the bass? And we drift from line to line as we're listening. And so you can listen to these pieces hundreds of times and have hundreds of different experiences because they have so many dimensions to them. There's so much going on simultaneously. And I think that's one of the tremendous sources of richness in Bach's music.
- 1.72** And in fact, you could take a piece like that and strip away three of the voices. Just listen to the tenor. Just listen to the bass line. And that would be a complete piece in and of itself, strangely enough. But in fact, here we have four quite beautiful individual lines, all working together and all creating this coherent design. So I'm going to stop there for Bach. If there are any questions about anything I've said so far, don't hesitate. We've got a lot to cover in the course, but there will be time for questions at the end of every individual lecture. So any questions about this so far? Yes.
- 1.73** You talked about having to take steps towards the music to appreciate it. And then with the vocal pieces, you gave the translations of the German. So do you think it's necessary to fully appreciate the music to understand the German or the language that the voice is in?

- 1.74** That's a really important point. So when I talk about having to take steps towards the music, the fact is that we no longer live in—none of us lives in Leipzig in 1724. So there's already a geographical and a language barrier in that sense, not to mention the cultural aspect and the fact that a lot of the conventions that were operative in this time are no longer operative for us. So there are certain things that won't be self-evident simply from hearing the music.
- 1.75** Of course, if you were alive at that time, then a lot of those questions simply would not have been there. You would have intuitively and immediately understood these things. You would have understood the words. You would have understood the context within which the piece was being played. So we no longer have the context. We have the work, and we can listen to the work and appreciate it on its autonomous esthetic terms. And we can say, "Oh, I like this, or this is beautiful." But yes, if you want to understand what the piece is doing, then I think it is necessary to at least read the text, read a translation of the text, and try to understand it on that level.
- 1.76** I think you can certainly enjoy and appreciate a piece by Bach or any other classical composer without necessarily doing that, but you can go a lot farther if you try to understand what was this written for, what is this attempting to tell us, what did the words mean, what is the broader context of the story of the piece. And I recognize that that can be daunting. So for example, in my case, I've always had a bit of a hard time listening to operas for the first time in an opera house. The reason for that is, when you go to hear an opera, it's usually in a foreign language. There aren't actually tons of English-language operas, except for Benjamin Britten, and a few other composers have written them. But by and large, you're hearing something in Italian or German or French, sometimes other languages as well.
- 1.77** So you're not going to understand the words. If you haven't read the story beforehand, you're not going to know what the story is either. And there's just a lot happening all at once. An opera can be three hours long or four hours long. It can be an enormously complicated plot. There's an orchestra in the pit. There's complicated music going on. There's singing. There's a text that you have to follow. It's very, very difficult to take all of that in simultaneously. So it's not that the composers were attempting to produce things that require extra work on the part of the audience to listen to. It's a simple fact that these pieces, in many instances, were written hundreds of years ago. We don't speak the language. We don't know all of the conventions that they are working within.
- 1.78** In contrast, if you listen to a contemporary pop song, the barrier for understanding is extremely low. That's the whole point. The whole point is that anybody can hear a pop song and intuitively understand everything. There are extremely few demands made upon your comprehension. So a typical pop song will take things that are already familiar—so rhythmic patterns that are familiar, chord patterns that are familiar, a narrative structure that is familiar as well, words that are familiar—and put a slight

twist of novelty on it. Slightly different sound, a slightly different performance style, maybe a slight twist to the narrative. But basically, you can grasp it on a first hearing.

1.79 And that's because we're immersed in this culture and we know all of these things intuitively. But if you were to take a contemporary pop song, bring it into the future 200 years from now, and play it to somebody in a completely different culture, I wouldn't necessarily assume that they would understand it or that they would be able to grasp the narrative or the language or any of those things. So, it's simply a question of your vantage point. How much context you have? If you have very little context, then, of course, it's going to be a little bit more difficult, and you have to maybe make some steps towards the piece. But it's not like you have to spend hours and hours. Just simply reading the text, maybe reading a program note, will usually provide enough context to get started.

1.80 Is it typical for a lament to be written for a woman's voice? Yes, that's the question.

1.81 No, not necessarily. And also it's worth pointing out that some of these pieces can be played or sung with different voice types. So there are many recordings of this piece, for example, that are song by a tenor or a countertenor, so a male voice. In fact, the character who is singing at that point in the story is, in fact, the Apostle Peter. So it's illustrating the experience of a male through a female voice. But no, not necessarily, no. There are many "lamentosos" movements featuring male voices. It's not particularly associated with one or another of the voice types.

Lecture 2: Joseph Haydn

At a glance — Joseph Haydn.

- 2.1 In my Bach lecture, we talked about the fact that Bach was immensely productive. He composed hundreds and hundreds of pieces, some of absolutely colossal dimensions like the St. Matthew Passion. He actually wrote two Passion cycles, in addition to hundreds of cantatas, hundreds of keyboard works. It's an immense output. So one of the questions that I want to keep returning to in these lectures is, how exactly did they do that?
- 2.2 Well, there are two main components to it. So one is that they had to because if you were a professional composer in this time and you were engaged in the services of a nobleman or of a court of some kind, then that was your job. You were in charge of providing music for the court or for the church or whoever it was that you were working for.
- 2.3 The other is that they were able to do that. Why were they able to do it? Well, because we had these forms and genres that were very powerful frameworks that existed during this time. So that is to say that if a composer was starting a new piece, they weren't just starting from nothing. They weren't starting from, well, okay, I have to dream something up here. No, there were forms that existed that were a framework that you could slot your ideas into.
- 2.4 If you were writing a sonata or if you were writing a minuet or a jig or something like that, then there was already a rhythmic concept that existed. There was a formal concept that existed. You knew that the piece would be in two sections or in three sections. You knew approximately what the modulatory scheme of the piece would be, which is to say you would start on this key, and then maybe you would move towards this other key, and then you'd go back to the original key at the end.
- 2.5 And all of these things were outsourced to the larger culture, which is to say the composer didn't actually have to invent all of that when he was writing. So you would already have a form, you would already have a genre, you were writing a symphony or a sonata or an opera or whatever. And all of these genres have different conventions attached to them. So what you can do is, you don't have to reinvent the wheel every time you sit down to write. These are forms that can be iterated.
- 2.6 You can write a symphony, you can write 10 symphonies, you can write 100 symphonies, and they might all approximately follow the same basic pattern, which is not to say that there are no instances of individual invention and decision making and flights of fancy and sparks of genius. Of course, there's all of that in those pieces. But the composer is freed up in a certain sense by not having to reinvent everything every time he sits down to write a piece.

- 2.7 And it's the case in contemporary culture with things like genre fiction, for example. If you're writing a thriller or a mystery or a romance novel or whatever it is—or writing a rom-com if you're a screenwriter in Hollywood, then there are conventions associated with all of these genres. You don't have to sit there and think, "how am I going to articulate this story? How many sections should I have?" And so on. No, it follows a predictable arc.
- 2.8 If it's a movie, for example, you start with presenting some characters, you present a situation, then you present a problem, then the problem has to get resolved, and then there's an ending section where presumably everything goes well if it's a rom-com or it goes badly if it's a thriller, perhaps, or a horror film or something like that. But anyway, there's a predictable arc to it. And that's the case with these pieces as well. So composers were able to iterate these forms and write many, many multiple instances of these types of pieces.
- 2.9 Now, perhaps nowhere is that so extremely the case as in the output of Joseph Haydn. So not only did he have to write a lot of music due to his employment situation, which we're going to look at in detail because it's quite interesting, but also he was able to because the state of the musical language within which he was working allowed for it. There were very, very strong conventions that made it so that he could focus on inventing things spontaneously within that very, very strong framework.
- 2.10 If you don't have that framework, which was the case for the romantics, by the way, as you get into the 19th century and beyond, composers are relying a lot less on set forms and on established conventions and genres. They're starting to write pieces that can't really be iterated, ideas that you can't really do more than once. And that progresses as you move through music history, where the forms get more and more unique, the pieces get more and more individual.
- 2.11 But it's not the case in the classical era, not in the same manner. We're going to talk now about Joseph Haydn, who was an Austrian composer, and he had a relatively long lifespan for someone of that day. He lived to be 78 years old. And he was born in 1732 in Rohrau, which is in east, that is now lies in Eastern Austria, and died in Vienna in 1809. So in common with Bach, he lived his entire life in a very restricted geographical region, and was absolutely compulsively productive. It's very difficult for a listener today to get a sense of Haydn's achievement as a composer because there's just so much of it.
- 2.12 You would need an entire lifetime to sit down and listen to all of Haydn's music. And a lot of it is extraordinarily high in quality, not all of it. And we're going to talk about some of the peaks and valleys of his output, but there's a lot of wonderful music, and you could just sit down and listen for hours and hours and hours to his output. But for most audiences, if you've heard any Haydn, you've probably only heard a tiny, tiny fragment of his output, maybe two or three pieces at most out of the hundreds and hundreds that he wrote.

- 2.13** So Haydn was clearly compulsively productive, obsessed with regularity, regular work habits, craftsmanship, working out his ideas thoroughly. And this is another instance, like Bach, of someone who basically kept their head down and spent their entire life working from an early age all the way up to the end of his life. He was consistently productive. The last few years of Haydn's life, he suffered from some health issues and was not quite so productive in the last five years of his life, more or less stopped writing. But other than that, when he was in good health, he was writing all the time.
- 2.14** There are other composers who have even larger outputs. The Baroque composer, Telemann, for example, wrote 6,000 pieces in his lifetime. He wrote so many pieces that, I think somebody worked out that you would have to basically write a piece every two and a half days, something like that, from you were six years old to the time you were 80 years old in order to match that output. I mean, it's absolutely mind boggling. But again, you can do that, provided that you have a strong framework and context within which you're working. If you don't have that, if you have to invent everything every time you sit down to produce a work of art, then your output will be much, much smaller.
- 2.15** So Haydn left us 107 symphonies, 68 string quartets, 41 piano trios, 13 operas. At the end of his life, he wrote two massive oratorios. He wrote, *Die Jahreszeiten*, *The Seasons*, and *Die Schöpfung*, *The Creation*, which are two—I think they're two and a half hours long each—massive, massive pieces. Sixty-two keyboard sonatas, hundreds and hundreds of other chamber music compositions, and the list goes on and on and on.
- 2.16** And the general consensus, critically speaking, is that his greatest works are to be found in his chamber music. That's where he's writing things that are the most interesting, the most compelling, the most individual also, and the most quirky—the things where his individual genius really manifests itself.
- 2.17** He's not very strong in operas. He's not particularly strong in concertos. Those are not really forms that he was particularly distinguished in. Today, his 13 operas, which are huge pieces, are very rarely performed. They've more or less been forgotten. They're not a big part of the repertory anymore. Of the 107 symphonies, there are maybe half a dozen or so, maybe you could push that maybe a little bit to a dozen, that are still performed today on a regular basis, which are indisputably great works, the best of them.
- 2.18** But really, the crown jewel of his output, I think, are his 68 string quartets. That's 68. It's also a very large number. Not all of them are at the same level. There are some that are more distinguished than others, but by and large, it's consistently very high in quality, I would say—his piano trios also.
- 2.19** I've got a box at home of the complete Haydn recordings. There's a company called Brilliant Classics that started marketing these things. You get all of Mozart in a box. It's

like 180 CDs. You get Haydn; it's 200 CDs and so on. It's not a good way to approach the works of these composers. First of all, nobody's going to listen to 200 CDs. Secondly, it's better to choose to begin with a few representative works and see what you think. Then if you want to, you can branch out from there.

- 2.20 It's worth also remembering that of this enormous, voluminous output, a lot of this work was not necessarily intended to remain in the repertory or to be played multiple times. The composers weren't always thinking about that. They weren't always thinking about posterity. They were in a situation where they had to produce. It was their job.
- 2.21 For example, if the count or the prince that you were working for needed music for a ball, then you would go and hastily write some dance music. You'd write a divertimento, or you'd write a minuet, or a cassation, in the case of Mozart, or all of these different dance genres within which these composers were working. But you wouldn't expect that that piece would last forever or that it would be played hundreds of times. You were writing music for a specific occasion. You have to remember that a lot of these things were not necessarily intended to form any kind of repertoire. In fact, the concept of an ongoing repertory didn't really exist at that time.
- 2.22 Music was predicated on the idea that you would have a continuous flow of new pieces. But you didn't necessarily bother with things that had been written 50 years ago or 100 years ago. If you went to a concert, an orchestral concert, for example, or if you went to hear an opera, it was usually a new opera. Today, things have shifted, obviously. Today, we have essentially a museum culture where we venerate the works of the past, although increasingly we're actually not doing that. But by and large, if you go and hear an orchestral concert or an opera, then it's something from the past. It'll be a few hundred years old, increasingly. But that was not the case during the classical Europe.
- 2.23 Okay, so Haydn, it's very difficult to say too much about his life because it wasn't terribly interesting. It's the same with Bach. It's like, well, there are biographies of Bach, but there's not that much to say. I mean, he's a guy who sat at a desk his entire life and wrote. So there weren't an enormous number of really conspicuous interesting events in the course of his life. It's the same with Haydn.
- 2.24 Haydn spent nearly his entire career in the service of a single prince. So he was hired when he was 28 or 29 years old to be the Vice-Kapellmeister, in other words, the second highest in command of music at Esterházy Castle, which lies in Eastern Austria, about 12 miles from the border with Hungary. So he entered the employment of one of the most powerful, noble families in that region at the time, which were the Esterházys. And you going to be hearing this name a few times because they were really very closely bound up with a lot of the music that was written during the classical era.
- 2.25 So Haydn managed to get this position as Vice-Kapellmeister. And the terms of his employment, which we're going to have a look at, are extremely interesting because it

explains his life trajectory, such as it was, and also the extent of his output. The important thing to understand is that at this time, the era before Beethoven, composers and artists, generally—they were not independent artists who were involved in self-expression, the way we think of it today.

- 2.26** This is the default mode of how we think about artists. The artist is an individual who is typically going against conventions in some manner or another, doing something that other people aren't doing, presenting something new to the audience, something novel, and they don't quite fit into societal norms. This is the romantic notion of the artist that we've inherited from the 19th century, and this is still basically how we think of artists today. In the 18th century, and earlier, the artist was really more of an artisan, more of a craftsperson, and in the case of Haydn, a servant, effectively.
- 2.27** So Haydn was in charge of providing a service in this princely household. So what does that mean exactly? Well, let's have a look at his employment contract and see what exactly he had to do. He was subject to the whims of the prince that he was working for. So if the prince says, you have to do this, then you have to do it. And in the case of Prince Paul-Anton Esterházy, he was very determined that Haydn should remain in this castle almost all of the time. Occasionally, he was allowed to accompany the prince to Vienna, which is where everything was happening. Musically, it's where all the artists were living, that were doing things that Haydn was interested in. But for the most part, he was more or less obligated to stay in the countryside, in this castle, by himself working his entire life. He did that for 40 years.
- 2.28** So he led a luxurious but very monotonous life at this castle, which lies outside of a town called Eisenstadt in Eastern Austria, and just worked obsessively. So here's Haydn's contract—or excerpts from the contract that he had to sign when he entered the employment of the Prince Esterházy. So this document is from 1761. "This day and year, as indicated at the end of this document, Joseph Haydn, born in Rohrau in Austria, is taken in and appointed Vice-Kapellmeister in the service of his Serene Highness, Paul Anton, Prince of the Holy Roman Empire, Right Ruler of Esterházy and Galanta, etc., etc., etc., according to the following terms.
- 2.29** Joseph Haydn will be received and treated as a house staff member, and his Serene Highness graciously places confidence in his belief that Haydn will conduct himself in a fitting manner: be mild, lenient, dignified, and composed with the musicians, and not treat them in a brutal fashion. When the orchestra is called upon to perform, the Vice-Kapellmeister, as all subordinates, minutes will appear in livery. So he had to wear the livery of the castle, just as any servant would have had to do. So there was no functional difference between Haydn, this great artist, and a servant. And this pertains not only to Joseph Haydn, but to all members that they appear in white stockings and white shirt with either pigtail or tie wig and thoroughly powdered." I love that part. Can you imagine an employment contract that stipulates that you must be thoroughly powdered all the time?

- 2.30** "Because the Vice-Kapellmeister must set an example for the other musicians, he will conduct himself in an exemplary fashion. Sid Joseph Haydn will refrain from all unnecessary familiarity and common association when eating in drinking and conversing, and be mindful of his position so as to encourage a harmonious relationship among his subordinates, keeping in mind how distasteful the consequences of any discord would be to his Lord."
- 2.31** Four—there are 13 points in this contract. I'm not going to read them all. This is the last one. "The Vice-Kapellmeister will be bound to compose such music as his Serene Highness shall command, and not let such compositions be communicated to any other party, much less be copied, but they shall remain for his use only and his rightful ownership, and he shall not, without permission or knowledge, compose for any other person. Joseph Haydn will, daily, whether in Vienna or elsewhere in his territories, appear both morning and afternoon at the princely antechamber to inquire whether His Highness wishes a concert to be given.
- 2.32** If he be so commanded, he will notify the other musicians and be attentive to be sure that not only he, but the other musicians as well appear at the stipulated time. To assure proper attendance, he will make note of those who are tardy or who fail to appear entirely." So again, he's totally subject to whatever the prince asks him to do. He has to appear in front of his bedroom every morning and ask, "What do you need me to do? What music do you need for tonight?" "If any dispute or cause for complaint arises among the musicians, the Vice-Kapellmeister will try to resolve such matters that his Serene Highness not be vexed with such trifling bagatelles." God forbid. ""For board, Joseph Haydn may eat at the staff table or rreceive compensation of a half gulden per diem expense." So he may eat at the staff table. ""Finally, this contract signed with said Vice-Kapellmeister on first of May 1761, shall bbe in effect for at least three years. And if said Joseph Haydn shall determine to try his fortunes eelsewhere, he will provide His Highness with half a year's notice, that is, at the beginning of the third quarter of the year."
- 2.33** This is a form of indentured servitude, effectively. So in other words, if he decides that he's having a miserable time and he wants to leave, he has to give half a year's notice. But the Prince, of course, can dismiss him at any time for any reason whatsoever. So would you sign this contract? Well, that was the deal. That was the deal. And in exchange for this— basically abdication of any freedom that he might have wanted to have— in exchange for that, he has this luxurious stable environment within which to work. So hence this colossal productivity. Everything was taken care of. He had no material concerns, living in a palace, basically. So that's the deal.
- 2.34** But nevertheless, he did leave us an absolutely colossal number of very distinctive pieces. And not only that, Haydn is credited really with—he's credited with not exactly defining the high classical style, but certainly pushing it to a farther degree of perfection than anybody else had done, through the breadth of his output, through his

ceaseless, tireless work, his efforts to always push his art to a higher degree of perfection.

- 2.35** He's often described as having effectively invented the genres that we most associate with classical music. So the symphony, the string quartet, the sonata, and so on. It's not really true. Haydn didn't invent any of these things. There were vestiges of these forms that existed already, that were being practiced in various ways. But he brought them to a higher degree of sophistication, certainly, and he also popularized them, notably the string quartet. So he's really the first composer to write these very ambitious cycles of string quartets.
- 2.36** So all of these forms have their origins in earlier periods of musical history. The string quartet, the basic idea of the string quartet is that you have four equal instruments, four performers, that are having a conversation. There's something intimate about it. You can play a string quartet in a small room, and it's conversational, and it's lively, and you can get into wonderful subtleties of expression in chamber music because there's only a small number of players. There's no conductor. You don't have to worry about coordinating everybody because there's only four people.
- 2.37** In that situation in chamber music, in the classical era, you can have what's called rubato, which is where you're not sticking strictly to a metronomic beat all the time, [musical beat sound] like that. You can be very expressive with the tempo. You can slow it up, you can slow it down, you can speed it up, you can push the beats this way and that. You can have very, very fluid rhythms. You can change the music at your will based on the expression of the moment. You can take a little longer with this phrase or you can speed up this phrase. The tempo can be a little bit faster, a little bit slower. You can have all of these little subtleties, these little expressive inflections in the music.
- 2.38** In an orchestra piece at this time, that wasn't the case. If you're writing a symphony, they didn't have these virtuoso conductors that we have today, this idea of the conductor as this artist in their own right who's shaping the music and phrasing it and so on. In those days, you would just give a tempo and the piece would start and you'd go [sound of musical beat]. It was much more—symphonies tended to be performed in a much more rigid way rhythmically speaking, and much more, almost mechanical in a sense. Whereas in chamber music, you could really get into the subtleties of expression. That's really where Haydn is at his strongest.
- 2.39** What he does is he takes these genres that already existed in some manner or another, and he streamlines them, and he makes them more powerful, and he also codifies them to a degree. What does the string quartet come out of? Well, the basic idea of the string quartet, again, as I mentioned earlier, it's a conversation between four people. The idea is you have independent lines.
- 2.40** That is actually a very important point because in the Baroque era, for example, did not typically have an independent bass line. You had a basso continuo, which I described

earlier, a continuous bass, which was a bass line, but it was also a harmonized bass line. So the bass would be played by a low instrument, plus a polyphonic instrument that could play chords. Basically, the bass line in a Bach piece or a Handel piece would determine the harmony, and then it would be immediately harmonized by an instrument playing together with it.

- 2.41** But you didn't have just a completely independent bass line most of the time. In the high classical era, this idea of having accompanimental instruments like an organ or a harpsichord, playing chords that go along with this bass line, that disappears. You have a much more simplified texture in many respects. The bass is an independent instrument, and you have these textures that are a lot more transparent, a lot lighter in many instances. You don't have four different independent melodies all going on simultaneously in a piece. Typically, you have a much more streamlined texture in which the top voice, the soprano or the main melodic line in the piece, is the most important. That's the thing that you focus on.
- 2.42** And then you have what are called accompanimental figures or accompanimental parts in the piece that support what's going on in the melodic line. Now, that's a bit of a caricature. I have to immediately qualify that by pointing out that, of course, there's still the polyphonic textures in the music of Haydn. Haydn and Mozart and Beethoven all wrote fugues. They all wrote polyphonic music. But by and large, that older style, the *stile antico*, the antique style that I described in my lecture on Bach, starting to fall by the wayside in favor of something that's much lighter, it's more entertaining, it's easier to listen to in a sense, and it's predicated fundamentally on melody.
- 2.43** So this was practiced in a way during the Baroque in a form called the trio sonata. And the trio sonata is a composition for two melody instruments, whatever it was: it could be two flutes, two violins, it could be flute and oboe, plus basso continuo, plus a bass instrument accompanied by a polyphonic instrument. So the idea is you have these two independent melodic instruments that are supported by an accompaniment. That gradually morphs into this idea of the string quartet. And in both instances, whether it's a trio sonata or a string quartet, we're dealing with abstract instrumental music.
- 2.44** There's no voice line. There's no story being told. There's no narrative dimension, at least not an explicit one. And the music unfolds in a particular characteristic style based mainly on the rhythm and what type of rhythmic figure is being played. Is it a fast movement? Is it a slow movement? Is it meant for dancing? Is it more of a singing thing? Is it very slow, etc.? So the basic tempo and character of the music will give the composer a framework within which to work. But ultimately, these are relatively abstract forms. And this, again, this is where Haydn is at his strongest.
- 2.45** He's not very gifted for drama. He's not very gifted for narrative. He's at his best when he's dealing with what you might call the abstract potential of music as such. So given this language, given these scales, these forms, these genres, these harmonic

procedures that we have, how can we arrange these elements in the most pleasing manner, in the most profound manner, in the most accomplished manner?

- 2.46** So we talked about Haydn's terms of employment. We talked about the pieces he was writing, and also about his position. Another thing I want to mention here is that the gap between the death of Bach and the first mature works of Haydn is about 10 years. So Bach dies in 1750. The first really representative works of Haydn date from about 1760, thereabouts. That's not very long, 10 years. But there's a tremendous stylistic gap between these two figures.
- 2.47** Now, part of that is explained by the fact that Bach, once again, was a bit of an anachronism. He was writing, by the end of his life, in a style that was thoroughly out of date, that was no longer things that younger musicians were interested in. But nevertheless, there was a very profound shift in attitude and in style between Bach and Haydn.
- 2.48** So again, the shift really is as follows: As I mentioned, the music becomes streamlined, simplified, more focused on melody. But there's another thing. Remember that in the Art of the Fugue excerpt that I played, four independent lines going on simultaneously. So when that's the case, the contrast that you can have in the piece is always braided together. You might have, think of it this way. It's like two people are having a conversation, and maybe person A thinks one thing and person B thinks another thing, but they're talking and they're having an integrated conversation about these things.
- 2.49** In Bach, you're hearing everything simultaneously. You might be hearing two independent lines, but you're hearing them at the same time. By and large, if you follow the progression of a Bach fugue, or really just about any of his pieces, you're not going to hear a great deal of contrast. You're not going to hear a great deal of sections starting and stopping, of changes in tempo, changes in character, changes in dynamics, how loud or soft it is. Once the basic texture of the piece is established, it just keeps going.
- 2.50** What starts to change in the high classical the style, the style of Haydn and Mozart, is that the music becomes much more charged with oppositions, with contrasts, and with a dialectical approach to form. So what does that mean exactly? Well, Instead of having things unfolding simultaneously, you have things one after another that contrast with each other.
- 2.51** So you might have a melodic idea that has a particular character, and you have a second melodic idea that has a contrasting character, and then they duke it out over the course of the piece. So there's a dialectical relationship. There's an oppositional relationship between ideas that contrast with each other in the piece. And partly what that comes from is the encroachment of opera and other theatrical genres into the domain of instrumental music.

- 2.52** Opera becomes a tremendously popular form. Opera, of course, is narrative by its very nature and dramatic and full of contrast. That then starts to spill over into the realm of abstract instrumental music. In a sense, that was the task of Haydn and Mozart in different ways to take these instrumental forms and genres, the symphony, the string quartet, and so on, the concerto, and infuse them with this dramatic sensibility coming from opera. So this music is full of contrast, full of dynamic movement, full of opposition. It's very dramatic, and it also unfolds with one idea after another that might be quite different from each other.
- 2.53** Okay, so that's the dialectical principle, and that is nowhere better encapsulated than in the concept of the sonata. So just to briefly recapitulate, and I do talk about the sonata in a little bit more detail in my previous course, but the sonata was by far the dominant mode of imagining a piece of music in the classical era. So the basic essence of sonata form is that you have an opposition between, usually two themes, but not always. Sometimes it's two harmonic regions. It could be an opposition between this chord on that cord.
- 2.54** And you have an expository section, an exposition, in which all the main materials of the piece are laid out. So it's like, okay, here's our first idea. Here's our second idea that contrasts with the first idea, Then you have a middle section called a development in which these different ideas are combined and taken through a whole series of different events in the piece. And then you have a recapitulation at the end, which summarizes everything that we've just heard and synthesizes the oppositions that we had heard initially in the first part of the piece. So this is a dialectical form.
- 2.55** So we have ideas that are different from each other. We lay out those differences. We show all these different characters that are operative in the piece. You can think of them almost as like operatic archetypes or different character archetypes that are present in the piece. Then we mix them together. We create situations in which they have to interact and they change each other. So there's a real dialectical principle. And then at the end, those oppositions are resolved. They're synthesized into something stable and cohesive at the end. So that's the principle that underlines the music of the classical era.
- 2.56** So, consequently, one of the big differences between Baroque and Classical music is that the Baroque piece will tend to not have a great deal of contrast in it. It'll be very continuous rhythmically, very continuous in terms of its texture, whereas Classical music tends to have what you might call a much greater dynamic range. The other thing that starts to change in this era is the invention of soft and loud. You might think, well, that's obvious. But there was a group of composers and orchestra in a town called Mannheim in Germany that invented the so-called Mannheim School, which was a dramatic broadening of the expressive range of music.
- 2.57** You could have a crescendo where the music gradually gets louder, a diminuendo where it gradually gets softer. You can have it gradually speed up, which is an

accelerando, or you can have it gradually slow down, which is a rallentando, and all kinds of other expressive effects like that. Basically, the music is getting more dramatic, it's getting more oppositional, charged with contrast. So I've laid out some of the basic stylistic things that you need to know about the classical era.

- 2.58** I want to talk a little bit more about how Haydn actually went about doing his work, because it's something that for me, as an active composer, I'm always interested in. I'm always fascinated by how artists spend their time and how they do what they do. So luckily for us, there's a manuscript in Salzburg that lays out in detail how Haydn actually spent his life. So this is what his daily routine consisted of.
- 2.59** "So in summer, he always got up at half past six. His first task was to shave, which he did himself until he was 73. After shaving, he dressed completely. If a pupil was there while he dressed, he made him play over his lesson on the piano. Mistakes were immediately corrected, instruction drawn from them, and a new example given. An hour and a half were spent at this.
- 2.60** At eight o'clock precisely, breakfast was on the table. Immediately afterwards, as he would sit down at the piano and improvise, sketching out what he intended to compose, and this task occupied him till half past twelve. Then he received or made visits or took a walk until half past one. From two to three, he dined, and afterwards either did small domestic tasks or went back to his music.
- 2.61** Then he took the morning sketches and scored them, which took him from three to four o'clock. Usually, he went out at about eight o'clock, but came home at nine and began to orchestrate, unless he took a book and read until 10:00. At 10:00, he supped on bread and wine. He had a rule to take no other evening meal but bread and wine, a rule which he only broke from time to time when he was invited out. At table, he loved people to joke and be in good humor. At half past 11:00, he went to bed. In old age, even later. In winter, this schedule did not vary greatly.
- 2.62** He got up half an hour later, and the rest of the day followed as in summer. In his extreme old age, that is during his last five or six years, weakness and illness upset this timetable. This once active man could no longer work, and And at this time, he also took a half hour's siesta." So there you go. Constant, rigorous, rigid routine and productivity, and the fact that he was able to sustain that over his entire working life is, I think, pretty phenomenal. So we've laid out the fact that there's quite a significant gulf between the style of Bach, particularly the late works of Bach, like the The Art of the Fugue or The Musical Offering, which the very abstract works that he wrote towards the end of his life, and the first mature works of Haydn. We've talked about the advent of the Mannheim School, the invention of dynamics, all these different orchestral techniques that were developed by the Court Orchestra of Mannheim in the second part of the 18th century.

- 2.63** There's one other thing before we get to the actual music of Haydn, which we're going to be listening to. There was an intermediary step. There was a generation of composers between Bach and the great classical masters called the pre-classicists. And as you might divine from their name, the pre-classicists were a bridge between those two styles. So they were working within a new style called the Galant style, which was very popular during the last couple of decades of Bach's life.
- 2.64** And this style is marked by homophonic textures as opposed to polyphonic, so mainly centered around a single melody, an emphasis on this one line that would be the primary line that you'd be listening to, and an accompaniment, and very, very clear, simple, straightforward forms. So whereas a fugue can go on and on and on and have all kinds of strange twists and turns, and fugues are often totally unpredictable. You can't imagine where they're going to go next.
- 2.65** The pre-classicists were writing in forms that were very simple and straightforward. You could start on the tonic or the home key of the piece. You modulate towards the dominant, then you'd go back to the tonic again. It's very simple, straightforward formal schemes. Two or three-part pieces. You have an ABA type of structure, where it was a first idea, then a contrasting idea, then you return to the first idea at the end.
- 2.66** Or we could have a binary form, an A, B type of structure. These are very, very simple forms that repeat it again and again. Not that different, actually, from a lot of popular forms—song form that we have in pop songs, for example, where you to alternate verses and choruses, verses and choruses, and there are untold tens of thousands of songs that all do that. And it's the same in the classical era.
- 2.67** The high classical style of Haydn starts to emerge in the second half of the 18th century. So Haydn takes these forms that were being developed by the pre-classicists and pushes them a little bit farther. They're not quite as simple as what those composers were doing. We can cite a few names, by the way. There are composers like Carl Philipp Emanuel Bach, who was one of Bach's sons, who was a prominent exponent of this new style. There was also the composer Monn, M-O-N-N, who was a prominent composer working at that time.
- 2.68** Haydn takes these ideas and makes them more complex, has more complex forms than what the pre-classicists are doing. It's still basically predicated on melody. It's still basically predicated on simpler, easier to listen to textures, but but pushing them a lot farther. Before we hear a piece by Haydn, let's listen to a work by one of these pre-classical composers. This is, again, an intermediary style. There are still elements of the Baroque in this, but you'll notice that it's easier to distinguish a primary melodic line.
- 2.69** So this is a sonata by Carl Philipp Emanuel Bach. It's in F minor, and it exemplifies a style that Haydn would later develop a lot, which was a posteriori, described as Sturm und Drang, which is a German literary concept that has to do with storm and stress. So a music of passion, a music of uncontrolled emotion, a music that is very turbulent. So

this is Carl Philipp Emanuel Bach writing in a style that presages the later advent of this much more dramatic and emotionally intense form of music. So here's his sonata in F minor.

- 2.70** Okay, so that's a work by a pre-classical composer, and you can hopefully hear the distinction between that and the style of Bach. There's a lot more repetition. The form is a lot simpler. The entire first half of the piece is repeated. It's played twice. And there are these characteristic rhythmic figures that keep returning over and over again in the piece [sound of musical beat], etc.
- 2.71** The other thing that I think is worth pointing out in this piece is that you could not sing this piece if you wanted to. You start to see a gap between vocal styles and instrumental styles. And instrumental styles of music, you can play figures that go all over the keyboard that are quite virtuosic. You can have very rapid scales and runs and trills and all sorts of things like this.
- 2.72** And of course, there was a lot of that during the Baroque era as well. But in a sense, all of Bach's music is related directly to the voice. You could sing, or at least potentially sing, probably the majority of his output. In the classical and pre-classical eras, you start to see these instrumental styles that are extremely virtuosic and that really go way beyond what the voice can possibly do. There's now a gap that's much more pronounced between those two things.
- 2.73** Now, there were Baroque composers that wrote instrumental music that you could not sing. For example, Vivaldi with his interminable concertos. He wrote 600 concertos in his life, and some of those are quite virtuosic. The Four Seasons, for example, has these violin parts that you could not sing them with your voice. They're far too difficult and complex. But by and large, you're starting to see more of a gap between instrumental and vocal styles in this music.
- 2.74** The elements of Haydn style, because we're going to listen to some of his music now and see exactly how this plays out. Now, we've already laid out the basics of it, but just to recapitulate. So Haydn perfected the development of these dialectical forms, these forms in which you have oppositions between different elements that have to be worked out over the course of the piece. So in many respects, his music is essentially abstract. So it does have that in common with a lot of Bach's output.
- 2.75** It's a idealized platonic ideal of what can happen in a piece of music. And it has very little to do ultimately with self-expression. This is something we've been talking about, the romantic notion of the artist as somebody who comes out and exposes their incredible ideas and their incredibly intense emotions and lays that all out for an audience. But the classical composer is not really involved in self-expression in the same manner. That's really a romantic idea. Haydn's music is, again, it's preoccupied with the potential of musical ideas themselves. See what it's possible to do with them.

- 2.76 By and large, the character of Haydn's music, however, tends to rather positive. It tends to be fairly upbeat, fairly cheerful. It's rhythmically vital. It's rhythmically exciting, and it's uncomplicated. It's charming. It's witty. It's relatively easy to listen to. And that's the dominant quality of a lot of his output, which makes it tremendously fun to listen to and entertaining and just enjoyable to hear.
- 2.77 So nevertheless, we talked about the fact that with these dialectical forms and the increased emphasis on drama, on the influence of opera, there has to be some way of keeping these oppositions, these fleeting emotional states, these contrasts from spiraling off into chaos and completely disrupting the ability of the piece to be organized in some coherent manner. So really, the work of Haydn's life, his obsession was trying to find a very strong internal coherence and formal logic that would allow the music to make sense as you move from one event to the next.
- 2.78 And what he increasingly does in his music is he relies upon monothematicism. And the idea there is that rather than having multiple different themes, as a lot of classical composers did. In a lot of Haydn's music, particularly the middle and later periods, he only has one theme, one subject, one melody, and it'll be present throughout the entire piece. And what he does is he'll chop it up into bits, and he'll take the first bar, the first few beats of it, and make a little section of that, and then we'll take the second part of it and make a little sequence, turn it into a section of the piece. But he'll take a single idea, divide it against itself, and then show all the ways that you can present that idea over the course of the piece.
- 2.79 So typically, Haydn works with extremely little material. There's very little there in the piece. The entire interest in the piece lies in the way that he takes this extreme economy of means, this very small amount of initial ideas, which from the outset, don't necessarily look particularly promising. They're not necessarily exquisite melodies. They're not necessarily totally fascinating musical ideas. But that's not the point. The point is, what is the trajectory of the piece? How does it move? How does it go to where it's going? That's where it gets really interesting.
- 2.80 Okay, so enough talking. Let's hear one of his pieces. This is an excerpt from one of Haydn's piano trios. The piano trio is a chamber music genre, in which you have three performers. You have a violin, cello, and a piano. A lot of piano trios, the main emphasis tends to be on the violin part. The piano is often more of an accompaniment, and the cello is frequently essentially duplicating what's in the piano part.
- 2.81 But Haydn starts to write piano trios in which you do have three basically independent parts. The cello part is usually a little bit simpler, a little bit easier, not quite as interesting or as virtuosic as what's typically going on in the violin. But nevertheless, it's written in the spirit of chamber music. You have three equal or quasi-equal partners participating in this musical conversation.

- 2.82** This is such a beautiful piece. Haydn uses orchestration, effects of instrumental writing, to create a very novel tone color, as you'll hear. In the beginning of this piece, the strings, the cello and the violin are playing pizzicato. They're plucking the strings rather than pulling them in unison with the piano. What that creates is a new sound. You take two instruments, put them together, playing the same thing, and you get a new timbre, a new tone quality. In the case of this piece, it sounds like a harp rather than a string trio. Anyway, here's the Piano Trio, No. 44, in E major of Joseph Haydn. This is quite a late piece, written in 1797, so when he was already getting into old age.
- 2.83** So we looked at some of the philosophical and esthetic underpinnings of this style. One of them is its ability to incorporate contrast and opposition, to have multiple distinct elements in a piece, to present them one after the other, present the opposition, bring them together, have a dialog, have different sequences that emerge out of the initial ideas, and then to resolve them at the end. What does that make you think of? Integration of opposites, bringing together multiple different ideas in a coherent framework that allows them to all exist.
- 2.84** This is a idealized version of what a society can be in a sense, and this comes out of Enlightenment principles, ideas of rationality, of clarity, of simplicity, of being able to have a discussion between equal people who might not think the same thing and come out with a synthesis at the end where perhaps elements of different ideas are retained and brought together. And that is really the defining spirit of a lot of this music.
- 2.85** So let's listen to another piece by Haydn, that exemplifies another aspect of his work. That was a piece of chamber music. Again, as I mentioned, the chamber music compositions tend to be him at his most subtle. You notice that the music is filled with lots of little expressive twists and turns and nuances and subtleties and lots of dynamic contrast, loud and soft parts and different rhythmic speeds and so on.
- 2.86** The symphony that we're about to hear, this is an excerpt from one of his middle symphonies. It's number 45, it's a piece that he wrote 25 years earlier before that piano trio. You'll notice that this piece is much less predicated upon changing tempi and changing textures and so on. It's a little bit more consistent in its basic texture, but it's very dramatic. This is the first movement of his so-called "Farewell" Symphony. A lot of his symphonies have these nicknames attached to them, which helps you to remember which ones they are, given that there's 107 of them. It's difficult to remember just from the number alone.
- 2.87** Anyway, the F-sharp minor symphony is remarkable for a few reasons. One of them is the rhythmic energy in this piece, the vigor of it, the dramatic expressive quality that it has. And again, this connects with what we were talking about earlier with Carl Philip Emanuel Bach, the Sturm und Drang style, the Storm and Stress. Well 'Drang' doesn't exactly translate to stress. It's more like a tension than perhaps stress, but that's the most common English translation anyway of that concept. So again, that's a literary concept that was also applied to music. But the idea is a very stormy, turbulent musical

expression, one that is very intense. So here's the 45th Symphony of Joseph Haydn in F-sharp minor.

2.88 So remember we mentioned earlier that this music is not intended for dancing, not explicitly, but the movement in it, the physical movement it refers to metaphorically, is sublimated. So rather than literally dancing, the audience vicariously experiences an intense feeling of forward momentum and direction, which actually comes from the highly directional nature of the music. It's very strongly oriented towards—well, these are harmonic processes, ultimately, where the music has an intense feeling of almost magnetic attraction to a harmonic pole, to a particular chord, a particular particular note that is the central note of the whole piece. And these are things that operate upon your perceptions subliminally. You might not be consciously aware of it, but it's orienting the whole piece very strongly.

2.89 So you have a sense of resolution at the end. You have a sense that the piece has run its course, that have arrived back where we started again. Well, that's because we started on F-sharp minor, we end in F-sharp minor, and then we have various episodes along the way, various modulations, where we move to other keys temporarily, or we move to a major key or a minor key, or move a third higher or a fifth the lower, we move to all these different harmonic regions in the piece. But there's a sense of a central place, a central place from which we begin and to which we must ultimately return at the end.

2.90 And so there's this sense of a drive towards this ultimate resolution, this ultimate conclusion that the music is always going to tend towards ultimately. No matter how far we get from the starting point in a piece like this, there's always the implication of a return at the end. That's one that makes this music so strikingly forward, let's say, in its orientation, so strikingly teleological. We're always inclining to an ultimate endpoint, an ultimate point of resolution.

2.91 And again, this is a style where you can have violent disjunctions. You can have violent changes of tone, of character, of dynamics, and integrate them within this coherent framework because of the strength of this harmonic scheme, because of the strength of the genres and the forms within which the composers are working. That's a very brief little summary of Joseph Haydn, his work, his accomplishments, and his historical position. I'm happy to take any questions that you may have about him.

2.92 Thank you. My question is whether, obviously talking about the earlier composers that we've mentioned, their motivation for writing was because it was their job, and therefore they were writing specifically for other people's wishes and wins. As that changes and people write more from the idea of expressionism and their emotional feelings, how does that affect the audience? Because there are certain pieces that we would say most audiences enjoy, even if they don't have a musical ear. They do tend to be the pieces that were written, not in an expression's period. I don't know, how would

that affect maybe if Haydn had written what he wanted to write? Would that have changed his ability in any way in your opinion?

- 2.93** That's a complicated question, but a very interesting one. On one level, I would say Haydn did write what he wanted to write. Maybe not every single piece, but by and large, the project of his body of work as a whole was clearly to integrate these oppositional ideas into a very strong framework. That was something that he was obsessed with over the course of his life. And he went farther than he needed to, let's say, in terms of fulfilling the requirements of his employment.
- 2.94** He could have done the strict minimum really, and written pieces that were much simpler, pieces that did not have any particular sense of development or continuity from one piece to the next. He could have pushed his capacity and his art and his craftsmanship much less far than he did. And that comes from clearly an inner drive in him that was extremely strong.
- 2.95** So while there isn't this idea of self-expression per se, as you do start to get in the romantic era, nevertheless, he had a personal project. He had something that he was particularly preoccupied with. It had to do not so much with him, with his own personal whims, but it's something like, what is the state of this musical language that I'm inheriting? What is it that my forebears have done? What is it that my colleagues are doing? What needs to be done moving forward? What do we need to do to continue this style, to perfect it, to bring it to a new level of accomplishment?
- 2.96** This is a funny thing when you're a composer or an artist working in a creative field, it's like you're never starting from nothing. There's always a dangling thread left over from the last piece that you wrote or the previous generations were doing. There's like something that's starting to emerge, but that's not fully there yet. And the artist will then take that and push it farther and bring that into being. It goes beyond self-expression. It's something like there's potential within the artistic language itself that the artist intuits and then tries to realize fully.
- 2.97** So on that level, there's a project there that goes beyond merely writing dance music for princes. It does go beyond that. In the time of the Romantics, from late Beethoven onwards, well, it has a few consequences. One is that Haydn had a relatively straightforward and uncomplicated relationship with his audience. If your audience consists of a noble family and then the guests that they have that they're entertaining, that's pretty straightforward. You either write things that they want to hear and have played at their events or you don't.
- 2.98** In the time of Beethoven, you start to get this idea of the artist as an independent figure who's not attached to a noble family in the same way. He's not a servant. He's not simply doing what he's asked to do. One of the consequences of that, of course, is that the artist can produce things that nobody understands, or they don't understand yet, or they don't like it necessarily, because they're pushing things in a direction that

might be highly individual. That, of course, creates a schism. It creates a schism between the individual and the society within which they're working. In a sense, that's the whole essence of the Romantic project.

2.99 We'll get into that in detail when we talk about Chopin and Liszt and Schubert also.

Lecture 3: Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart

At a glance — Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart.

- 3.1 Now we're going to move from Haydn to Mozart. Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart, born in 1756 and died not very long afterwards in 1791. So this is a very short lifespan, unfortunately. We talked about the phenomenal productivity of Bach and Haydn their work ethic, the fact that they had relatively uneventful lives, the fact that they were in situations that not only allowed them but required them to sit and compose enormous quantities of music. It's difficult to understand the genius of a Bach, the profundity of his music, the greatness of his achievement.
- 3.2 But you can understand it in terms of craftsmanship. You can understand in terms of, okay, if you relentlessly applied yourself 12 hours a day, every day for 60 years. You could imagine that eventually you would get good at what you were doing. There's a quote from Bach, actually, where he says that, "In fact, my achievement is not so extraordinary. Anybody who would apply themselves in a similarly rigorous fashion could achieve what I have achieved." That's not true, of course. Bach was being a little bit modest there. But nevertheless, that was the attitude. The attitude was, well, it's down to hard work. Anybody else who did that would achieve the same thing.
- 3.3 So we can frame Mozart—we can frame Bach and Haydn in terms of their work ethic, their devotedness to their craft, and their ability to sit there hour after hour after hour writing. And also with respect to the forms that were prevalent in the time that they were writing, that they were working within, that gave them that framework that they needed to invent their music. With Mozart, we're starting to get into things that are a little bit harder to grasp in that sense.
- 3.4 There's this idea of Mozart that we have of an astonishingly gifted child. Defying belief, actually, that the compositions that he was producing from a very early age seem almost not to be from the hand of man. It's this mystical quasi-religious faculty that's ascribed to Mozart very often by commentators and critics and other musicians. There's something in this music. It is celestial. It seems to be heavenly. It's got extraordinary exquisite balance to it. It radiates peacefulness. It radiates this unworldly beauty. And here again, there's so much of it. And it's so perfect that it's hard to comprehend how one person could have done that.
- 3.5 Keep in mind that Mozart lived about half as long as Haydn, about half as long as Bach. He had a very short lifespan, 37 years. And he wrote more than either of them. The output of Mozart is so vast that it's difficult to comprehend. And he did not have the simple life, the sedentary life of staying in a castle his whole life, as Haydn did, or the relentless need to write hundreds of cantatas and hundreds of religious pieces for church services, as was the case for Bach.

- 3.6** Mozart is edging into the era where the artist is a marginally more independent figure, where he can accept or not accept commissions based on his needs for income, his interest in writing this or that type of piece. And while he's still working in that commissioned model where a nobleman or a prince or whoever it might be is asking him to write a piece, he has a little bit more autonomy in his adult years. Not so much when he's a child. We'll get into that. But there is something incomprehensible about Mozart's achievement, and no amount of study really can dispel that.
- 3.7** By the time Mozart was six years old, he was demonstrating an uncanny, astonishing gift for music, just able to instantaneously absorb anything that his teachers were telling him. Gifted at performance, certainly, he was a very skilled keyboard player. Gifted improviser, he could make up ideas on the spot and immediately extemporize on them. Gifted composer, he could write in any style, any type of piece with seeming ease and endlessly productive. Just a constant fountain of extraordinarily high-quality ideas, one after the other.
- 3.8** Mozart also gives us a new concept in music history, a new type of figure, which is the figure of the child prodigy. Mozart's the archetypal child prodigy in many respects. He exemplifies this idea of a child that just seems to be born out of nowhere and can do things that nobody else can do from a very early age, a giftedness that you can't explain. So not only was he insanely talented, but he was also, when he was a child, he was completely delightful. He had a hilarious sense of humor. He was witty. He was imaginative. He was charming, and he learned with incredible rapidity. Well, those were good qualities to have. And Mozart's father was not indifferent to this.
- 3.9** So Leopold Mozart, his father, realized very early on that, well, this is something really special that I have here on my hands. And he was determined to turn that to his own profit. And he came up with the idea of effectively treating his son like a circus animal. So he started embarking upon these tours across Europe with his son, where he would take Mozart and present him to the various crowned heads in European capitals and have him perform like a trained seal.
- 3.10** It's like, well, here's this freakish child who can play blindfolded. He can improvise with a cloth over the keyboard so he can't see the keys. He can come up with a complete sonata on the spot. Just give him a melody and he'll make up a piece for you. He would have these musical contests with local musicians who can come up with the most extraordinary piece with no preparation whatsoever. And he would always win. It would have been pretty horrifying, I think, to be a professional musician at the time and to see this six-year-old who can do all this stuff.
- 3.11** So the Mozarts get into this routine of touring, constantly traveling around to all these different European countries, destinations, and showing off this child. Mozart did that for a decade of his life: from 1763, he's six years old, to 1773. So that's 11 years of his life being treated this way. To some extent, there was something about that that must have appealed to him because everywhere he went, everybody loved him. Everybody

thought here's this astonishing genius. Here's this amazing child. And it certainly was good for the family finances. It was very good for Leopold Mozart. It made him wealthy because every time they would go to visit one of these castles or whatever it was, they'd be given gifts, gold snuff boxes and things like that, and cash gifts as well. And that was the deal for 11 years.

3.12 Now, throughout all of that time, Mozart is visiting all these different cities. He's visiting Vienna, Munich, Brussels, Paris, London, Amsterdam, Zurich, Vienna, etc. In all of these places, he is unconsciously absorbing and consciously absorbing the musical cultures. If he goes to Paris, he hears some French music, he meets some French musicians, he sees what they're doing there, and he absorbs that. If they're in Italy, he picks up the language, he learns about Italian opera, he learns about Italian musical forms that are being practiced. He's like a sponge. He's picking up all of these influences from all over the place.

3.13 So already, that's an extremely different existence from that of Bach. Remember, we looked at that map. Bach's entire geographical existence fits into 50 kilometers or something like that. It's very, very restrictive. He never left that area. Mozart saw the entire Western world, basically, as a child picking up all these influences from different places, meeting an extraordinary number of musicians, and he absorbs all of it. So by the time he's a teenager, he's had an experience that virtually no other musician in history has had before. And that certainly feeds into his art and partly explains the breadth of his accomplishment, but not entirely.

3.14 It's not the case that Mozart was just throwing out masterpieces from the time he was a baby. It's not quite true. A lot of the very, very earliest Mozart pieces are probably written partly by his father, in some cases, extensively. So it's difficult to establish that with certainty, but he was obviously certainly helped by the people who were tutoring him. And the very, very earliest pieces—I'm not knocking them by any means because that a seven-year-old could do that is pretty astonishing, but it's not a mature style yet. He's seven, and he doesn't have a mature style yet. That starts to come a little bit later. When he's in his late teens and starts to get into his 20s, by that point, the basic elements of his style are in place.

3.15 Now, Mozart also had in common with Haydn and in common with Bach, clearly an extremely intense work ethic. He loved to work hard. And this is something that comes up again and again in his letters as a constant theme. He just loves to sit there and work all day. And again, he's always trying to push his art farther and farther. This is a very conscious thing. He was not satisfied with the standard of pieces that were being written in his day. He thought that he could do something a lot better.

3.16 So Mozart is trying very hard, and again, approaching his art very much like a science. What would happen if we did this? What would happen if I pushed this a little bit farther? What would happen if I tried this new approach, and he's always trying things out. In that sense, he's absolutely obsessed with his art, completely obsessed. It's going

far beyond just simply writing pieces for the nobility to amuse them. In fact, he resented doing that, especially early on in his career. He had to write endless numbers of dance pieces, as I described earlier, and he didn't particularly enjoy doing that, but he was able to do it. He could knock them off in 20 minutes, write a dance suite.

- 3.17** But what he really wanted to do was to—well, he was extremely ambitious, like Haydn, but in a slightly different direction. So remember that Haydn, especially when you get into his mature phase, he starts to write pieces that are monothematic in nature. There's only one idea, which guarantees a certain form of coherence. But you can take that one idea and present it in a bunch of different lights, show all the different facets of the idea, divide it against itself, create contrasts, but always with the same basic material. So what Haydn is doing is he's showing you the diversity that you can have within unity. So even though there's only one idea, showing all the facets of that idea.
- 3.18** Mozart is interested in doing the opposite of that. He's interested in a multiplicity of ideas. And this has something to do, I think, with the sheer fecundity of his imagination, the fact that he was able to spontaneously generate idea after idea after idea after idea in an almost stream of consciousness manner. And there are fantastic ideas. He has that capacity. So Mozart is not going to write a piece based on a single theme, single melody. No, he will come up with 10 themes in a piece or more. He'll just keep generating them. But it doesn't spiral into incoherence in Mozart. And the reason for that is his grasp of large scale form is extremely solid, arguably more so than that of Haydn.
- 3.19** So in a Mozart piece, the sense of direction, the line that connects the piece from the beginning all the way to the end is extremely strong. You always have a sense of where you are with respect to where you began and where it is you're ultimately going. You're never lost. There's a very strong sense of movement in the pieces and of coherence. And because of that, the tightness of that framework and the exquisite balance, the symmetry of his forms, he could be much more spontaneous in his invention because he's not going to fall off. He's going to ultimately always end up on his feet. He's like an expert gymnast that can do extraordinary pirouettes and somersaults in midair and always land on their feet.
- 3.20** So Mozart has this capacity to go off on these tangents, invent a theme and another theme and another theme, and take us here and there and all over the place, and it still coheres. It always works. It's maddening, actually. It's maddening for composers because he never makes a mistake. The proportions are always exactly right. The voice leading is perfect, the way he sets up his chords. The melodies are always compelling, interesting. Textures are always fresh and enjoyable to listen to. It's hard to grasp.
- 3.21** There is another issue in Mozart's life that I think colored his output. We talked about the fact that he was a child prodigy, that his father exhibited him throughout much of his childhood. That created a rather perverse family dynamic in the sense that the father became dependent on his son. It doesn't usually work that way, but in order to

have enough income to survive, he needed his son to remain a child. That was the basis of the whole enterprise was that this is a child prodigy.

- 3.22** In various conscious and unconscious ways, some of them very deliberate, he encourages his son to remain this delightful little child forever. That's what he wants, which increasingly creates a tension, obviously, because Mozart is not interested in remaining his father's son his entire life. He's not interested in being a trained seal throughout his teenage years. He wants to an independent person, move away from the family. And his father raises every possible objection over that happening, tries to keep him at home in Salzburg, which was not where Mozart wanted to be. He wanted to be in Vienna. He wanted to be in these great cultural capitals and meeting other artists and being active in the world.
- 3.23** So, imagine a situation like that where the father is dependent on the son for family revenue and also dependent on the son being an eternal child. So that was rough. That was very rough for Mozart. It's not helped by the fact also that he was naturally gifted at producing music that has this almost childlike openness and serenity and luminosity to it. It's something that we tend to associate with Mozart.
- 3.24** So there are a lot of similarities of style between Mozart and Haydn. We talked about one major difference, which is the Haydn emphasis on diversity within unity and Mozart being more about unity despite diversity or something like that. But there's one other major difference between the two of them, which is that Mozart succeeded where Haydn did not. Haydn was terrible at opera. Those operas are boring. You can just forget about them. Don't listen to them. His concertos also are okay, but they're not particularly thrilling. What do those two forms have in common, the opera and the concerto?
- 3.25** The concerto, just to resume, is a form in which you have a solo performer, and then you have a mass of orchestral performers. And the soloist is pitted against the orchestra. So you have a solo voice. It could be a solo piano or a solo violin or an oboe or a flute or a bassoon or whatever it is. And then you have this orchestral mass. And there's a confrontation between the two. So the the orchestra will present its ideas in the way that you would expect a mass of people to speak, which is to say in unison and all grouping together. Then the soloist presents a more nuanced, more expressive version of the same thing. Then there's not a contest exactly, but an opposition, certainly, between the idea of the individual and the idea of the mass. That's the essence of the concerto form.
- 3.26** In common with opera, the idea is you have individual. You have this single person who's at the front of the stage who is singing or who's playing, and then you have the mass behind them that's supporting them and at times arguing, not necessarily agreeing with what they're saying. Haydn wasn't very good at that. It just wasn't his native tongue, so to speak. But Mozart excelled at those genres. And in fact, the greatest works that he ever created, arguably, are to be found in the operas.

- 3.27** And in his many piano concertos, his violin concertos, his horn concertos, the bassoon concerto, the concertos for multiple instruments, and so on. These are exquisite works. And so the idea of the individual expressive solo voice floating above this mass of other performers is very key to Mozart's output in general. It's not to say that the string quartets are any less good or the symphonies. He certainly wrote phenomenal works in every genre, but he's especially strong in opera and in the concerto.
- 3.28** So the essence of opera, we can maybe talk about this just to define it a little bit. Opera was an idea of dramatic music, fusing together of literary and musical conceptions in a single work. The term opera means literally "work," and it's a bringing together of all of these things. And there are many other dramatic or quasi-dramatic musical forms that existed at around the same time, such as the Singspiel, for example—which is a form in which, it's similar to opera, but you have spoken interludes. So the action is moved forward by spoken bits, like in musicals, musical theater, where there are numbers, there are song sections, and then there are sections where basically the people on stage are acting. They're speaking, they're having a dialog, and those bits are not typically set to music.
- 3.29** In opera, rather than having spoken dialog, you have recitative. And recitative is, it's similar to speech, but it's set to pitches, and there's an instrumental accompanying to it. But the function of the recitative in an opera is to move the action forward. But it's not a formal song, so to speak. It imitates speech in its rhythms and in its cadences. Then you have choruses in which the body of singers that are present on the stage are all singing together. And those are usually reserved for particular dramatic moments in the opera. And you have arias as well, which are sung pieces, usually intended for a single performer, but you also can have duos and trios and so on.
- 3.30** An opera, even though it might be extremely long, some operas are several hours long. It can be written in multiple acts in which there's a curtain that goes down, there's an intermission, and you go back 20 minutes later and you see the second part, the third part, sometimes even the fourth part, and so on. But basically, it consists of an alternation of these different types of movements, just like in the cantatas of Bach, which we talked about, where you'll have a recitative, an aria, a chorus, and so on. Well, those sorts of ideas are present in opera as well. And you alternate them. You cycle through these different types of movements. And Mozart is extraordinarily strong at this. He's strong at it because he has an unerring dramatic sense. He's able to keep you absolutely gripped over two hours, three hours or more.
- 3.31** And there's a few reasons for that. So one of them is that the sonata principle, which we talked about in my second lecture, we talked about the fact that you have these dialectical forms that are emerging where you have multiple musical characters or ideas that are exposed, laid out one after the other. They contrast with one another. And then there's a synthesis that appears at the end. Well, what is that other than a dramatic concept? That's basically what that means. You have person A who thinks one

thing, person B who think something else, they have a discussion, maybe they disagree, and then maybe they come to some synthesis at the end.

3.32 And what Mozart understood was that that is a proxy for dramatic movement. And he brings together the directionality, the striking teleological, directional nature of these dialectical forms with the drama of opera. He brings those two things together. And not only does he do that, but he's exquisitely able to time things over these very, very long time spans in such a manner that it just pulls you forward, irresistibly. So the greatest operas of Mozart are extraordinarily gripping. If you haven't heard them, I can only recommend that you sit and hear them. Attend a performance if you can. That's the best way to hear them, but you will not be bored. They're exquisite works.

3.33 So the characters in operas are often cartoons or archetypes, maybe is a more charitable way of putting it. They're simplified, idealized caricatures of character types that you might meet in real life. And then these archetypes, of course, contrast with one another and are left to work out their differences in a dramatic setting. In a sense, that's more or less what happens in Mozart's instrumental works as well. And that might be partly where their power is derived, the fact that we're always dealing with character in Mozart, always with these archetypes. And a lot of the instrumental pieces, although they might not literally have singers in them, function in a very similar manner to the operas.

3.34 Now, let's talk about some of the aspects of Mozart's style that will hopefully provide some context. We talked earlier about the advent of the Galant style in Europe, and the Galant style, to define it, is, again, an increasingly predominant role given to melody. We're moving away from the old polyphonic style towards a style that is simpler, more streamlined, in which the textures are straightforward and the forms are clear. So this is what Mozart inherits.

3.35 And his music radiates symmetry, radiates balance. It radiates this harmonious nature that is extremely pleasing to listen to. And it tends to be less charged with dramatic movement and dramatic contrast than that of Haydn. So even though, obviously, Mozart is an extremely skilled dramatist, the actual impression you have when you're listening to it is not necessarily of something extremely turbulent. So he's able to integrate this dramatic movement, this dynamism, into a very, very, very strong, stable, and clear framework. Extremely pleasing to listen to.

3.36 So I'm going to suggest that we listen to something, and this will give you an idea. We're going to hear an excerpt from one of Mozart's concertos. So remember that in order to write a concerto, you need to have a soloist. You need to have a virtuoso performer who is willing to stand up in front of the stage, in front of all their colleagues in an orchestra, and play a solo part. These solo parts are often extraordinarily demanding. Soloists, consequently, would make their names by playing concerti, by commissioning them from famous composers and going off on tour playing them. It would make an impression on the audience that was very strong.

- 3.37** If you were a skilled performer and had a certain charisma and could play these pieces, then that would make your reputation. There were a lot of very famous virtuosos in the Baroque and Classical eras who basically just did that. They would play concertos, the solo pieces with an orchestra, and they would tour around playing these pieces. These are, in a sense, the forebears of the rock stars that would emerge in the 20th century. These were extremely charismatic virtuoso players who were very skilled at making a strong impression on the audience.
- 3.38** So Mozart had a lot of requests for pieces from these sorts of performers. And one of the pieces that he composed in this genre is his the Bassoon Concerto. So the bassoon is a woodwind instrument that plays in the bass register, bass and tenor register. It's a large woodwind instrument, and it's not really so much something that you associate with solos, with concertos. But Mozart wrote one, and it is a lovely piece. It's a piece that I'm particularly fond of. It has this very cheerful quality to it, but it also runs you through all of these quasi-operatic archetypes within an instrumental framework.
- 3.39** And that's one of the things that I find really quite remarkable about this piece, is that every time you hear a line on the bassoon on the solo part, it immediately makes you think of a character in opera, different sorts of characters. There's the more turbulent expression. There's a more cheerful one. There's a Bel Canto aria, where it's very beautiful, melodious singing. There are other things that are more dance-like. But whatever it is, it's very easy to imagine the soloist as being not only a person, but a sequence of different people, different characters over the course of the piece that are interacting with each other in interesting ways.
- 3.40** Just before we hear this piece, the way most concertos work, especially in the Classical era, is you start with an expository section. So that's the orchestra playing by itself without the soloist and presenting all the main themes that you'll be hearing over the course of the piece. So the soloist is standing there on stage waiting, waiting for their chance to play as the orchestra gets going. Then there'll be a little cadence, a little pause, and then the soloist will make their grand and it's always very impressive.
- 3.41** The idea is you're setting up a contrast between the not very subtle, orchestral way of playing, and then, of course, all the refinement and the expressivity and the subtlety of what the soloist is able to do. And then that alternation continues over the course of the piece. And that's where the dramatism of the concerto form comes from. So here is the first movement of Mozart's Bassoon Concerto.
- 3.42** [musical piece]
- 3.43** Okay, it's not necessarily the finest of Mozart's concertos, but it's nevertheless a wonderful piece. That solo bit at the end, by the way, just before the orchestra comes back in, that's called a cadenza. A cadenza is a passage that in that time was typically improvised. The soloist would then have their chance to show off all their virtuosity, all the tricks that they knew how to do for the audience. Then there would be a little

cadence, a little trill, and then the orchestra would come back in and round off the piece.

- 3.44** But I love that piece. Now, Mozart, I mentioned the fact that his productivity is perhaps, in a sense, almost more difficult to comprehend than that of Haydn and Bach. He was able to write things with seeming ease. He would not make very many sketches. He would just sit down and write as though the piece was already entirely in his head before he even started to write. It's quite hard to believe. And that progressed as he moved into adulthood. And in the last year of his life, something astonishing happens. You might have seen the film *Amadeus*, which is a great film. Most of it is fiction, by the way. There are some elements of reality in it, but a lot of it is definitely embroidered.
- 3.45** But there's one dimension in that story that is historically accurate, which is that one of his very last compositions was a requiem, a Mass for the dead. And he was commissioned to write this piece anonymously. So there was an anonymous patron who asked him if he would write this piece and asked him to state his fee and his terms, and they made an agreement. And he never knew who commissioned the piece. The film implies that it was Mozart's rival who was doing this and who poisoned him.
- 3.46** The reality is that there was a count who commissioned pieces by various famous composers in order to pass them off as his own work and to perform them and impress his friends. So a very vain, narcissistic count who commissioned these pieces for that reason. But anyway, Mozart never knew this. He simply knew that he was asked to write a requiem. And he throws himself into the task and writes this astonishingly profound piece.
- 3.47** In little time, although he's not able to complete it because he becomes ill with rheumatoid fever, which was pretty astonishingly horrible, especially at that time. There were no treatments for this. And it was a fairly common illness in Vienna at the time, but Mozart had the bad fortune of catching it at a time when his system was already run down from overwork. He was completely exhausted and working like a madman his entire life and died a very painful death because of it. Anyway, in the midst of being sick, in the midst of writing this commission, this requiem, which he also was convinced was his own requiem. He was convinced that he was writing the piece for his own death and that he'd been deliberately pushed into this by somebody. He became very paranoid about who the actual commissioner was.
- 3.48** Anyway, in the last year of Mozart's life, 1791, he composes one after another without any breaks, he composes the B flat Piano Concerto, one of his great, most exquisite compositions. Two huge operas are premiered that year. The Magic Flute and *La clemenza di Tito*, two multi-hour long pieces premiered three weeks apart in two different European cities. That would be enough, you would think, for one year. He also composes the Clarinet Concerto, an exquisite piece, the Little Masonic Cantata, which is a 15-minute choral work, and approximately 20 other pieces in one year.

- 3.49** It's incomprehensible to me how he managed to do that, while being rather unwell, and dealing with complicated family issues the whole time, and traveling constantly, and supervising the performances of his own works. It's difficult to grasp. Let me play you another piece by Mozart. This is an excerpt from Don Giovanni, which is, I think you could say, certainly one of his most popular and perhaps his greatest opera. The Magic Flute might be slightly more popular, but Don Giovanni is pretty amazing, and you have to hear the whole thing. This is just a tiny little excerpt.
- 3.50** Anyway, in Don Giovanni, it tells the story of Don Juan, who's, of course, not a very appealing character. So he's licentious and violent and extraordinarily prolific in love as the libretto describes in great detail, and he's used to bullying people and getting his way. And eventually, he meets a terrible fate. He meets something that he can't cheat and lie his way out of. And he encounters a ghost at the end of the opera and is dragged off to hell. It's all quite dramatic. Now, there's an aria in this opera that's quite famous, which is referred to colloquially as the Catalog Aria. And what it is, is his servant, Leporello, is running through a list of all of the women that his boss has conquered over the course of his adventures. So I'll read you the text of this aria:
- 3.51** "In winter, he likes fat ones. In summer, he likes thin ones. He calls the tall ones majestic. The little ones are always charming. He seduces the old ones for the pleasure of adding to the list. His greatest favorite is the young beginner. It doesn't matter if she's rich, ugly, or beautiful. If she wears a skirt, you know what he does. My dear lady, this is the list of the beauties my master has loved, a list which I have compiled. Observe, read along with me. In Italy, 640. In Germany, 231. A hundred in France. In Turkey, 91. But in Spain, already, 1003. Among these are peasant girls, maid servants, city girls, countesses, baronesses, marchionesses, princesses, women of every rank, every shape, every age. With blondes, it is his habit to praise their kindness. In brunettes, their faithfulness. In the white-haired, their sweetness."
- 3.52** Okay, so Leporello doesn't have a very good boss. Let's put it that way. And this Catalog Aria, is, again, one of the most famous parts of Don Giovanni. So we'll listen to this piece. This will give you an idea of Mozart's operatic style and also of his ability to project a very strong sense of drama and character in his music.
- 3.53** [musical piece]
- 3.54** It's very difficult to present an excerpt from an opera. You really have to hear the whole narrative, the whole story, and get a sense of the arc of it, but that's one of the more famous arias from this piece. I'd like to play an excerpt from one of his symphonies, a very late piece, the Symphony No. 40 in G minor. Just a quick word about the way Classical symphonies are typically structured. So these are multi-movement works, which is to say that you'll have typically a fast allegro movement at the beginning, which is energetic, and it's typically the most complex of the four movements as well.

- 3.55** So it's the movement that adheres most closely to the sonata idea, the dialectical principle of having different motifs and themes and having a, what would you say, a dialog amongst those various ideas. You often have a slow movement, a minuet, which is a light dance, or a scherzo, which is a little bit more energetic, and a finale. The finale is often a rondo or some other fast dance. So the idea of the Classical symphony is that you have all these different movements that are like archetypal representations of all the different facets of a person, of a human.
- 3.56** The symphony presents you with a picture, a very complete picture of the inner life of a human. You've got all these dimensions. You've got the intellectual dimension. You've got the heart dimension and the slow movement, which is typically very lyrical and expressive. You've got something relating to physical movement, to the feet, through dance, and so on and so forth. It's like all these different facets of our being, of our nature, are represented, in turn, in the different movements of a symphony, and you get this very complete experience.
- 3.57** This is a minuet from the 40th symphony of Mozart. And this piece is something that I wanted to play for you for a couple of reasons. One of them is that Schubert was obsessed with Mozart. We're going to talk about Schubert tomorrow a little bit. And he was fascinated with the late symphonies in particular. And of this particular movement, he said that it's as though you can hear angels singing with the orchestra. There's something celestial about it. He was very taken with that quality of the piece. The other thing about this movement, I think that's quite interesting, is it prefigures Beethoven in a lot of respects.
- 3.58** It's an amazingly forward-thinking piece of music to have written, and there's a incredible dynamism in the rhythm in this piece that comes from this constant displacement of rhythmic accents. Typically, you would expect the accents to follow a regular pattern in a rhythm. You'll have a strong downbeat, one, two, three, one, two, three. You'll keep that pattern going. But Mozart keeps displacing it so the accents don't necessarily fall on the downbeat. They don't necessarily fall on the first beat. And that's a rhythmic trick that Beethoven took extraordinarily far in his own symphonies later on. Anyway, this is, I think, a very beautiful movement from one of his late symphonies. Let's listen to this.
- 3.59** [musical piece]
- 3.60** So imagining that he wrote more music than Bach or Haydn did and lived to be only half their age. It's tempting to imagine what he might have done had he not died in 1791. Of course, we can't know that, but there's a complete arc, nevertheless, in his work, where it's very difficult to project beyond where he ended up at the end of his life. Very difficult to imagine that. And in any case, it's not as though he didn't write enough music. We're going to continue that tomorrow. We're going to start with Schubert. We're going to look at Beethoven, and we're going to look at Chopin. So we're going to edge into Romanticism. Are there any questions before we sign off for today? Yes.

- 3.61** Thank you. I was just curious to know, were there moments throughout your research and teaching that changed your way of thinking in the last three composers that you mentioned that also not only inspired your own personal work and also on a practical level?
- 3.62** Yeah, absolutely. As a composer, as an artist, it's hard not to be aware of what's been done in the past, especially now. There's this phenomenon called the anxiety of influence that starts to take root in the 20th century, where increasingly we have this body of cultural achievements that stands before us, this massive monument, and you can't ignore it.
- 3.63** In the time of Mozart, you would have been aware of what your colleagues were doing and maybe a few of your predecessors, but you didn't have a thousand years of musical repertory at your fingertips. And, of course, today it's extremely different. Anybody can go on the internet, and you can listen to basically anything that was ever written by anybody for free. So it's a very different situation. So it's common now for artists not only to be preoccupied with their own work, but also with the creative output of other people. And it's impossible to get away from that. And of course, it affects you.
- 3.64** On one level, you compare yourself in intentionally or not with what other artists have done. For some people, that can really be quite debilitating. For example, if you're a composer and you're obsessed with Beethoven, you're like, "Well, I can't measure up to that." It can be paralyzing. I think any artist has to, on one level, have the temerity, the ego, the disagreeableness, perhaps, to imagine that what they have to say is valuable and that it is worth directing resources towards. And it's worth getting other people to pay attention to it. I think it goes along with the artistic enterprise to some degree.
- 3.65** You can't allow yourself to be overwhelmed by what the artists of the past have done, or else you'll be paralyzed. You won't be able to make anything. But you can learn from them, certainly. Probably the composer from whom I've learned the most has been Bach. And part of that is because the music has this quality of universality. It deals with the fundamental, the most elemental, the most fundamental problems of musical composition in an extraordinarily profound way.
- 3.66** The things that I've learned from Bach really are applicable to just about any possible style of music or musical situation you could think of. Just simple things like, how do you create a sense of continuity of a trajectory in a composition? How do you integrate different ideas into a piece? How do you do a lot with very little? How do you create a strong expressive effect in a piece of music? How do you take different independent musical lines and create a coherence out of them? How do you set up a texture? All of these things. These are fundamental musical issues. It's like every art form has them.
- 3.67** It's like if you're a photographer, then you have to deal with composition, light. These are the basics of photography, that they don't change. It's the same with musical

composition. It doesn't really change over the centuries. And Bach offers you that in a particularly distilled and abstract and idealized fashion. So I've learned quite a lot from Bach. Otherwise, no, it's a lifelong process. I'm always listening. I'm always hearing new pieces. I'm always reevaluating pieces that I've already heard, and they do certainly affect me.

3.68 One of the things while preparing this lecture that really impressed me was Mozart's ability to create a single line of development from the very beginning of the piece to the very end that is totally coherent, draws you forward, has a real momentum to it, but within which he can incorporate all of these diverse elements. It's amazing. So as a composer, I take technical things from that. I'm like, well, how can I take aspects of that and apply it to my own style, my own language, which, of course, is extremely different.

3.69 So, yeah, I think a creative artist today, by necessity, has to look backwards and forwards simultaneously. You want to do something new, you want to create something. The essence of creation is that you're doing something that hasn't already been done. You're not merely creating a pastiche of things that were done before you, but you also want to understand what's been done in the past so that you can see what your own particular individual contribution might be. So, yes, absolutely. That's always been an integral part of my work has been not only my own personal creative projects, but also a very, very close and continual contact with music of the past.

Lecture 4: Ludwig van Beethoven

At a glance — Ludwig van Beethoven.

- 4.1 Good morning. Today, we're going to talk about Ludwig van Beethoven. Beethoven is a figure that fascinates virtually everybody. He's extraordinarily interesting in many respects, and he's also a transitional figure. We talked yesterday about the enormous gulf between the style of Bach towards the end of his life and the first mature works of Haydn, how in the space of about 10, 15 years, you see this colossal shift in the composition of music. And with Beethoven, you don't really see that in the same way. His early works are actually quite similar in many respects to the music of Haydn.
- 4.2 But where you do see a shift, a very profound shift, is over the course of his own creative life. Beethoven is transitional in the sense that he bridges the gap between the Classical and the romantic styles or eras. So what that means is that the early works could easily be confused with the later works of Haydn. If you were not a musicologist, if you were not a specialist, you could easily have trouble distinguishing between the two. He was deeply influenced by Haydn, also by Mozart. And you see him in his early works trying to master this language that had been established by his forebears.
- 4.3 By the end of his life, his style has evolved to the point where he's completely disrupting these Classical forms to a degree that virtually destroys them from within. And this inaugurates an entirely new style, but also an entirely new attitude of the artist vis-à-vis their public. So we talked about how Haydn, we looked at this in detail, Haydn was essentially a servant. He had, of course, his independent thoughts and ideas and his own autonomous development in terms of where he wanted to take his art. But Haydn was in a form of indentured servitude to this Prince Esterházy.
- 4.4 Mozart was marginally more independent, but he's still taking commissions from the nobility, and he's still beholden in many respects to the tastes of the time and having to write loads of relatively indifferent dance music and things like that. And he's still very conscious of the necessity of having popular success as his finances depend on it. He needs to write operas that are popular.
- 4.5 With Beethoven, you start to see a very new attitude emerge. And the attitude is something like this: I stand apart from my society. I'm not merely a servant. I'm somebody who has their own independent individual point of view, which may completely and violently diverge with that of my contemporaries and that of my public. But I'm autonomous, and I'm going to pursue that, and I'm going to pursue it to the ends of the Earth if I need to. And there's an almost prophetic quality to his works, the idea that maybe these pieces are not yet understood, but they will be eventually.
- 4.6 That shift of attitude is utterly profound. And, in a sense, that's where we still are culturally. That's how artists are still viewed. We still think of artists as people who are not exactly like other people. They're not servants. They're creating something new

that is going to potentially be disruptive, potentially be not understood, but that in time, if it's a good piece of work, if it's got enough depth to it, will eventually be understood. Maybe in 50 years time, maybe in 100 years time, might not necessarily be appreciated during the lifetime of the composer. So that's something fundamental about Beethoven that really is a significant game changer in the history of Western music. But there's a whole bunch of other factors that come into it as well.

- 4.7 Already during the later years of Haydn, it became not only possible but widespread to earn a living through the sale of scores. So, whereas earlier composers would receive a commission or they'd be employed by the nobility to write a piece, and that would be that. You would be paid once, and then the piece would be played, and that was your fee. Suddenly it becomes possible through the advent of music publishing, printed music scores and their wider availability, their wider distribution, to make a living through that. So, Beethoven is also able to benefit from this new commercial model, where you're not necessarily entirely dependent on the nobility. You can also earn a living selling works to publishers.
- 4.8 So, let me give you a few basic biographical details about Beethoven. He's born in 1770 in northern Germany, in a city called Bonn. Like Bach, Haydn, and Mozart, he was born into a family of musicians. So there are a few recurring themes starting to emerge here. So a lot of these composers, they did not emerge out of nowhere. The Bach family was vast. There were dozens of members of Bach's family, all bearing the surname Bach, who were professional musicians, going back generations. All of his uncles, cousins, parents, brothers, sisters, all musicians. Same was the case with Haydn, same with Mozart as well.
- 4.9 So these figures don't simply emerge out of nowhere. They emerge out of a culture in which that is what they know. They're profoundly steeped in the culture and the music of their time. And it's the case with Beethoven as well. But he had a slightly less happy childhood than Mozart. So Mozart—it's complicated because on the one hand, he was clearly exploited by his father, and clearly that was hard on him. But he also had all of these extraordinarily delightful experiences traveling all over Europe and being treated like a star and being loved by everybody and so on. So I suppose it was a bit of a mixed bag.
- 4.10 With Beethoven, he had a pretty seriously rotten childhood. So his father was also a court musician, but he was also an alcoholic brute. And Beethoven's father had the idea that, like Mozart, who was a very famous case, everybody was aware of this incredible child prodigy. His father had the idea that, well, maybe Ludwig could also be a famous child prodigy. Maybe I could benefit from this because it was very clear from a very early age that Beethoven was extraordinarily gifted. So we already have this precedent of a Mozart who is able to achieve fame and fortune through his precocious gifts.
- 4.11 So the father decides, well, by whatever means necessary, I'm going to get Ludwig to do this as well. So he would beat him. He would wake him up in the middle of the night

and drag him to the piano in his pajamas and force him to play for hours and hours and hours. It was pretty atrocious. So that was his childhood. And in many respects, that clearly left some scars. But it's also true that the relentless discipline of it made it so that he had a very well-developed technique by the time he was an adolescent.

- 4.12 This doesn't always work. A child who is simply not gifted or has no affinity for music—it's just not going to produce anything. It happens that Beethoven was a creative genius. So one could argue that he would have achieved that one way or another. But the discipline of it, at least, or perhaps the fear, the terror of his father may have spurred him on, may have made him want to try harder. We don't know.
- 4.13 Now, the other thing that I think is interesting about Beethoven is he did not actually become a famous child prodigy like Mozart for a number of reasons. One of them is that he didn't really seek to establish himself early on in his life as a celebrity performer composer. He wasn't particularly interested in that. He had a more introverted character, in a sense, and was determined to master his art. He was determined to study it very closely, to try to absorb what Haydn and Mozart had done.
- 4.14 And there are periods of his life for which we have absolutely no completed compositions whatsoever. There's a period of five years between when he was 15 and 20, where, as far as we know, all he was really doing was just studying. He wasn't producing any creative work. So whereas with Mozart, we have works dating back to when he was seven, if not earlier. With Beethoven, it's not the case.
- 4.15 So, he was determined to achieve this mastery, this technical command of the language of music and of the different styles and dialectical forms that were being practiced by Mozart and Haydn. And then we start to see an early style emerge. So before I go any farther with that, I'll just quickly point out that Beethoven's life work divides up more or less neatly into three periods. This is always—you have to take this with a grain of salt because these are things that are determined a posteriori by musicologists and historians. So it's not as though there's a clear line in the sand dividing his different periods and his different styles.
- 4.16 But nevertheless, there are two major shifts in attitude that you see in his work. You can clearly distinguish an early style which has the clarity of line, the purity of voice leading, the simplicity of texture, the simplicity of form also, of Haydn and Mozart, with, of course, his own distinct personality. One of the things that once you start to get a little bit more familiar with these early works, what you do start to notice is that Beethoven has, first of all, a wicked sense of humor. He's very funny in these pieces, and he also has a sense of constantly thwarting the listener's expectations. So that's not a prominent feature of Mozart. Mozart's music, for all of its grace, its subtlety, its balance, its symmetry, is not full of surprises, but Beethoven is. And these things might not necessarily reach out and grab you when you're listening to the pieces for the first time.

- 4.17 But nevertheless, there are a number of notable instances of this, where he just simply refuses to do what the listener is expecting. He always takes you off onto some unexpected direction, or he throws in a dissonant cord that suddenly wrenches the music off somewhere else, or he interrupts the rhythmic continuity. Or he has false entrances where it sounds like the performers made a mistake and started too early, and then everybody has to start again and all of these sorts of things. So even in the very early works, you see instances of this. So he's got this devilish of subversive quality that is subtle in the early works, but you can still hear.
- 4.18 Now, something seems to happen around the turn of the century, around 1800. One of them is he starts to lose his hearing. And we don't know precisely what the cause of that was. There's a bunch of competing theories as to what precisely it was. He seems to have had some a degenerative condition with his auditory nerve. But around the turn of the century, it starts to affect him. So he doesn't just suddenly become deaf overnight, but he starts to be a little bit more hard of hearing and also to develop tinnitus, which is something that I also have. So if any of you have tinnitus, you know how irritating it is.
- 4.19 Tinnitus is this constant whooshing or ringing or buzzing sound in your ear. It can be provoked by sudden loud noises, or it can be inherited in some instances, or it can be—it has various different causes, but there's no treatment for it. And so not only is he starting to lose his hearing, but he also suffers from this constant noise in his head. This was not really debilitating in his middle period yet. This was a progressive condition that gradually became worse. He never completely lost his hearing. He never became utterly profoundly deaf, but it certainly got very bad, especially at the end of his life, where he could barely hear anything. He could distinguish between high and low noises, but that was about it.
- 4.20 Anyway, so at the turn of the century, he begins to lose his hearing. And by this point, it's also becoming clear that Beethoven is very unlucky in love. And this is something that was a recurring motif in his life. He was unable to find any domestic arrangement that would bring him any happiness. He was constantly falling in love with various countesses and women from the nobility who were above his rank socially and inaccessible to him. And he never married, never had any children.
- 4.21 So this increasing sense of isolation was also exacerbated by his difficulty hearing. And this inaugurates a middle style. And the middle style is distinguished by a few things. So one of them is he starts to move away from the symmetry and the poise of the Classical style. He starts to write pieces that are more and more vehement, that are more rhythmically violent, that are more emotionally turbulent, and that are, in some instances, harshly repetitive, rhythmically, where he's pounding away at some obsessive rhythm, again and again and again.
- 4.22 The middle works that exemplify this style, well, you could argue that it begins with pieces like the third symphony, the Eroica symphony. And the Eroica symphony, if you

to compare that to his first two attempts in symphonic style, the first and second symphonies, there is just a massive shift going on. He's moving away from these pleasant, well-written, certainly masterful, but ultimately relatively harmless early works that look backwards towards Haydn, and moving to a new style that you could describe as heroic, a style that Glenn Gould, the pianist, referred to as Beethoven on a massive ego trip.

- 4.23** And what he meant by that was the exacerbation of Beethoven's personal subjectivity of his own feelings, his own ideas and attitudes starts to come to the fore, and it starts to disturb this equilibrium. In the Eroica symphony, what he does is he plans a piece that completely disturbs this equilibrium, that just completely goes outside of the standard framework of a symphony. It's massively longer for one thing. It's massively more complicated from a formal point of view also, with all of these strange, unexpected byways and twists and turns and the drama of the music somehow holds it all together.
- 4.24** And he also writes music that is increasingly, emotionally, extraordinarily intense. So that's the third symphony. And the third symphony, there's an interesting story behind that. He was initially a huge fan of Napoleon Bonaparte, and determined that this was one of these archetypal great men of history, and he's going to drastically improve the world. After Napoleon crowns himself Emperor, Beethoven becomes extremely disillusioned with Napoleon. His initial idea was to write a symphony that would be in honor of Napoleon and his achievements.
- 4.25** After that happens, he violently scratches out Napoleon's name on the title page of the piece. You can see this in the manuscript. The manuscript has been violently attacked. There's holes in it, and he's scratched the name off. But he names it the Eroica symphony, the Heroic symphony. So nevertheless, it's an attempt to describe musically some metaphysical, intense struggle towards greatness, towards an ultimate triumph of the individual human spirit. And this is something that is manifest again and again and again in these early works, also in pieces like the Fifth Symphony.
- 4.26** Now, there's another aspect of Beethoven's style that I want to underline here. Remember, Mozart was able to spontaneously invent the most exquisite melodies and just a never-ending stream of wonderful ideas. Beethoven shares something with Haydn, which is that he tends to work with extraordinarily little material. And unlike Haydn, who tended to write these monothematic sonatas where you would have just one theme, and then you would try to show all the facets of that idea.
- 4.27** Beethoven is obsessed with this dialectical principle that we talked about yesterday, where you take opposing ideas, opposing themes, and you use that to move the music dramatically forward. There's this idea of conflict. There's this idea of potentially irreconcilable differences in musical materials that have to be hashed out, and in many respects, Beethoven is the consummate master of the development. So development is a concept we looked at a little bit yesterday. But what it basically means is you take the

ideas that you laid out in the exposition of your piece, the themes, the rhythmic motifs, and you put them through their paces.

- 4.28** The German word for development is *Durchführung*, which means to lead through something. And it's very tied up with the notion of movement and direction and also large scale architecture. So Beethoven is obsessed with this. In a sense, the material, the motifs, the melodies and Beethoven, are not really the point. They're never really the point. A lot of his themes are, in fact, extraordinarily simple, almost banal. In fact, you would look at some of the ideas he comes up with in his sketchbooks and think, this is ridiculous. This is like the work of an untalented student.
- 4.29** I'm going to play you an excerpt from an early piece of his, and you'll see what I mean. This is the first String Quartet, Opus 18, No. 1 in F major. This piece exemplifies that idea. The theme is just so ridiculously uninteresting that you almost can't believe it. If you look at his sketches, there are pages and pages and pages of him to come up with some an idea that he can work with that will be decent enough to hold up in this piece. Even though the idea is so simple, it takes him a very long time to arrive at it. He seems not to have had that spontaneous gift for melody, for just the spontaneous invention of themes. Many of Beethoven's themes are, in fact, just arpeggios. They're just the notes of a chord being played one after the other. They're not even really particularly melodic in character.
- 4.30** Let me play you this example of early style, which, as I mentioned earlier, mostly looks backwards to Haydn. But what you can see is him making this extraordinary architecture out of a very, very, very simple idea. So the theme, I can just hum it for you now [musical sound]. That's about it. That's the whole theme. Try to listen to what he does with this, how he manages to spin that into an entire movement, an entire architecture with lots of surprises along the way. This piece is from 1801, so it's more or less bridging the gap between the early and middle periods.
- 4.31** [musical piece]
- 4.32** So what starts to happen in the middle period is Beethoven asserting his own individuality increasingly, and not only his own individuality, but it's a Titanic struggle of an individual against his own inevitable dissolution and decay. And the idea is that he's not only expressing his emotions, he's expressing his desire to not be destroyed by the colossal forces of the universe conspiring to kill him, something like that. And that attitude is markedly different from what any composer, previous to him, had attempted to express. There's this idea that my life is extraordinarily difficult. This is actually a quote from him: "I might be the most miserable of all of God's creatures, but I'll ultimately triumph." This is a spirit that emerges again and again in this work.
- 4.33** The idea is, I'm expressing my indomitable spirit. I'm not going to allow myself to be destroyed. And there are a few reasons for that that stem from his own extraordinarily intransigent character. He was a very difficult person by all accounts. He could be

charming at times, but certainly very, very difficult. The deafness played a part in it. His romantic isolation, certainly. But there's also a philosophical underpinning behind all of this. So it's not merely an extension of his own personal character.

- 4.34 But that is really mirrored in pieces like the Fifth Symphony that have these incredibly strident, emphatic endings that seem to go on and on and on, where he seems to be saying, I'm going to win. I'm not going to be destroyed. And so this middle period is involved in that basic attitude, and it makes the music off-putting, certainly in certain respects. It certainly was at the time. Of course, now we've absorbed this attitude culturally, but this was profoundly shocking when these pieces were played for the first time.
- 4.35 Now, what starts to happen eventually is his personal circumstances get worse and worse. And from 1815 onwards, there's another dramatic shift that starts to happen. So Beethoven becomes increasingly tangled up in intractable family disputes that are incredibly unpleasant. So his brother, Kasper, dies that year. And Kasper had a son called Karl. And Beethoven entered into an unbelievably nasty and cruel dispute over the guardianship of Karl, because Karl's mother, of course, was alive and naturally wanted to raise Karl, but Beethoven felt that she was not a person of character, not somebody who should be allowed to raise his nephew.
- 4.36 So he attempts to convince the courts through all kinds of subterfuge, all kinds of methods, to grant him the right to raise Kasper and to live with him, which does not work. It fails for a number of reasons. First of all, it's completely obvious that Beethoven leads a chaotic and rather dissolute lifestyle. Secondly, he's not of noble birth, which was the ultimate legal motif given for not granting him this custody of his nephew. But this eats him up for about five years of his life, if not more. And it makes him profoundly miserable. Perhaps it was his frustrated ambition to have children of his own and his desire to raise a child and seeing that as his opportunity to do so.
- 4.37 But nevertheless, in his later years, he becomes increasingly withdrawn, and he retreats into his late style. And the late style is something that is difficult to come to terms with in many respects. Beethoven's late style inaugurates the idea of the musical avant-garde, essentially. What that means is he no longer cares what the audience thinks. He no longer cares even what the performers think. And it's not clear that he even cares whether or not the pieces are played. His idea is, you may not understand it now, but that doesn't matter. Future generations will.
- 4.38 Now, after 1815, along with these family disputes that I mentioned, his deafness becomes increasingly severe, to the point where he can't really play anymore. He had all of these devices set up. He had this thing called a hearing trumpet, this thing you would stick in your ear, and apparently it would focus the sound and allow you to hear a little bit better. Maybe it would amplify the sound somewhat. It's not clear that it actually did anything. And he had these methods of putting a stick on the soundboard of his piano and then putting his head against the stick so the vibrations would be

transmitted into his head somehow, just increasingly desperate to be able to hear. But of course, he can't. And it's becoming problematic. And I think it's clearly affecting his compositions as well. The sound of the piece starts to become really, in many instances, unrelentingly harsh.

- 4.39 You might wonder, how is Beethoven able to compose despite the fact that he was becoming profoundly deaf? How is that even possible? We have this idea that a composer sits at a piano and maybe improvises and comes up with a melody and then writes it down on paper using music notation, but it doesn't really work that way. In fact, many composers, perhaps even most of them throughout the Baroque and Classical years did not primarily write at a keyboard. They wrote at a desk. How can you do that?
- 4.40 Well, what you do is during your training as a composer, you absorb the language of harmony, of counterpoint. You develop the capacity to hear inwardly what you're writing. You can certainly hear the intervals, you can hear the chords. And once you know the harmonic patterns, the chord progressions, and the ways of joining chords together, the ways of joining tones together to make a line, it becomes rather abstract in many respects. You don't actually need to hear the acoustic reality of it to know what it's going to sound like and to know what the effect of it is going to be.
- 4.41 So Beethoven was, like pretty much every composer at that time, trained in that way. And this is still extraordinarily common not every composer writes at a desk, but many do. Even though he was profoundly deaf, he still knew what he was doing. He knew what it would sound like. Now, I think where you do start to see a real difference in terms of the sound of his music is the treatment of instruments and the orchestration, particularly in the later symphonies. You can certainly hear this in the Ninth Symphony, for example, which is just, at times, a deafening racket. It's so intense. It's so unruly sounding. It's so constantly brow beating the listener with its rhythmic savagery, but it's also at the same time profoundly powerful.
- 4.42 So this is his late style, and not only does it translate into a violence in the sound, but also in increasingly just completely exploding all of these balanced, symmetrical Classical forms. We talked about how in the third symphony, the Eroica, he's already starting to do that. He's already starting to drastically expand the bounds of what these forms can do. So they're no longer these well-bred, symmetrical forms with a predictable trajectory to them. He's writing things that are quite a lot longer, quite a lot more complicated, and in which there's this implacable dramaturgical logic that's always pushing everything forward and taking all of these different ideas that contrast with one another and having these extraordinarily fascinating architectures emerge out of that.
- 4.43 So his late style is difficult to come to terms with in many respects, and it's perhaps exemplified by a piece called the Grosse Fuge, and that is a work for string quartet. So Beethoven, in his last year, starts to write a series of string quartets that are quite odd.

His early string quartets predictably follow the Classical model of a four-movement work, starting with a Sonata Allegro and so on. You have a scherzo, you have a slow movement, you have a rousing finale.

- 4.44 The late works, however, start to take on an increasingly strange form. They become enormously lengthy. Some of them are divided up into as many as 11 sections or movements, very short little movements. It seems as though Beethoven is, at that point, he's no longer adhering to Classical forms and Classical principles, but rather he seems to be investigating music itself. He seems to be thinking about the abstract potential of music. And well, what could you do that would be different? What could you do that would be a re-imagining of the experience of listening to a piece like this?
- 4.45 In his String Quartet, Opus 130, which is one of his very last works, he had this initial plan that the piece would end with a great fugue. Remember that the fugue is a form that we associate with Bach, with polyphonic music, where you have all of these independent voices. We heard the second contrapunctus from the Art of the Fugue yesterday. What we heard was a rather austere, very abstract piece.
- 4.46 You can be assured that Beethoven is not going to do that. He's not going to write something cool abstract. He writes this fugue that is initially meant to be the finale of this grand string quartet, and it is shockingly strange. It sounds apocalyptic. It has red hot emotional intensity. There are passages of it that are so complex, so virtuosic, so strangely written, seemingly in total defiance of the actual technique of string instruments that contemporary string said, "Forget it, this is unplayable. It's just chaotic noise."
- 4.47 And the reaction to this fugue, this finale to this late string quartet, was so unanimously and stridently negative that his publishers said to him, You have to write a different finale for this piece. This is going too far. It's not even playable. And quite uncharacteristically, because Beethoven was incredibly intransigent. He wasn't someone that you could say, you have to do this differently. For some reason, he relented in this instance, and he writes a new finale to the string quartet, which is much more sedate, much more in keeping with Classical principles. It's a nice enough piece, but it's nothing like this utterly wild and bizarre fugue.
- 4.48 This is where it gets a little bit tricky with historians and musicologists, it's like, well, what is the proper finale for the string quartet? Is it the one that Beethoven was pressured, perhaps bullied, into changing? Does that authentically represent his ultimate wishes for the piece? Did he himself think that maybe he had gone too far? Was he just bowing to pressure? We don't really know. So the piece is, it exists in two versions, one with the amended finale and one with the original fugue at the end.
- 4.49 I'm going to play you an excerpt of the fugue, and you can see for yourselves what it sounds like, but just a couple of notions about it. The first is that there are two main subjects in the expository section of the piece. The first is rather chromatic. It's an odd

fugue subject. Chromatic in the sense that it uses the black and the white notes of the piano. It uses these small intervals that are rather dissonant, rather unusual. It's not an obvious subject for a fugue by any means because it's harmonically quite ambiguous. It's not clear if you hear this subject exactly how it should be harmonized, what the chords should be, where it leads you. That's the first thing. He starts with this very strange, uncharacteristic motif.

- 4.50 Then the second thing is, he has this other motif that is surpassingly violent. It simply takes no account of string technique. It has these enormous leaps where you have to move a 10th or a 12th. These are huge intervals on the violin, which is not easy to do. You have to cross strings. It's very awkward. You have to shift your hand extremely rapidly in order to play these figures. And even today, this really pushes violin technique to its limits.
- 4.51 And more to the point, it's also a totally unsuitable subject for a fugue because it's got these gigantic intervals in it, and it's very hard to make a four-part conversation with something like that. But what he does is just utterly astonishing. I'm going to read you a few contemporary comments about the Grosse Fugue. So many performers, many commentators, critics, referred to it as exhausting, apocalyptic. My favorite is, it's an indecipherable horror. It defies categorization. It's filled with paradoxes. And one historian says that it's the most problematic single work in all of Beethoven's output.
- 4.52 Today, the critical consensus on this piece is quite a lot more positive. It's a fascinating work. Stravinsky, for example, said, "The Great Fugue now seems to be the most perfect miracle in music. It is also the most absolutely contemporary piece of music I know, and contemporary forever, hardly birthmarked by its age. The Great Fugue is in rhythm alone, more subtle than any music of my own century. I love it beyond everything." There's a little phrase in that quote from Stravinsky that is really important that I want you to hold on to. The idea that it's contemporary forever.
- 4.53 Okay, so that's an interesting concept. What exactly does that mean? There are pieces that, for one reason or another, always seem to have something new to say to us throughout the generations, throughout the ages. They don't get old. They don't become a mere relic of a forgotten time, but they have a quality of eternal newness to them. I don't know exactly what constitutes that quality. I don't know how you can find it. If you could bottle it up and sell it, that would be pretty fantastic, but it seems to be quite rare.
- 4.54 But there are pieces that, for one reason or another, seem to always speak to us anew and to have new things to say and to never never get old. Maybe it's that they have some a symbolic or an archetypal dimension to them. Maybe it's their unwillingness to adhere to norms, their tendency to strike out in bold new directions and open entire new esthetic vistas for listeners? I don't know.

- 4.55 But whatever it is—the spirit that lies behind this work, its indomitable character, its strangeness, its visionary quality, his willingness to do things that are utterly out of step with what anybody else is doing, that's a quality that has persisted. So let's listen to the first five or so minutes of the Grosse Fugue. Remember, this is a 15-minute long piece, so this is just going to be an excerpt from the work.
- 4.56 [musical piece]
- 4.57 Okay. It's so insane. That is such an insane piece. That was written 200 years ago, and it sounds absolutely contemporary. It sounds disturbing. It sounds bizarre, still. That was written, what, 30 years after the death of Mozart? Not so long afterwards. So we're a long way from the symmetry, the poise, the grace, the simplicity, the elegance of that style. We're a very long way from the Opus 18 F major string quartet by Beethoven that we heard earlier. So that's the trajectory, the artistic esthetic trajectory that happens in these pieces. It's astonishing. And it was profoundly disrupting for his successors.
- 4.58 Beethoven, in his own lifetime even, becomes this legendary figure, this almost God-like creator who's doing things that are incomprehensible. And this has never been done before in the art of music, not to this degree. And he gets quite a reputation in the last years of his life—becomes a cultural celebrity, even though he's quite withdrawn, his fame spreads all over Europe. And at his funeral, there are thousands of people showing up in Vienna to pay respects to him.
- 4.59 So he's a very, very new type of artist, very new type of figure. You have to also mention the achievements of his last years. I mean, this is clearly an extreme piece, but we also have works like the Ninth Symphony, which has that famous choral finale, the "Ode to Joy," which is this profoundly humanist work where he's saying to the audience directly that all men shall be brothers, that he's trying to point towards a universal brotherhood, a music that is addressed to everybody, a music that can potentially unite people. You'd think that that might not necessarily be coherent with the piece that we just heard.
- 4.60 But that was his idea. And his idea was that in time, even though this is disturbing and disrupting and not understood, in time, it will be understood. In time, everyone will acknowledge the greatness of these pieces. In fact, that is what happened. Before we end the lecture on Beethoven—we'll take a few questions, too—I want to go backwards and play you a piece from his early period. This is a piece from 1798, so we're going back 27 years. Now, partly to contrast it with the Grosse Fugue, but also partly to demonstrate that even in these very early works that clearly are indebted to the Classical masters that came before him. Even there, there are a number of features that are very distinctive, that are distinctively his.
- 4.61 This is an excerpt from the Sonata in C minor for piano, which is nicknamed the Pathetic, the Pathetic. So named because of its rather melancholic character. The

middle movement, I think, is one of the most beautiful things Beethoven ever wrote. It is just an exquisite little piece.

- 4.62 Now, typically, if you were to write a slow movement in a piano sonata, you would use this, what's called an ABA form. It's very, very common in Classical music. You have an opening gesture, an opening material, and you have a contrasting middle section which gives you a little bit of variety in the piece. Then at the end, you round it off by recapitulating what we heard at the outset. You restate the A section. The B section will typically contrast in many different respects from the A section. It'll be maybe in a different tempo. It might be in a different key. It might have a different melodic or rhythmic underpinning. The idea is you have a well-rounded symmetrical form, but with enough variety in it by dint of this contrasting middle section to give you a bit of a sense of trajectory, a bit of a sense of movement.
- 4.63 Beethoven typically takes that relatively simple, straightforward form and does something quite individual with it. So this piece has a rather ambiguous form. It sort of looks like an ABA form, but it also looks like a variation form because there's this melody that keeps returning—returns three times over the course of the piece, and each time in a slightly different form, with a different complement, a different rhythm, different texture. And also, he has two contrasting episodes instead of just one. So that means it's kind of a rondo, but it's also kind of a variation form, but it's also kind of an ABA form. It's all of those things at the same time.
- 4.64 Beethoven is not just merely taking these Classical forms as a cupboard that you fill up with stuff and just saying, okay, that's the form. No, he's always trying to push them a little bit farther, trying to do something new with them, even in these very early works. Here is the middle movement of the Pathétique Sonata, and this is from 1798.
- 4.65 [musical piece]
- 4.66 It's so beautiful. That's the work of the 28-year-old Beethoven. Just an exquisite piece, profoundly moving. I never get tired of hearing it.
- 4.67 So Beethoven lived to be 56, so that's quite a lot older than Mozart ever got to be. But he wrote quite a lot less music. We were talking about Bach, Mozart, and Haydn as all being workaholics, all being hyper-productive. Well, Beethoven's output, he was no slouch in the productivity department, but it was about a quarter of what Mozart wrote, maybe even a bit less.
- 4.68 The reason for that is not it's not that he was working less hard. It's that he can no longer just adhere to these repetitive forms and write dozens or even hundreds of the same type of piece over and over again. Haydn wrote his 107 symphonies. Beethoven wrote nine. You can't write a piece like the Ninth Symphony 100 times. It's a unique piece. You can't iterate a form like that. You can do it once. Then that starts to become more and more a motif in romanticism. We'll stop there now. Are there any questions?

- 4.69 Do you think that there's morality in music?
- 4.70 I suppose there is to the degree that if you're a composer and you're creating something, you're offering something to other people, and you're suggesting that they spend their time on it.
- 4.71 There are different ways you can do that, of course. You can be motivated by a desire for attention. You can be motivated by a desire to appear better than other people, or you can be motivated by a desire to advance your own career interests, or you can be attempting to produce something that could be ennobling, that could elevate your audience. To that degree, I believe there is an ethics of composition. You can think in terms of what is the effect that you are having or hoping to have on your audience? What is it that you ultimately want them to experience?
- 4.72 It's not that the composer writing trivial or third-rate music or who's interested in having a popular success above all else is necessarily behaving unethically. But you do make choices as an artist, and you are proposing that people spend their time in a particular way, and you are doing something—you're putting something into the world that changes the world, literally. In that sense, I suppose one could argue that there's a responsibility that goes along with that. But I don't know that I would be able or willing to venture too much farther into that question, which is quite complex and continually shifting. That's about the best I can do for now.
- 4.73 So this question is about the comment you made that despite Beethoven's tortured childhood, that because he was a creative genius, his success was inevitable. A factor in that was that the proliferation of publishing with the scores. Now in the modern age, we have YouTube and you can go viral. There is that analogy. But also in the modern age, it seems there's more temptations for those who are miserable, like Kurt Cobain is the obvious case study. Do you think these archetypal, tortured creative geniuses, are they more or less likely to have success inevitably in 2024?
- 4.74 Oh, that is such an interesting question. You mentioned Kurt Cobain. There's a lot of rock stars that destroy themselves very rapidly: Amy Winehouse, Jimi Hendrix, Jim Morrison, Janis Joplin, all dying at around 27. It's called the 27 Club. I think part of that is explained by the fact that if you take young, sensitive, creative people and push them into a situation where they are given vast wealth, vast opportunities, and fame on a level that is almost unimaginable— all of that in their early 20s—how many people are psychologically equipped to withstand that?
- 4.75 That kind of fame, I mean, we talked a little bit about Mozart's childhood and how he was paraded as almost like a monkey in a cage to all of these crowned heads. But if you think about what someone like Kurt Cobain went through, who was actually never intending to become a massive celebrity. He was a creative person who happened to be born at a time when the music industry was at its absolute zenith, and he happened to be working in a style that resonated massively with people. But those were, in a

sense, almost accidental circumstances. It's not something that he was aspiring towards.

- 4.76 And the same happened with a lot of these creative people. They were pursuing ideas that were important to them and making things that they wanted to make, and it happened to resonate with the wider culture, and they happened to have the good fortune or the bad fortune, perhaps, to have that be noticed. There's a degree of contingency in all of this. It was by no means inevitable that any of these people would become famous. Jim Morrison, the lead singer of The Doors, who died at 27, was effectively a totally disenfranchised Beatnik—a bum living in Venice Beach, California, who happened to be not only very creative, but extremely charismatic and very good-looking, and that got noticed. And it killed him. It killed him. He couldn't handle that.
- 4.77 So, yes, the possibilities of mechanical sound reproduction, the vast expansion of the audience for music has certainly made it possible to reach an enormous number of people and to become famous extremely quickly. Some people, some rare people are able to handle that and not completely lose their minds, but they are definitely in the minority. So you wouldn't wish that on most people. That starts to be—in a sense, this is a romantic archetype that we're still completely infatuated with. This is a 19th century concept of what an artist is.
- 4.78 Remember that in the Baroque, the Renaissance, and certainly the Middle Ages and beyond, going backwards in history, artists were artisans. There's a difference between an artist and an artisan. An artisan is somebody who learns a set number of tools and techniques and a repertory, if you like, of skills that have been handed down, and they exercise those tools and techniques. They don't fundamentally question them. It's like being an expert cobbler, for example. There was not a massive categorical difference between a sculptor and any other tradesperson or artisan.
- 4.79 The romantic idea gives us this image of the artist that is fundamentally outside of society, fundamentally able to do things that nobody else can do. We have this idea of the creative genius, which is, again, a 19th-century idea. And we're still in that. Because that's our perspective and because that's the prevailing attitude, it's hard for us to imagine things any other way. But there's no reason to imagine that that archetype of the tortured creative genius will exist forever.
- 4.80 In fact, I think there are already cracks appearing in that, partly because the expansion of what's available on the internet is so colossal, it's so vast that we no longer have a horizon that's dotted with these majestic, mountain-like, towering figures in our culture. We have our foothills, people that are famous for a while, but then the culture rapidly moves on, and there are more of them. It's very hard to keep up with it. So where that will lead is anybody's guess. I don't know. But anyway, that's my rambling answer to your question.

Lecture 5: Franz Schubert

At a glance — Franz Schubert.

- 5.1 Would you take this deal? The assurance of an early death, but immortality through the seemingly inexhaustible fruits of your genius, that was Schubert's lot in life. Franz Schubert. We're going to talk about him today. Schubert died at the age of 31. That's even younger than Mozart. But he was similarly productive. The thing about Schubert is that his demise came so quickly. And it was so tragic that it's hard not to retrospectively view his work through that lens.
- 5.2 You listen to the early works with their incredible freshness, their beauty, their radiance, and you hear them as though they're tinged with this sadness because you know where he's heading. That's not just our present day historical perspective. It's not just a sentimental fundamental cast that we have on this music. Schubert was aware of it himself. He had this strange sense throughout his life that he was not destined to live for very long.
- 5.3 Similarly to Mozart, many people have wondered, just what on earth would he have done had he lived twice as long? It's very tempting to ask that question, particularly in the case of Schubert, because his late works are really quite astonishingly magnificent and forward-thinking and visionary in many respects. And you just want to try to peak beyond that horizon. What if he'd had six more months? What if he'd had another year? What if he had 10 more years? Of course, it's an unanswerable question.
- 5.4 But what happened with Schubert that I think is so interesting is he partly killed himself through overwork, he partly exhausted himself. There's something of that in Mozart as well. There's this idea that he has this turbulent mind that is unstoppably generating ideas all the time. He can't even keep up with them. It's this almost creative, I don't know what you would call it, creative obsession. He can't stop writing, and he pushes himself to the point of utter, utter exhaustion.
- 5.5 To a degree, that's what happened with Bach. Now, Bach lived quite a lot longer. I believe he was 64 when he died. Oh, and by the way, there's a story about that. Bach ruined his eyesight through obsessive work, working by a candlelight, working in dim light throughout his entire life, and started to have a lot of eye problems at the end of his life. Well, it was an English quack-doctor, actually, who killed him.
- 5.6 There was an oculist from England who was traveling around Europe, promising miracle cures for people who were afflicted with eye problems. And word got around to him that the Cantor Bach in Leipzig was suffering from such a condition, and this oculist agreed to operate on Bach. And of course, his techniques were complete fiction, and he probably knew this. This was a complete fraud doctor and managed to kill Bach through a botched eye operation with no anesthetic, of course. So you can imagine the suffering that he must have endured.

- 5.7 But there's a thread in all of this. These composers, they have this gift, but it's also not a gift in a sense. The compulsion to work yourself to death because you have all of these ideas and you can't stop them. There's something of that in Schubert, but in an even more intense, even more extreme form. Schubert would he'd sit down and write a piece with extraordinary facility, extraordinary rapidity. And the second it was done, he'd grab another sheet of music paper and start another one. He did this his entire life, and he worked with obsessive regularity and at tremendous speed.
- 5.8 The young Schubert was, like all the other composers we've mentioned so far, extraordinarily precocious. It was very clear from a very early age that he was uncommonly gifted. His teachers were astounded by his facility, by the rapidity with which he could learn to play the piano and learn all the basics of musical composition. His professor at college said, "I have nothing more I can possibly teach him. He's already been taught by God." This was the idea. This is like the idea that this is an unexplainable phenomenon.
- 5.9 So Schubert was so obsessed with his creative faculties, with this constant desire to create that he devoted himself to it 100%. There was no room in his life for anything else. In fact, he neglected everything else. Even though he only lived to be 31, in his later years, he became remarkably disheveled, had terrible health, didn't look after himself, never married, no children. It's the same thing as what we said with Beethoven. There's this sense that there's no room for anything else.
- 5.10 But it didn't just stop there. It didn't just stop with his neglect of his own self and his own personal circumstances. He also neglected his professional circumstances to a large degree. He didn't really have any professional success during his lifetime. So that's another thing that really sets Schubert apart from Mozart and Beethoven, who did have public careers, who were celebrated and famous within their lifetimes. Schubert did have some minor successes, but for the most part, it was elusive for him. Most of his compositions were not performed by anybody during his lifetime, and the ones that were, were not particularly successful.
- 5.11 For example, throughout his early '20s, Schubert composed a long series of theatrical works. Some of them are operas, most of them are Singspiel. The Singspiel is a type of form that's related to opera. We spoke about this a little bit yesterday already, but the idea is basically that large sections of it consist of spoken dialog. You have ordinary theatrical interludes, and then there are some musical sections, but it's not all scored to music, so it has more in common with a musical. He absolutely threw himself into writing these. He wrote something like, I think, 13 of these massive works in his 20s, and they weren't successful.
- 5.12 So he hoped that he would be able to earn enough money through these productions to become financially independent and be able to make a name for himself as a composer. That didn't work. So instead, he devoted himself to genres that were less public in their fundamental orientation. Schubert wrote hundreds and hundreds of

chamber music pieces, songs, mainly, and short little piano pieces as well, hundreds of them.

- 5.13** And he completely redefined the art of the German art song, which is known as the Lied, L-I-E-D. And the plural form of that is Lieder. And that is a genre that is related to the song, but it's a specifically German tradition of art song. And the idea in the Lied, L-I-E-D, is that you have a seamless bringing together of poetry, in this case, typically Romantic poetry and music. The music illustrates what's going on in the poem and amplifies it. And there's a total symbiosis of music and literature in these works. And nobody excelled at this more than Schubert. In fact, the cornerstone of his body of work really lies in his Lieder.
- 5.14** So just to give you a little bit of a context and orientation, Schubert died in 1828, one year after Beethoven. He was born in 1797. So that's a remarkably short lifespan. His life largely overlaps with that of Beethoven. So he's born around the time that Beethoven's early style is starting to cohere, and Beethoven is starting to become known as a musician, and he dies the year after Beethoven. So you could think that he's going to be like Beethoven, perhaps an outgrowth of the, essentially, Classical style. But Schubert takes his cues from the late works of Beethoven, with which he was very much familiar, and that's what forms the backbone of his style.
- 5.15** So Schubert is, in fact, through and through a Romantic in his fundamental esthetic orientation. Beethoven, you can speak of a transitional figure, somebody who is between the Classical and Romantic attitudes. But Schubert is definitely into the 19th century, the German 19th century, this idea of individual subjective expression, of the music being an expression of emotion, not simply the abstract potential music, but something that speaks of an individual, an individual suffering, an individual's passions. And like Beethoven, he was also interested in and in tune with the major philosophical and esthetic developments of his time. Very interested in authors like Goethe, for example, who certainly helped to form his esthetic stance.
- 5.16** So I'm at a bit of a loss talking about Schubert, because ideally, I would just quote from dozens pieces because they're so exquisite. It's difficult to single out individual works, actually. There's just such a long list. But nevertheless, we're going to hear some examples of his work, and hopefully that will at least provide an introduction to what he did.
- 5.17** So overall, we have approximately 600 pieces by Schubert—extensive song cycles, symphonies. Officially, he completed seven symphonies, but there are many fragments, many incomplete ones. The late ones are extraordinary. They clearly are pointing towards certainly late Romanticism, if not even farther beyond that. The early symphonies are him trying to find his footing in this genre. They're not such perfect works. I think they're very nice. They're fun to listen to, but they're very repetitive. They're not particularly distinguished. Well, after all, he was extremely young at the time, so we can cut him some slack. But there is a huge development that occurs

between the very early pieces, the early symphonies, the early string quartets, and what he was able to do in the later years of his life.

- 5.18** He wrote many string quartets, hundreds of pieces of chamber music, including the famous Trout Quintet, which is a simply exquisite piece. Really encourage all of you to listen to that work. And the String Quintet, which he completed only two months before his death. The String Quintet is a 50-minute long piece for two violins, viola, and two cellos, and absolutely sublime work.
- 5.19** Why did he die so young? Well, overwork, certainly. There's a sense that perhaps over an individual's lifetime, you have a set amount of things to say. You have a certain quantity of talent that's allotted to you, and you can compress that or you can expand it. And Schubert just blurted it all out very rapidly, and he was just spent at the end of his life, just done. But he also, well, he died of syphilis, which at the time was not a nice way to go, and he suffered terribly. And that started to affect him certainly in the last four or five years of his life. He knew that he was ill, and he knew that there was probably not going to be a cure for him.
- 5.20** So remember, this is the output of a compulsive creator, of somebody who simply cannot stop generating ideas all the time. And with that, what you do see is there's an unevenness to the output, certainly. Not everything that he wrote is at the same level. I mentioned earlier that the early symphonies, for example, are less distinguished. One of the things you notice, if you listen to the first three symphonies of Schubert, he certainly had a gift for melody. There's no question there. He was certainly, I think, as gifted as Mozart, perhaps even more. His melodies are so distinctive. They're so characterful. They're so beautiful. But he had no gift for development.
- 5.21** That's something that really distinguishes Beethoven. His ability to take completely uninteresting material, like that string quartet we listened to, and spin that into this massive, enormously involving musical drama that just pulls you in. It's completely gripping. Schubert's very different. He's not so strong in large-scale forms, not in the way that Beethoven was. He's not so gifted at writing a continuous 10 or 15-minute long movement and taking you through all of these these different dramatic turns. What he is extraordinarily gifted at is setting a mood, setting an atmosphere, creating an intense expression in his music, and inventing melodies that are simply unforgettable.
- 5.22** So this is not a Beethovenian genius in the sense of being primarily interested in the trajectory of a work and the movement of a work over time. But he's somebody who just had a ceaseless flow of remarkable ideas. And consequently, he's really at his strongest in these shorter forms, the Lied form, for example. Now, we've talked about the fact that in Beethoven's slow movements, or in a lot of slow movements in Classical music for that matter, you frequently see this ABA form. There's an initial idea, contrasting middle idea, and then a return to the initial idea at the end.

- 5.23** Now, that ABA form is also referred to as Lied form. And the reason for that is a lot of songs follow that essential pattern. It's a very simple approach to form. A thing, a different thing, and then a return to the initial thing. It's like you have unity, but you also have a bit of variety. And it's a framework that you can use and fill with pretty much anything you want. So that is a form that Schubert uses quite a lot. And the other advantage, I suppose, working in that form is that it doesn't require a lot of time for its elaboration. You can write a two-minute piece, three-minute piece, four-minute piece with this formal envelope, and it can work quite well.
- 5.24** I don't want to discount the achievement of his later years because he did write a number of extensive and enormously impressive, more discursive type of pieces in the last years of his life, his late piano sonatas, for example, or the string quintet, which I mentioned earlier. But other works, such as the Trout Quintet, just they're so repetitive. He'll state a theme, an exquisite theme. You're utterly charmed by it. You're utterly drawn to it. And he'll repeat it again, the second time, and a third time, and a fourth time. And a lot of commentators, musicians, historians, and so on have tended to criticize this aspect of his work and say, he just didn't know how to develop. He didn't know what to do with his material. It's too repetitive.
- 5.25** I don't buy that. I think that it's so exquisite that it doesn't matter. And there's a quote by Stravinsky. He talks about this. He was asked by his friend Robert Craft, "Well, what do you make of Schubert, what do you make of the amount of repetition in his music?" And he said, "What does it matter if I fall asleep if when I wake up, I am in heaven?" He also said that the melodies of Schubert are so beautiful. It doesn't matter. They can withstand that amount of repetition. And in fact, according to Stravinsky, I keep quoting from Stravinsky, but he was very insightful, he's the only composer who can get away with that, who can write melodies so perfect that they can withstand unaltered repetition, and they still work.
- 5.26** So let me tell you a few things about Schubert's life and how exactly he went about his work. So this is a quotation from a biography of Schubert written by Marcel Schneider, a French author. He writes, "Schubert worked with exemplary regularity every morning, from 6:00 to 7:00 to noon or 1:00, every day. As soon as he had finished a composition, he started immediately on another one. This disengagement from the completed work, the lack of enthusiasm for the object achieved are characteristic of the creative mind, whose activity constantly renews itself, deriving fresh impetus from the successive creations to which it gives life and from which it withdraws as soon as each one is completed."
- 5.27** Now, that is actually rather typical of creative people. This is a pattern. They tend not to be terribly interested in the things that they've completed. They want to move forward and do the next thing, and they're always most engaged with the thing they're presently working on. So what that indicates is that it's really the process of creation that is important. It's not necessarily the finished product. It's always the, "what's the

next thing going to be? What can I do next that will be different? What can I do next that will be a new, fresh idea?" And that's always the thing that seems to drive these hyper-creative people forward, to the extent that they just forget about the earlier pieces.

- 5.28** So let's talk a little bit about Schubert's style. Now, we've heard a lot of different stylistic and esthetic approaches so far. We heard the sublime abstraction, the incredibly beautiful and technically unassailable late works of Bach that pushed counterpoint to its absolute limits. We heard the emotional violence, the extremism, the turbulence of Beethoven. We've heard the symmetry, the balance, the grace of Mozart, and the joviality, and the humor of Haydn. Schubert's early music presents us with a peaceful, heavenly serenity that is quite addictive. It has a charming uncomplicated innocence to it. It's absolutely affecting. There's something so direct about it, something so just absolutely childlike, in a sense, but a child of genius. But it's not simple music. In fact, it's ultimately deeply sophisticated.
- 5.29** What starts to happen is after Schubert goes through that period in his early 20s, where he's writing that long sequence of unsuccessful operas. At a certain point, he decides, it's enough. I'm not going to do this anymore. I'm not going to try to achieve any worldly success. I'm not going to try to become a famous, wealthy composer. At the same time, that's when his health really starts to become a bit of an issue. The work starts to change as well. Starts to move out of this early, cheerful, radiant serenity that you see in so many of the early pieces towards something rather darker.
- 5.30** And the later pieces seem to point towards an ultimate inevitable dissolution, a slow, steady, consistent march towards death. But not a terrifying, hellish, torturous death, but one of a peaceful resolution of earthly troubles. Something to look forward to, perhaps. Something that would deliver him of his suffering. And that's really the polar opposite of the attitude that Beethoven expresses in his work, where it's, "I'm going to ultimately emerge victorious. I'm not going to be crushed by fate. I'm going to transcend that." Schubert seems to accept and also to anticipate his fate with a certain degree of equanimity and almost this resignation. And that is something that comes across, not merely metaphorically, but quite directly in his later pieces, and particularly in a song cycle called *Die Winterreise*, Winter Journey. So I'm going to play you an excerpt from that.
- 5.31** So Schubert was a composer obsessed with writing song cycles. And song cycles are not merely a set of individual songs, but rather they have an overarching narrative structure, and the poems are connected to each other. So in the case of *Winterreise*, you have a long collection of poems that are all centered around a single theme. The theme, of course, is winter, but winter is a metaphor. It's used metaphorically as a stillness, a kind of death. And that is exemplified in the opening song. Now, I will read the lyrics for that. The poem was written by the poet Wilhelm Müller. And you can see perhaps why this resonated so much with Schubert towards the end of his life.

- 5.32 "A stranger, I arrived here. A stranger, I go hence. May was good to me, with many a bunch of flowers. The girl spoke of love, her mother even of marriage. Now the world is dismal, the path veiled in snow. For my journey, I cannot choose my own time. I must pick the way myself through this darkness. My moon-cast shadow acts as my companion. And on the white meadow, I look for a deer's footprints. Why should I stay longer until they drive me away? Let stray dogs howl outside the master's house. Love loves to rove. God made it so. From one to the next. Sweetheart, 'Good night. I will not disturb your dreams. That would spoil your rest. You must not hear my footsteps. Soft, softly shut the doors. As I leave, I shall write good night. Upon the gate for you so that you may see I have been thinking of you.'"
- 5.33 This is a metaphorical walk through the snow that is a march towards ultimate dissolution. But it's not, again, a terrifying one. It's sad, but there's a certain resignation in it. This piece is called Gute Nacht, Good Night, and it is the opening song from the Winterreise cycle of 1827. That's the year before Schubert died.
- 5.34 [musical piece]
- 5.35 This inevitable, unstoppable march through the snow is reflected in the rhythm of the music, which is unhurried. It's not particularly fast. It's not particularly slow. It's just a regular, indomitable rhythm of walking forward towards this ultimate point, and Schubert knows where it is. There's an interesting feature in this piece, which is that you might have noticed that the mood brightens a little bit just before the end. It moved from a minor to a major key temporarily. That's the point where Schubert is talking about, I mustn't disturb your sleep, and he's being silent. He doesn't want to wake this object of his affection. And that's characteristic of the dramatic effects and expressive effects you get in his music. He's very sensitive to that.
- 5.36 This shifting to a major key could be either a reflection of a resignation of peacefulness, accepting as fate. It cannot be changed. Or perhaps it could be ironic. It could be deliberately going against the rather dour emotional tenor of the poem. But in any case, it doesn't last for very long because right before the end, it switches back to minor again. And then we're back to this, the expression of the opening of the piece.
- 5.37 So there's lots of very subtle ways that the music can paint or illustrate the poem. And he's an unsurpassed master of doing that, of conveying the mood, the emotion of a text. Many people consider Winterreise to be one of the most perfect artworks created in the musical canon. One of the things that strikes me the most about it is how direct and simple it is. It's very easy to listen to. It's melodic. It has a certain amount of repetition. The rhythms are uncomplicated. The textures are straightforward. And yet it's deeply, deeply moving. So I think that's part of the reason why Schubert remains certainly one of the most popular and widely listened to composers of the Classical and Romantic eras. It's uncomplicated. It's immediately affecting. It speaks directly to you. It's very direct.

- 5.38 We talked about the fact that Schubert had given up really all professional ambitions, all ambitions also in terms of his personal life. And around 1824, he does have a few adventures. He falls in love with the Countess of Esterhazy. Remember I said yesterday that that name would keep coming up? Well, all of these composers, Austrian or otherwise, seem to have had dealings with the Esterhazy family, this noble family that promoted artists, and Schubert was no exception. The love affair was from the start, but nevertheless, he created a number of works that were certainly in tribute to her and also dedicated a late piece, which I would love to be able to play for you, but we're just limited in time, unfortunately. But there's a piece called the Fantasia in F Minor for a piano duet. Absolutely exquisite work that was dedicated to the Countess Caroline, Esterhazy.
- 5.39 Now, here's a quote from one of Schubert's letters that tells you a little bit about his character and about what his life was like. So he writes, "I feel I am one of the most miserable and unfortunate men in the world. Picture to yourself, one whose health can never be reestablished, who from sheer despair, commits fault after fault instead of amending his life. Picture to yourself a man whose high hopes are dead, to whom from henceforth love and friendship have nothing to offer but pain, who is even no longer aglow with the love of beauty. And tell me if that man is not forever wretched. Each night when I go to sleep, I wish that I may never again awake, and each morning recalls the suffering of yesterday. So joyless and friendless my days would pass if Schwind [that was his friend at the time] did not often look in to take care of me."
- 5.40 Pretty bleak. What amazes me is that despite this very black outlook, his productivity was always undimmed. It's pretty incredible. Now, he might have been slightly exaggerating. He might have been wanting to manipulate the person he was writing to. He might have been—who knows? Maybe it's not completely sincere. You can't always take the documents of composers and their declarations at face value. There's often more to it than what you read, but nevertheless, it's a pretty remarkable letter.
- 5.41 So remember, we said that Schubert was the consummate master of not only the Lied but also of the song cycle. And I'd like to just make a very quick distinction there before we move on, which is that it be easy to just call these pieces songs, but it's not exactly the same thing. The Lied, again, is a specifically German association. What you get is this intense melding together of music and words, and a quasi-dramatic quality also. And it's associated with a very intimate form of expression. In the Lied tradition, you're addressing either yourself as a performer. It's music that is written for people to play and to have a private experience while playing, or else you're perhaps addressing a small gathering of close friends.
- 5.42 So this repertoire was typically played in salons or in private residences. You didn't have recitals the way we have now. You didn't file into a concert hall 600, 700 people, 1,000 people, to hear somebody on stage singing with a pianist. No, these songs were made for amateurs to play for their own amusement or for a small, intimate gathering. And

that was where Schubert really shined in that very close, very direct form of expression. Not these grand public statements, which was again where Mozart excelled. The art of Schubert is much more intimate in its scope.

- 5.43** Now, just to distinguish Lied, the Lied tradition from song. Song is a much more broad term. In a sense, all it really means is that it's a composition with a solo voice. But a song can be anything. It can be a popular song; it can be a folk song; it can be an art song. There are many, many different sub-categorizations, whereas Lied is a very specific concept, and typically it involves a solo voice plus a pianist.
- 5.44** I'd like to play you another vocal composition by Schubert. This is actually quite an early piece, but it's also one of his most famous compositions. So this dates from 1815, when Schubert was 18 years old, and it's based on a poem by Goethe. So this text is called *Der Erlkönig*, or the Erlking. And what that means—well, it's a figure from German mythology. The figure of the Erlking is the king of the elves, lives in the forest and snatches up young children and drags them away, a pretty horrible concept.
- 5.45** So Schubert was drawn to this poem by Goethe, I suppose, because of its inherent dramatism and its expressiveness and the rather upsetting topic, which he magnificently translates into music at only 18 years of age. So let me read you the text, translated in English, the text by Goethe, and then we'll hear the song.
- 5.46** "Who rides so late through night and wind. It is the father with his child. He has the boy well in his arm. He holds him safely. He keeps him warm. My son, why do you hide your face in fear? Father, do you not see the Erlking? The Erlking with crown and cape? My son, it is just a streak of fog. You, dear child, come, go with me. Very beautiful games I will play with you. Many colorful flowers are on the beach. My mother has many a golden robe. My father, my father, do you not hear what the Erlking quietly promises me? Be calm. Stay calm, my child. Through dry leaves the wind is sighing."
- 5.47** "Do you, fine boy, want to go with me? My daughters shall wait on you finally. My daughters lead the nightly dance and rock and dance and sing to bring you in. My father, my father, and don't you see there the Erlking's daughters in the gloomy place? My son, my son, I see it clearly. There shimmer the old willows so gray. I love you. Your beautiful form excites me, and if you're not willing, then I will use force. My father, my father, he's touching me now. The Erlking has done me harm. It horrifies the father. He swiftly rides on. He holds the moaning child in his arms, reaches the farm with great difficulty. In his arms, the child was dead."
- 5.48** Now, the story here is: the child sees something in the forest that frightens him. The father is trying to distract him, saying, "No, it's not real—it's just the wind." But the child sees it and sees it again. And he keeps repeatedly bringing this up and saying, "Don't you see it? Don't you see it? He's trying to get me." And the father repeatedly tries to dispel it. Until it's too late. They're riding on horseback towards the farm that they're trying to get to, which I suppose represents the place of safety, that if they

were able to reach it on time, the child would survive. But unfortunately, that does not happen. And by the time they get there, the child is already dead. He's been killed by this mythological creature in the forest.

- 5.49** So what Schubert does with this that is really ingenious is that he creates a song that implicitly has four different characters, four different voices in it. Again, this is a Lied. This is for a solo voice plus piano. But the solo voice has to incarnate four different characters. So there's the narrator, who's recounting the story. There's the voice of the boy. There's the father. And there's the figure of the Erlking. How does Schubert do that? How does he create this multiplicity of different characters with only one singer? Well, he keeps changing the register of the voice. The boy, predictably, is in the upper register of the singer's range. When it's the father speaking, it's a more, it's a lower, it's a more grave tone of voice that's used. And he has these different characterizations for the different characters.
- 5.50** It's a song that actually takes great skill to perform because the singer has to switch between four different personas as they're singing it. So let's listen to this early work of Schubert's from 1815. I'll just point out before we hear it that this was written in a few hours in one afternoon by an adolescent.
- 5.51** [musical piece]
- 5.52** That's quite hard to play. You might have noticed in the piano part, the pianist has to play these octaves at incredible speed. You have to do that the entire time. It's quite exhausting. And the vocal part is not easier. But it's a wonderful piece of music. So that's a very early piece of Schubert. And I'm going to stop with one other excerpt from his works.
- 5.53** Now, I mentioned that Schubert wrote some remarkable pieces at the very end of his life, and foremost among them, perhaps, is the String Quintet in C major, which is really a high water mark in Classical or Romantic chamber music. This is an enormously lengthy composition. It's 50 minutes long. It has the most exquisite slow movement that radiates an exquisite calm, repose, and serenity. It's very, very stable. Nothing much happens in it. And it has this very, very simple texture.
- 5.54** I just want to play you a couple of minutes of this piece. You have to hear the whole thing. This is an adagio that in a typical performance, lasts around 18 minutes. It's quite an amazing composition. But this will just give you an idea. This is from the slow movement of the String Quintet in C major by Schubert, written when he was extremely ill, two months before his death.
- 5.55** [musical piece]
- 5.56** I think that's just really quite hypnotizing and very beautiful. Any questions about Franz Schubert before we move on?

- 5.57 When listening to a piece of music with a particular composer, how much do you think a listener would benefit from understanding the larger body of work by a particular composer, or maybe even the composers before that as well?
- 5.58 Thank you. It certainly makes a difference. Actually, I can tell you an anecdote about that. I have a friend who teaches composition in the USA, and whenever she encounters a new composer, someone whose works she hasn't listened to before, she makes a habit of listening to the entire body of work. This is probably a little bit on the exceptional side. Not everybody does that, but she will listen to everything. She says that she can't get a sense of their accomplishment unless she does that, and she can't put the works into their proper context. I think one thing that's really important to grasp also is that it's very difficult to evaluate isolated individual works with no context.
- 5.59 It's very hard to know what you're hearing. It's very hard to know how they differ from other pieces that would have been written around the same time. It's very difficult to know what might be distinctive or exceptional about them. You can appreciate them on the level of, I enjoy it or I don't enjoy it, but you'll understand the phenomenon, I think, in greater depth if you have a broader picture of the works. But this is a lifetime goal. It's not something that you can do in a few days.
- 5.60 And that's, again, a reason why I encourage people always to adopt that longer view of art, that it's not about a single concert. It's not about having a single positive experience listening to recording. But it's something that you can construct over the course of your life, and you can return to these pieces and hear them differently because you know more about them or because you've heard other works in between. And it grows over time. That's one of the beautiful things, I think, about the progressive development of this relationship that you can have with art.
- 5.61 So, absolutely, you know what? It does benefit from that immeasurably. I can tell you some anecdotes about my own experience. I had a very very difficult time, actually, when I was younger, appreciating the vocal pieces of Bach, simply because at that time I didn't speak German. I didn't really understand the cultural or the historical context. I didn't particularly understand what it meant that Bach was a Lutheran, what that meant culturally, what that meant in terms of what the pieces were trying to do. All I heard was some certainly very beautiful pieces, but I didn't know what he was doing at all.
- 5.62 It wasn't really until I took the time to understand more about the time period, understand the reformation, all of the context surrounding that, and Bach's role also in taking the vulgar tongue of the day, the German language, and using that to set music as opposed to Latin and all of these other things that came into it. Then suddenly it clicked together and I understood it. I could enter into the expressive world of the pieces much more easily.

- 5.63 There's a video you can find on YouTube of the physicist Richard Feynman. Somebody asks him, "Doesn't all of your extensive knowledge about the physical world get in the way of your simple enjoyment of a flower or viewing the sky? Aren't you trapped into this eternal analytical mode of thinking, where you're always thinking about the reasons for these physical phenomena and what brings them about and why it is that we see the way we do, the cones in our eyes that allow us to see color, the interaction between the flower and the bee, all of these different things that go into it?"
- 5.64 And he says, "No, on the contrary, my understanding of these phenomena deepens my appreciation of them, and they strike me as even more mysterious and even more exquisite and even more beautiful because I know all of these things that are going on that make these things the way they are."
- 5.65 And I often get asked a variation on that question because a lot of what I do publicly and on my YouTube channel and in my teaching also is rather analytically oriented. We take pieces, we pull them apart, we show what makes them work, we show what the components are that go into a musical composition, and try to explain all of that. I'm often asked, "Doesn't that interfere with your simple enjoyment of a piece of music? Can't you ever just sit down and listen and not be always analyzing everything?" The answer is, "No, I can't. I can't shut that off because I hear everything that's going on. I can't stop it, but it has deepened my appreciation immeasurably."
- 5.66 So yes, that's a long answer to your question, but absolutely. And that's something that unfolds over time. And you don't have to take it to that degree. It doesn't have to become analytical. But even just as something as simple as just reading a little bit about the context, reading a little bit about the life of the composer, hearing a group of works, hearing not just one or two Schubert symphonies, but listening to all of them in sequence, for example. You could take—they're not terribly long pieces, but even if you took half an hour a day for a couple of weeks, you could do that. I certainly encourage everybody to do that. Thank you for the question.
- 5.67 When you talked about the life of these composers, you kept mentioning how they almost paid a price of sacrificing something very important to them in order to produce this greatness of music that they did. It seems like a theme throughout their lives that they sacrificed their health, their emotional stability, their romantic life, all of those things. Fast forward to today's society, it seems like we are so focused on our immediate gratification of things. I was wondering if you think that's a factor in why we don't produce the same level of greatness in music as it was back then.
- 5.68 There's a few components to that. The first thing is that there's clearly a thread running through the lives of all these composers, which is if you seek gratification and comfort, you're not going to be able to go as far. These composers all deferred those things, in some cases, indefinitely, in order to pursue this greater goal that they had. Anybody who pursues comfort, and that's their primary value, is going to be limited in terms of what they can achieve. I don't think that really changes.

- 5.69 So one of the things that I always get from reading biographies of composers and other artists is it's useful to read these stories and read about their lives just to get a sense of how difficult it must have been. You have this idea of genius that's passive. It's like, well, he was just born phenomenally gifted and so naturally. It involved genuine suffering in many instances, and also not just physically, not just in terms of the sheer stamina that it took to write all of these pieces and to neglect everything else, but also the capacity to go against the prevailing wind in your society. That's something that's very rare. Very few people do that. And it's not hard to see why.
- 5.70 It takes genuine bravery to do that. And genuine bravery is rare. These artists have all had it. They were all not only gifted, but phenomenally brave. So it's useful to return to the lives of these artists and just contemplate. Put yourself in their shoes and think about, well, would I have made those choices? What would that have been like? What would that have felt like?
- 5.71 Now, obviously, today we live in a phenomenally different society in every respect. Everybody we've looked at so far has been pre-Industrial Revolution. So there are some aspects of these lives that are not particularly atypical. I mean, obviously, medicine was in a much less advanced state than it is today. A lot of people still lived in essentially an agrarian context. The world was not as urbanized as it is now. I mean, there are many, many, many differences between then and now. And you will start to see a massive shift in the role of artists and the type of lives that they're tending to lead after the advent of the Industrial Revolution.
- 5.72 We'll talk a little bit about that tomorrow. We're going to look at two modern composers, Arnold Schoenberg and Igor Stravinsky. Their lives were certainly extraordinarily different from the ones we've looked at so far. I hope that answers your question.

Lecture 6: Frédéric Chopin & Franz Liszt

At a glance — Frédéric Chopin and Franz Liszt.

- 6.1** What we're doing in this lecture is looking at a very small selection of composers, and, of course, we have to do that because of the format. There's also the fact that I'm attempting to present a line of development and show what happens over the span of about 200 years in music history. But there are many key figures that I've had to leave out, unfortunately. Maybe I haven't had to, but I've chosen to leave them out. We didn't talk at all about Handel, for example. We didn't talk about Wagner at all, and Wagner is pretty key. It's simply not possible to get into all of these figures in-depth.
- 6.2** Today, I'm going to talk about two composers in one lecture, which is a bit of a stretch, but there's reasons for that. They have quite a lot in common, and they exemplify the Romantic spirit, perhaps better than anybody else. We're going to jump ahead now to Chopin and Liszt. Now, both of these figures are continuing to fascinate audiences worldwide. Their works are probably among the most performed pieces for piano that have ever been written. It's absolutely taken for granted that a professional pianist, a concert pianist today, is going to contend with their works.
- 6.3** So these are two absolutely towering figures of the 19th century. Now, again, their lives overlapped to a degree with those of Beethoven and Schubert. They're both born around the same time. They're approximately contemporaries. Chopin was born in 1810 and Liszt in 1811. Now, Liszt lived to be quite a lot older than Chopin—lived to be, I believe, 78 years old. Chopin had a very short life. He died at 39. But what I'm going to do is I'm going to talk about the points that these two artists had in common, what it was that they were both attempting to do, musically and esthetically, and we're going to listen to some of their characteristic works.
- 6.4** I had a phone conversation a few weeks ago with a pianist that I work with quite a lot, a cherished collaborator of mine, a really gifted artist, and we were talking about Chopin, coincidentally. She said something that I thought was really quite amazingly insightful, which she often does. It was that part of the reason why these composers are so popular and so relevant and so enduringly fascinating, and why they produce such extraordinary work, is that their push towards expanding and developing keyboard technique, the possibilities of the keyboard, that happened concurrently with advances in instrument design.
- 6.5** And in a sense, nobody has ever written better for the piano than these two composers. Nobody has ever exploited the possibilities of the keyboard with greater depth, with greater imagination, with a greater insight into what you can do with this instrument. And well, that has to do with the fact that they lived at precisely the right time for that to happen.

- 6.6 So I have to make a bit of a parenthetical remark here about the relationship between composers, performers, and instrument builders. You can think of this as a triangle, effectively, and all three components of that triangle have to function together in order to have a musical culture. Performers obviously need instruments in order to play. Composers obviously need performers in order for their works to be played. And all of those components have to be functioning properly.
- 6.7 The other thing is that throughout the 19th century, we talked about the fact that up to now, we've been talking about pre-Industrial Revolution figures. Around the middle of the 18th century, if not a little bit earlier, there starts to be a rapid change in the construction of musical instruments. During the Baroque and Classical eras, musical instruments are really optimized for performances in small rooms, for the most part. We don't yet have these large audiences in the same sense as what we today have, where you can have a concert hall where you have to play for 10,000 people, and perhaps even beyond.
- 6.8 In the 19th century, the concert halls start to become larger, the audiences start to expand, and you start to have a middle class also that is larger than it's ever been in history. There's a middle class that is better off and that has more leisure time, quite simply. And so there's a gradual rising of living standards that happens in the 19th century. And along with that, there are new techniques for manufacturing instruments, and not just manufacturing them, but in fact, mass manufacturing them.
- 6.9 So instrument manufacture is no longer simply a matter of individual artisans crafting individual instruments, but rather very, very large numbers of pianos, flutes, oboes, etc., being produced. And along with that comes more advanced techniques, and along with that comes instruments that have more technical possibilities. The range of the piano gradually expands to seven octaves.
- 6.10 And today, the range of the keyboard is seven octaves and a third. It's absolutely gigantic range. It covers the entire range of the orchestra, if not more. And these new larger grand pianos with their steel frame construction are extremely strong. You can have very long strings. You can have strings that are louder, that resonate more, that can fill a huge concert hall. And you can create quasi-orchestral effects with these instruments as well.
- 6.11 So compare that to, say, an 18th-century harpsichord. It's a very, very different animal. So they both are keyboard instruments. They have the same basic layout of the keys. They might have a slightly similar morphology, but it's a totally different proposition. So with these new instruments, you can easily fill a large concert hall with sound. You can project it all the way to the back of the hall. You can create these orchestral effects. You can push virtuosity to its absolute limits.
- 6.12 And Chopin and Liszt were both, in a sense, the perfect composers for the perfect time because they both had the imagination to push these instruments to their limits, but

they also had the technical resources to develop piano technique. So both of them were not only composers, they were also virtuoso performers. They were able to do things that nobody else could technically do, could not physically do.

- 6.13** So both of them were writing pieces that, in a sense, were not really performable by very many people at the time. The piano works of Liszt were playable only by Liszt. He had this phenomenal technique. Nobody had ever seen anything like this. Absolute dexterity and rapidity and virtuosity in both hands. He could play these figures at astounding speed, his hands darting all over the keyboard, and just incredible dexterity. He also had gigantic hands, so he could reach these huge intervals, these huge stretches, play these massive chords on the keyboard. And so he exploited all of that in his keyboard works.
- 6.14** So we laid out the fact that they both were born at a time when there was a lot of advancements being made in instrument manufacture, and they exploited those both in their performance and also in their compositions, writing these new hyper-virtuosic pieces. Most of the works of Beethoven or Mozart would have been accessible to a gifted amateur player in the 18th century. Now we're starting to get into things where almost nobody can play these pieces.
- 6.15** Of course, that's changed. Now, because these works are so central to the pianistic repertoire, you have to learn how to play them. They're basically obligatory, and the standards of performance have risen, consequently, to unbelievable levels. So that's all part of this triangular relationship again. Performers, composers, instrument builders working together.
- 6.16** So what do these two figures have in common? Well, one obvious thing is they're both essentially Eastern Europeans who found success in the West. So Chopin was Polish, in fact. He was born in Poland to a French emigrant father and a Polish mother, and moved to Paris when he was 20. And despite the fact that he had a French father, he was asked not to speak French. His father wanted to be as integrated as possible into Polish culture and insisted on Polish being spoken in the household. So Chopin is, in fact, half French, and he lived for much of his life in France, but he always retained a Polish accent. He never felt completely at home speaking French, and he considered himself to be Polish.
- 6.17** Now, Liszt was born actually not far at all from Esterházy, from the castle that Chopin—that Haydn spent his professional life at. So he was born in a small town in what was then the Kingdom of Hungary, which lay within the Austrian Empire. And this was approximately 35 kilometers from Haydn, 1811. And here's that Esterházy connection again. His father, Liszt's father, was in the service of the Prince of Esterházy, not the one that had known Haydn, but another Prince. And the father had met Joseph Haydn in that capacity.

- 6.18** So today, the town that Liszt was born and is part of the modern state of Austria, but it was at that time part of the Kingdom of Hungary, and he was ethnically Hungarian. He grew up, nevertheless, speaking German. So, of course, these border regions are always complicated. Nevertheless, he declared himself to be Hungarian. He felt that that was what he was, even though, again, his career was largely spent in Western Europe, including Paris.
- 6.19** So, Chopin and Liszt knew each other. They met in Paris and met quite frequently during the 1830s. And so here are these two phenomenal virtuosi, these artists who have an absolutely unparalleled instrumental imagination, people who are both able to do things that are transcendently difficult, let's say. We'll come back to that word transcendental in a minute. And they were friends, and there may have been some jealousy between them.
- 6.20** Liszt was extraordinarily good-looking, incredibly charismatic, and a rock star figure, essentially, in his life. He was also a phenomenally charismatic performer. And Liszt had this capacity to just absolutely enthrall audiences. People would faint at his concerts. They'd never seen anything so extraordinary. Chopin was not like that. He wasn't this flashy showman who was gifted at getting a rise out of a crowd. He was much more introverted, much more shy, not as interested in performing.
- 6.21** We know that Chopin performed approximately 30 times publicly in his life, which is not very many times. But for the most part, Chopin was much more at home, much more comfortable in the salon atmosphere we talked about in the lecture on Schubert. So much more interested in an intimate relationship with his audience. Small crowd of just friends and admirers. But he was not this traveling superstar in the sense that that Liszt was.
- 6.22** So this concept of a traveling star who goes from capital to capital, amazing audiences, and amassing a fortune in the process, that's something that we certainly associate with the 19th century, with this idea of—well, certainly Paganini is another example of that. Liszt is a key figure in that movement, but it's not an entirely new idea. It wasn't hugely prominent during the Classical era, but in the Baroque period, you did have a lot of traveling virtuosi, people who would go around from city to city playing concertos.
- 6.23** Often, these virtuosi were composers. They would write pieces for themselves to play that would show off their ability. They could be oboists or violinists or flutists or whatever, and they would travel around playing their own concerti. But that starts to make another resurgence in the 19th century. And not only does it make a resurgence, but the technique is pushed to an even greater degree of extremity.
- 6.24** So here's where their life paths start to diverge. So we mentioned that Chopin had a rather short life. So he was frequently ill. And, of course, it's complicated to diagnose historical figures after the fact, but he seems to have suffered from chronic tuberculosis, and he died of that in his 30s. Whereas Liszt, in contrast, lived a very long

in his life, was a celebrity throughout his life, and composed an extraordinarily extensive body of works in many, many different genres.

- 6.25** So to resume, summarize the differences between the two, Liszt strikes me as the more introverted figure of the two. And I would say also that the music, by and large, is somewhat more refined than that of Chopin, which, incidentally, is not automatically a value judgment. It's simply a quality that I think radiates from Chopin's music.
- 6.26** Chopin was the consummate master of miniature forms. There's nobody who's better at it than him, especially in the keyboard literature. He was able to write these perfectly balanced, flawless, exquisite, beautifully lyrical compositions, a series of them. He would not just write one, but he'd write an entire volume of them. It might be 12 or 14 or 32 of these pieces. They're all typically relatively short, between maybe one and three minutes length, sometimes longer. He was very, very strong at that.
- 6.27** But he was also able to write longer pieces as well. Whereas the bulk of his output consists of piano music, there's also a number of chamber compositions by Chopin for other instruments. For example, there's a late cello sonata, cello and piano, that is a really quite beautiful piece. Anyway, but what he's primarily associated with are his solo piano compositions. It's the same with Liszt. Neither of them was particularly strong with the orchestra, Chopin in particular, never really bothered to master orchestration. He did write a piano concerto, for example, but that's not really where he's at his strongest. Liszt, on the other hand, wrote pieces that were often quite a lot more extensive, but his technique was not quite as refined.
- 6.28** The harmonies of Chopin are just exquisite. He had such a refined, subtle harmonic imagination, and he really pushes harmony quite far in the 19th century. And he also writes these keyboard pieces, for example, his set of nocturnes, where you have an endless ornamentation in the right hand. It's very similar in many respects to vocal ornamentation. Sounds like a singing line all the time in the right hand—beautiful legato figures.
- 6.29** And these right-hand passages in Chopin are often rhythmically distinct from what's going on in the left hand. So in the nocturnes, for example, you'll frequently have just a regular accompaniment figure in the left hand. It doesn't really change in 3/4 time. Then in the right-hand, will have these lines that seem to just float on top effortlessly that aren't obviously rhythmically related to what's going on in the left hand. That's very typical of Chopin, and he does it with really extraordinary subtlety.
- 6.30** Liszt has a somewhat more complicated reputation. Okay, so very few people would dispute the greatness of Chopin, the greatness of these works. There are people who don't particularly like them. It's not to their taste, but it would be hard to deny his absolute mastery over his materials and techniques. So Liszt, whom I adore, I love the music of Liszt. His reputation is more complicated by the fact that he had that

showmanship quality to him. He would happily sacrifice that subtlety if he wanted to make a more extreme dramatic effect. And there's something to his music.

- 6.31** Some of it is astoundingly flashy and even vulgar at times. Because his main concern in some of those pieces is with making a very strong, striking effect. He's not just thinking in abstract terms about music and the potential of music and what can you do with form and what can you do with texture and all of these things. He's often thinking in terms of what would be an amazing thing to perform, what would be something that would really get an audience's attention if I were standing out there on the stage.
- 6.32** And he often thinks in those terms. Not always. Liszt also was capable of writing things that were much more subtle. But that's something that is a running thread through a lot of his work. So some critics, some commentators, some listeners will find Liszt exciting, dazzling, the technique almost unbelievable at times, but perhaps not quite as profound, not quite as subtle as what Chopin does.
- 6.33** The other thing that is striking in Liszt is that very often he starts with really extremely simple, not particularly compelling ideas. We saw that a little bit with Beethoven, where Beethoven would start with these little fragmentary ideas, and you would think —well, you can't really do anything with that. It's not very promising. Then he'd spin that into something, some massive sonic architecture. So Liszt would also start with, very often, folk tunes, very simple little melodic ideas. But the difference is that Liszt wasn't particularly strong in development. There's one piece of his where you do see a long line that spun out over the course of a piece that is enormously impressive. That's the Sonata in B Minor, which is, I think, one of his greatest works, and it's a piece that is today played by pianists all over the world. It's a great piece.
- 6.34** But much of the time, what Liszt was actually doing is he's taking these simple tunes and elaborating them through pianistic figuration. So he'll take this core of an idea and he'll invent these phenomenally prodigious textures that caused the pianist to have to do really unbelievable things. And then he varies them over the course of the piece. That's not to in any way denigrate or belittle his accomplishment because the works are really extraordinarily striking and exciting, and the best of them are undeniably masterworks. But that's a little bit the difference in character between the two of them.
- 6.35** Liszt, more extroverted, more interested in showmanship, in a sense. And when he performed, also, he wasn't afraid to embellish pieces and to depart from the score and come up with things on the spot and improvise and things like that. Whereas, Chopin was notoriously extremely finicky about the way his pieces were meant to be played. He wanted exactly what he wrote to be played, not one note being changed. So although I've racketed them together in this lecture, they are, in a sense, very different personalities.
- 6.36** So I'm going to suggest that we listen to a composition by Franz Liszt, and this is from a set of pieces that he wrote called the Transcendental Études, the Étude d'Exécution

Transcendente. Now, what that means, the title is that these pieces are so difficult. They're so virtuosic that they transcend the limits of the keyboard, and that's pretty much the case. Even today, these are not the most frequently performed pieces of Liszt, simply because they're out of reach for most pianists. I mean, they're really phenomenally difficult.

6.37 This is a piece that's particularly interesting to look at because it illustrates Liszt's creative habits, I think, in his way of generating material. This piece was actually written not once, but three times. When he was 14 years old, Liszt decided to write a set of piano études that would show off his facility, and it would be an attempt to show also his compositional abilities. This first version of the piece is called *Étude en Douze Exercices*, so 12 Exercises for the keyboard. And this first draft of the piece was written in 1826. He's 14. Beethoven is still alive at that point. And at that point, these pieces are very good for a 14-year-old, but they're not exceptional pieces.

6.38 Then later on in 1837, he rewrites them. He writes a second version of the piece that's much more elaborate. He takes the original pieces, uses them as a skeleton and elaborate upon them and comes up with much more interesting textures. And this second version of the piece is called the *Douze Grandes Études*, the 12 Grand Études for keyboard. So that's 1837.

6.39 But then he's still not quite satisfied, and his technical ability keeps increasing, and he keeps getting more ideas for these pieces and wants to perfect them. And in 1852, finally, he rewrites them a third time. And this time, they're no longer simply called études or studies, but rather *Transcendental Études*. So there's not really a level beyond transcendental as far as pianistic difficulty goes.

6.40 So this final version of the piece, this third version, is published in 1852. Now, these pieces, I think, are absolutely marvelous. They're among my favorite pieces by Liszt. And he was extremely gifted at creating an expression, an intensity of expression that is uncommon. Now, this particular piece is based off of a poem by Lord Byron called *Mazeppa*. And it tells the story—it's a narrative poem about Ivan Mazeppa, who is a military leader of Ukraine, being tied to a horse as punishment. And the horse is racing all over Europe with a poor Mazeppa tied to his back.

6.41 This is alleged, of course, it's not historically accurate. Thank goodness. So this piece attempts to illustrate that, this vision of a man being tied to a horse and dragged all over Europe. And interestingly, in the poem, the man survives. He ultimately gets off and emerges triumphant at the very end. He does not die, although he comes close a few times. So this is *Mazeppa*. It's the third movement from the *Transcendental Etudes* by Franz Liszt.

6.42 [musical piece]

6.43 So something about this vision of riding on the back of a racing horse and perishing at the end. It's like an obsession with Romantics for some reason. I have no idea why. It's a

reoccurring theme. Anyway, so that's an example of the Lisztian approach to writing for keyboard. So as you can see, it's extremely spectacular. It's very impressive. Some would argue that it's not a piece that necessarily has an enormous amount of musical substance to it. There's a lot of repetition of this melodic idea and a lot of, well, basically just variation of it with all this figuration. But I would take exception to that.

- 6.44 There is music that functions in a different way from the more developmental tradition of Beethoven and other Classical and Romantic figures. Sometimes the interest in a piece of music can come from the degree of invention that is in the instrumental writing. Somebody who comes up with a keyboard style or a violin style or a new way of singing that is extremely striking, and the substance can be derived from that. It can be derived from the instrumental aspect. That's the case with Liszt, and he did it arguably better than anybody else. His inventiveness in terms of these textures is so extraordinary that I don't personally miss the fact that it's not going to develop in the same manner as a Beethoven sonata.
- 6.45 There is a certain reliance on a consistent thickness of texture in these pieces with these quadruple octaves and these runs and these extremely rapid passages that run over the entire keyboard. But he just uses everything. He uses all the resources of this instrument and pushes it as far as it will possibly go. So he has this a flashy side to him, but he's also capable of extraordinary harmonic experimentations. And as Liszt gets older, as he gets into his 60s and 70s, and he starts to write pieces that really push harmony, traditional harmony, to the breaking point. The pieces get so harmonically complex and ambiguous that it starts to point towards a radically modern style. And we'll talk tomorrow about where that ultimately leads.
- 6.46 The other thing that Liszt did that I think is actually quite interesting, and most definitely a formal his innovation in his music is that remember that the Classical symphony or a string quartet or piano sonata is typically articulated in several movements, usually four movements. What Liszt does is he, in some of his longer pieces, he telescopes the different movements of a piece into a single, long continuity. So instead of having a break, you have a fast movement and then a break, and then a slow movement and then another break and so on. Liszt creates these continuous expanses, these continuous stretches of music where it flows from one movement to another quite seamlessly, and it never stops.
- 6.47 Sometimes he returns cyclically to things that we've heard earlier on in the piece, and sometimes he doesn't. But he's able to write these very long continuities that way, which is increasingly going to be a staple of the Romantic esthetic palette, if you like, where the pieces tend to get longer and you start to get these ever more epic developments that can go on for half an hour or longer.
- 6.48 So there's another thing I want to mention here. We spoke about the fact that in Beethoven, you start to see the output being a lot more modest in contrast to what Schubert or Mozart was able to produce in their lifetimes. And we talked about the fact

that part of the reason for this is that Beethoven is starting to push these forms to the breaking point. And we saw that in the Grosse Fuge, the fact that the traditional symmetry and section breaks and formal schemes that you see in Classical music are starting to just break down. They don't really function anymore. And that forces him to write these unique pieces that can't be really reproduced very easily.

- 6.49** In contrast, the Classical forms, the sonata form, minuet form, rondo, and so on, those forms can be easily reproduced by a competent student. You can say, okay, here's how variation form works. Here's how a sonata is articulated. Here's what goes on in a rondo, etc. And the student, with a moderate degree of ability, can reproduce those forms. But it's not so of these much more extravagant Romantic forms. These much more extended pieces, these pieces that don't necessarily adhere to a particular framework.
- 6.50** And that starts to become generalized throughout the 19th century, particularly in the second half of the 19th century, where the language of music is expanding all the time, starting to incorporate new possibilities, new ways of imagining forms, new ways of imagining pieces. And eventually, that pushes the very language of music to the breaking point, which is something we'll talk about tomorrow.
- 6.51** But we've gotten used to this concept in music that every new piece must present us with something novel, must do something that is, in a sense, fundamentally different from what the composer has already done or what their colleagues might be doing, which definitely had consequences. So you start to see that composers are producing fewer pieces and spending longer writing them. So it's no longer uncommon for a composer to take a year to write a piece or sometimes even more.
- 6.52** Whereas Schubert might have dashed off Erlkonig in a few hours in an afternoon, that starts to be less and less of a possibility because we no longer have these forms that can simply be iterated multiple times. So a greater degree of novelty, greater degree of formal and certainly harmonic innovation in the pieces, and also an increased sense of the artist's individual subjectivity as being a fundamental component of the creative process.
- 6.53** So now, let me play you a piece by Chopin. So Chopin composed many pieces in established genres, such as the prelude, the étude, nocturnes, and a few other genres that he didn't exactly invent, but he certainly developed, such as the polonaise or the mazurka. So these were all Polish dances that he elaborated into these vast pieces for a solo keyboard. And he also wrote three piano sonatas that are really remarkable works. They're certainly cornerstones of the pianistic repertoire, and they're remarkably subtle as well in their construction, more so than the works of Liszt, in general, I would say. But probably the works that he's most associated with are these smaller forms, the nocturnes and preludes, which would be books of individual pieces. And they remain phenomenally popular today with pianists.

- 6.54** So I'm going to play you an excerpt from the final movement of Chopin's Sonata in B flat Minor, Opus 35. This is a very late piece. It's a very experimental one, very odd piece in many respects. And It stunned and shocked audiences at the time. The composer, Robert Schumann, who knew Chopin and was aware of what he was doing, reviewed this piece. Schumann was also active as a music critic and a writer on music. He got the score of this piece and had a look at it and wrote a review. He was absolutely dumbfounded by it. He never seen anything like this. The last movement of this sonata is, in fact, very strange.
- 6.55** It consists of an entirely monophonic texture, which is to say that rather than having cords or multiple lines or some counterpoint or harmony, it's just a single line on the keyboard played in octaves the whole time, and it's blisteringly fast. It's so fast that the notes just become a blur. And the thing is, when you listen to this piece, you'll notice that it doesn't seem to be any identifiable material in it. There's no melody, there's no harmony. The rhythm is just a blur because it's so fast.
- 6.56** So it's like, what is this thing? Well, what the thing is, I suppose, is a constant state of becoming. It's making a line and having it move and following the trajectory of that line. But there's no object in it. There's no thing that you can point to and say, this is the theme or this is the melody or nothing that you can put brackets around. Rather, it's a continuous state of change and flow in this musical material.
- 6.57** So when Schumann got a hold of this score and had a look through it, he hated it, absolutely hated it. He said, "This is more like an irony than a music. From this musical line without and without joy, there breathes a strange, horrible spirit which annihilates with its heavy fist anything that resists it. And we listen with fascination and without protesting until the end, but without nevertheless being able to praise, for this is not music." So that's Robert Schumann on Chopin. And bear in mind that Schumann understood that Chopin was a great creator, a great musician. Nevertheless, he could not follow him in this direction. So this is the third movement—sorry, this is the last movement of the B flat minor sonata by Chopin, Opus 35.
- 6.58** [musical piece]
- 6.59** So there it is. What was that? I don't know. It's so fast. There are, in fact, elements in that repeat. There are little sequences and little collections of notes that repeat themselves in various ways, but it's so fast that it's very hard to hear. So I was asking my pianist friend about this piece and saying, "How does anybody play this? This is unbelievable." And she said, "Well, it's actually not as hard as it sounds. It's nowhere near as hard as the Liszt pieces. And part of the reason for that is, Chopin writes so idiomatically for the keyboard, everything just falls effortlessly under the fingers. The speed is actually not a huge problem because there's not that much lateral hand movement a lot of the time, and you can just race through it," which astounded me. I don't think I could race through that piece.

- 6.60 But anyway, that's an example of the forward-thinking nature of the Romantics. That's their basic essence. The Romantics were people who are always pushing forward, always trying new things, always experimenting, always attempting things that have never been done before. That's really the essence of the Romantic spirit. And these composers saw themselves, I think, as these archetypal hero figures, these heroes that are on a quest for something new, venturing into unexplored territory, into a desert, and trying to come back with something that could be exploitable, that could enrich the society that they lived in.
- 6.61 So I want to play you one more piece before we stop for today. I'm going to just play you an excerpt from one of the most popular works of Chopin, which is the Polonaise in A flat. And this is a piece that also shows, I think, Chopin's ability to take established forms and familiar materials and do something really quite unexpected with them. And again, he's completely departing in all of these pieces from any Classical conventions.
- 6.62 The piece that we just heard is basically formless. It's just a continuous movement, a blur. This that we're about to hear is not formless. It has clear sections. It has clear melody. It has a clear structure to it, but it's a very odd structure. It's a very asymmetrical one and has a lot of surprises along the way. Here's the A flat Polonaise by Frédéric Chopin.
- 6.63 [musical piece]
- 6.64 Okay, so that last section there, you might have noticed there's a repeating pattern on the left hand [musical beat]. It's very fast. Now, that's done in octaves. So the pinkie and the thumb have to be held like this, and you're going [musical beat]. It's at insane speed. It's really quite phenomenal that pianists can do that. But anyway, so that's a very, very, very brief summary of the lives and some of the creative achievements of these two composers. It's necessarily a very partial one. So again, you have to really sit down and listen to these pieces in sequence, I think, to get a sense of the breadth of their accomplishment.
- 6.65 But nevertheless, these two figures really exemplify this Romantic spirit, and they're both great innovators. They're both people thinking really in terms of what can be done, what doesn't exist yet that we can create, that we can do, that would push us forward into the future. So they're really not looking backwards at all. They're deriving some ideas, of course, from the music of their predecessors, but really, it's astoundingly visionary music in many respects. It's not hard to see why it's popular today. These pieces are spectacular. They're deeply impressive. They're melodic, they're memorable, and they're extraordinarily fun to listen to. You really have to see them played live. That's quite astounding.
- 6.66 So any questions or comments about Chopin and Liszt before we break for the day?

- 6.67** How would you evaluate a piece based off of the technicalities of it and the potential intention of the emotional reaction of the audience?
- 6.68** So my evaluation of a piece is simple: Do I want to hear it a second time? That's it. And I have to qualify that somewhat because occasionally I'll hear a piece and I'll have a strong negative reaction to it. I'll be bored, or I'll find it tedious, or just expressively, I won't be drawn to it. And I'll think, "Oh, I'm glad that's over." And I think everybody will have that experience at some point if you go regularly to concerts. Not everything's going to affect you.
- 6.69** The other thing is, if you're hearing a piece for the first time, you have to remember that the performer is a conduit. So the performer comes between the work of art and the listener, in a sense. You have to have that intermediary. So we can't peer into Liszt's brain or Chopin's brain and have a undiluted experience of precisely what they intended. We have to pass through the intermediary of the performer.
- 6.70** So if you're hearing a piece for the first time, you don't necessarily know—if you don't like the piece, you don't automatically know if it's because it's a bad performance or if it's the piece itself. So it can take a while to untangle these things. That's why it's also useful in many instances—if you don't particularly like a piece, you can always try to listen to a different performer, a different recording of the same thing. And in all of these Classical pieces, there are, in many cases, dozens or even hundreds of different recordings that exist. And some performers will take a very, very different approach to them.
- 6.71** But to return to that question of how do I know if I'm interested in a piece, if I'm compelled by it, I always try to keep an open mind and delay my judgment as long as possible. So my assumption going into it is always, okay, I don't know what this is yet, but I'm going to listen and we'll see. I'm not going to judge it. I'm not going to think too hard about if I like it or don't like it. At first, we'll see. If I'm strongly repelled by a piece for the first time you hear it, then that might be an indication. But I'll usually try to wait for a second or third hearing to be absolutely certain.
- 6.72** That being said, there are pieces that just instantly draw you in, where they just grab hold of you and they won't let go and you become fascinated. I've had that experience on multiple occasions. I'll hear a work, and within seconds, you just plunged into this world that fascinates you, and you might not understand it. You don't know how you got there. You don't know what you're doing there, but it's like, what is this? And then you have to listen again and again and again. And then the piece grabs hold of you. And that's the piece that is likely to be a lifetime companion, I think.
- 6.73** So yeah, you can pay attention to your reactions to a piece while you're listening to it and see if you're drawn to it, if you're repulsed by it, if you're bored by it. But don't judge it. Don't judge it just yet because it might take a few listenings to reveal itself.

- 6.74** Okay, so this question is about actually listening to classical music. You mentioned going to concerts or recordings. How would you recommend—do you need an expensive speaker or earbuds? How would you recommend listening to classical music?
- 6.75** Okay, excellent question. Okay, let's pull this apart. Concerts can be expensive, but they're often not. A lot of classical concerts are free. A lot of them have very cheap tickets as well. When I was a student in Paris, I used to go to the Paris Opera all the time, and we could get tickets for €5 for that. Okay, so it meant sitting at the back, and there was often a column in between you and the stage, so you didn't necessarily have the best seating the house, but it was €5. That was all right. What does it cost to go to a pop concert? If you want to go hear, Ariana Grande, it could cost you £150-£200 to hear a concert like that. So it's not quite a reflection of reality. Some concerts are very inexpensive.
- 6.76** So okay, if you want to get a first-row seat at the Metropolitan Opera in New York, then yes, that'll be expensive. But there are lots of other options available. Chamber music concerts are often free. There are lots of lunchtime concerts, for example. Now, I recognize also that there is a geographical issue as well. So you're likelier to find a diverse range of concerts in a big city. That's true. That's always been true, and that's difficult to change. So if you live in a smaller place, in a small town, right in the countryside, then there's probably not going to be an opera house right next door. So there are things like that that you have to travel to if you want to experience use them. That is true.
- 6.77** But we do have recordings, and recordings are accessible to everybody. So no, you don't have to have fancy headphones or anything like that. None of that stuff is necessary. Not at all. You can have a life-changing synthetic experience listening to something on an iPhone speaker. It doesn't matter. There are people who get really into audio, really seriously into it and spend a fortune on speakers. But it doesn't improve the music. It doesn't even necessarily—it might make it sound a little bit better, but it doesn't change the essence of it, which is the experience of listening. No, the barrier to entry should be as low as possible. Start with where you are, see if there's a concert you can get yourself to, and if you can't get to a concert, just go on the internet.
- 6.78** There's really a profound change happening in terms of the accessibility of the arts. This is a point I've made before in this course, but even when I was a teenager, if I wanted to get to know a piece of music, in some cases, I had to actually order the disk or I had to buy a copy of the score, and sometimes that was not accessible to me. I had no money at all, but sometimes you couldn't get these things in a public library, so it was tricky.
- 6.79** But now that barrier, it just doesn't exist. I mean, you can go on the Internet now and find anything. I mean, literally anything. There's a website called imslp.org, which is the International Music Score Library Project. I think that's what it stands for. And it's a vast

repository of all the Classical scores by Beethoven, Mozart, Haydn, and so on. All of these scores are available as free downloads as PDFs. Anyone can download them. They're out of copyright now, so there's no issue there.

- 6.80** Or a recording, It's like, you can go on YouTube. You don't even have to pay for a 10 euro, or whatever, Spotify account. You can just go on YouTube, and every piece ever written, virtually speaking, is available for free. So it's like we have this extraordinary privilege of access to the totality of our cultural production now. So that barrier doesn't really exist. I think it exists in people's minds to a degree, and there's still this persistent idea that classical music is off-putting, that you have to have a fancy suit, or that you have to go to a major capital, or you have to buy an expensive ticket. And I think there's lots of things that could be done differently and ought to be done differently in order to dispel that notion. Absolutely.
- 6.81** But it's also true that you can just listen to hours and hours and hours of any imaginable music for free on YouTube. So start there, see what you think. It might hold of you, and you might want to go farther.

Lecture 7: Arnold Schoenberg

At a glance — Arnold Schoenberg.

- 7.1 Artists are always caught between inner necessity and external pressures. This is part of the existential lot of the creative person. There's basically no solution to this dilemma. Artists are compelled by the need to say something, to express something, to give form to something that doesn't yet exist in the world, or maybe exists in the world in the form of potential. But nobody creates in a vacuum. We might like to. We might think that that would be a desirable situation. But of course, it's impossible. The artist always must interface with the society within which they live and within the, well, the social conditions that they're born into.
- 7.2 That is a bit of a running thread, a running theme throughout the lives of the composers that we've looked at so far. Each of these composers, Bach, Haydn, Mozart, Schubert, they've all had to deal with this problem in various ways, and they've all had different situations. Bach, for example, had unbelievable professional pressures. He had to write liturgical music at an insane rate, 20 to 30 minutes of music every week for years on end. Schubert wrote music that was intended to be heard in basically a private setting most of the time, had very little public success, and was eventually consumed by his voracious need to create.
- 7.3 All of these composers have had to deal with striking a balance between their own compulsions, their own expressive desires, their own particular esthetic projects, and the conditions that were possible for them to do their work within. We talked about how Haydn basically had to enter into a form of complete servitude in order to have any professional existence whatsoever. Now, this question of how do you deal with social reality, how do you deal with this balance between your inner necessity and the inevitable external pressures?
- 7.4 It comes to a boiling point in the late Romantic and Early Modern Eras. And we start to see artists entering into a more and more complex relationship with the audiences of their time. So you could argue that with Haydn, that relationship was relatively straightforward and simple. It was transactional. He was in the employment of a prince. He had to produce music that would please a prince. He did so brilliantly and was successful at that.
- 7.5 We're going to look at two figures today who are emblematic artists of the 20th century. Now, it's obviously extraordinarily reductive to only speak about two 20th-century composers, especially given the fact that we've had to leap over some very significant and intermediary figures between Chopin, Liszt, and the two figures we'll be discussing today. Nevertheless, these two artists that we're going to look at today are a useful lens through which to look at the 20th century. And it may also take us some ways towards understanding the present condition of composers and other artists,

certainly. So the composers we're going to look at today are Arnold Schoenberg and Igor Stravinsky.

- 7.6** We're going to start with Schoenberg, and we will end this course with Stravinsky. Schoenberg was born in 1874 in Vienna to a middle-class Jewish family, and he is certainly one of the most controversial figures in all of 20th-century music, but also a hugely consequential one. To understand Schoenberg's particular historical position and his creative achievements, we do have to move a little bit back.
- 7.7** So the last composers we talked about, again, were Chopin and Liszt. In between, there are a number of other extremely consequential figures that continued this lineage of German Romanticism and the forward march, I suppose, of esthetic evolution in music. Among those figures are Robert Schumann, who comes, well, actually, a rough contemporary of Chopin, Brahms, Wagner, Richard Strauss, and Gustav Mahler.
- 7.8** So all of these figures are participating in some manner or another in a gradual process of evolution in the language of music. One of the things that you start to observe when you look at the music of the second half of the 19th century is that there's less and less repetition in the music, and there's less and less what you might call neutral material. Let me explain what I mean by those things.
- 7.9** If you look at a typical Mozart string quartet or a Haydn sonata—setting aside the refinement, the quality, the expressiveness, the exquisite artistry, and so on—what you will see is there's a fair amount of material that is effectively outsourced to the larger culture. Which is to say, there are figures that are accompanimental figures or repetitive figures that you might see, for example, in the left hand of the keyboard part, or that you might see in the cello part of the string quartet. And these figures, these little rhythmic motifs or these little accompanimental motifs, are not invented by the composer. The composer doesn't have to make all of this material up when they sit down to write.
- 7.10** Now, there's a whole repertory of such figures. For example, probably the most famous instance would be the so-called Alberti bass in Mozart. And the Alberti bass is essentially—I don't have a keyboard, so I can't demonstrate it to you. But the Alberti bass is a simple repeating figure in the left hand of a keyboard part where you take a triad—it's a three-note chord which forms the basis of Western harmony—and you just break the chord up into its constituent tones, and you repeat them in a regular pattern. And this bass figure is omnipresent throughout the music of the Classical period. And in Mozart, you see a lot of materials like this. You see scales, where he runs up and down the keyboard, arpeggios, rapid runs, different accompanimental figures, different rhythmic figures. These things were not invented by Mozart. They were already there, and he shapes them into something else. He puts them into his composition and gives them a context. But the point is there's a certain amount of neutral material, i.e., material that does not only exclusively exist in that composition, but that can be used by a composer in order to create a texture or a musical— to support a musical idea.

What happens throughout the latter part of the 19th century is that composers are starting to rely less and less on these sorts of devices.

- 7.11** The idea being that rather than have repetition and things that are already familiar from other contexts, there's going to be less material in a sense, but you're going to continually vary it and change it all the time. You see that certainly in the music of Robert Schumann, you see it in Brahms. It's not to say that there's no continuity in that music. There is. There is a very strong, very directional sense of continuity, but there's less of this obvious repetition. Instead, you have a continual process of variation or developing variation, as Schoenberg referred to it.
- 7.12** That poses some challenges for audiences. One of them is that if there's less obvious repetition in the music, then there's less redundancy in it, and therefore, it's making greater demands on your focus, on your attention. Because there might be passages in a Haydn symphony where there's a great deal of repetition. There's a figure that's repeated hundreds of times. And that doesn't solicit your active attention when you're listening to it. Those sorts of things will provide a railroad along which you can move, but you don't have to be consciously thinking about every single note in the piece. They just push you forward.
- 7.13** When you start to reduce the amount of repetitive material, then the music is, again, it's making greater demands on the listener, inevitably. No matter how elegant or beautiful the piece might be, there's more going on in a sense. Now, that is absolutely not to diminish in any sense the music of the Classical style. Not at all. We have to view this as simply a change, a change in priorities, a change in compositional processes. The other thing is that the basic, the smallest grammatical unit, if you like, of a piece of music starts to get smaller.
- 7.14** In the Classical style, a lot of the processes in a sonata or a string quartet or a symphony are based off of a theme, what's called a theme. The theme is essentially a complete melodic statement. It's a melodic statement that has a beginning, a middle, and an end. It has devices called cadences that tell you clearly where the phrase comes to a pause and where it comes to a full stop at the end. There's an object-like quality to these Classical themes. You know when they start, you know when they end. It's very easy to recognize them when they return in the piece. They're complete melodies.
- 7.15** As you get into the latter half of the 19th century, there are still themes. But in a sense, the materials that composers are working with start to get smaller, more cellular in nature, more microscopic. The composer might be dealing with just a few notes associated perhaps with a characteristic rhythm systemic figure. And then this cell, because it's smaller than a complete melodic statement, might be more amenable to a continuous process of change in variation. So that gives rise to things like the enormously long and complicated continuities in Wagner operas, in the tone poems of Richard Strauss, and in the massively lengthy symphonies of Gustav Mahler.

- 7.16** So Schoenberg is born into this context where he's still in this pre-war world, where there's this quite straightforward, unproblematic lineage of great figures that came before him in the musical world. And there are living composers that are prominent public figures, such as Strauss and Mahler, who have this God-like status to him. And he's fascinated not only by the extraordinary forward-thinking nature of this music and by all of the ways in which this music is innovating and trying new things and exploring new sounds, new combinations of tones, new types of orchestration. He wants to participate in this.
- 7.17** So what he does is, first of all, he starts to try to get a solid Classical education. He tries to master the basics of musical composition, but largely on his own. He considers himself somewhat of an outsider in the musical life of Vienna and sets about attempting to teach himself. So he happens to have been extraordinarily creative and brilliant, but he's an autodidact, mostly. He did take some lessons with a Viennese composer called Alexander Zemlinsky. But for the most part, Schoenberg is really this autonomous figure who seems to have developed the most extraordinary musical capacity, largely on his own, largely independently.
- 7.18** So he absorbs the ethos, the esthetic of late Romanticism absolutely perfectly. He's got it at his fingertips. And let's talk about what that looks like for a minute. I don't know if any of you have heard symphonies by Mahler. They're really quite something. These are very, very long pieces. They can easily be an hour or longer. And they can have individual movements that are 20, 25, 30 minutes long. Mahler will throw in an extraordinary amount of material into these pieces. They're like epics. It's like reading Proust or something. You go through this this unbelievably long and complicated process of development with all of these different ideas and textures and themes, motifs. But it's also hugely expressive, so much so that the language of music almost starts to collapse under the weight of this emotional intensity.
- 7.19** So this is really the ultimate endpoint, in a sense, of the Romantic push towards novelty, towards expansion of musical language, and it coincides with a period that is relatively stable and relatively prosperous in European history. During this era of late Romanticism, you start to see the advent also of much larger orchestras, much more sophisticated instruments that are able to play in any key with ease, which is not the case necessarily with Classical instruments that were more technically limited.
- 7.20** And along with that, you see these massive concert halls being built. You see these gigantic orchestra compositions, such as Mahler's eighth symphony, the so-called Symphony of a Thousand, that doesn't literally require a thousand performers, but it certainly requires several hundred. It's typically done with about 400 performers on stage, if not more. This is an era of esthetic excess, certainly, musical gigantism, and pushing the limits of expressivity as far as it will go. We already got a hint of that, more than a hint of that in the pieces of Liszt's that we listened to yesterday.

- 7.21** So this is the context that Schoenberg comes out of. He's coming at the tail end of something, much as Bach did in his time. Bach was the ultimate flowering of the polyphonic style that was dominant in Europe for about a thousand years. So he's not an instigator, right? Bach was not somebody who started something new, but he really comes at the end of something. In a sense, well, Schoenberg is like that, and he's also an absolute radical who completely breaks with tradition.
- 7.22** His position is ambiguous, and it's not terribly easy to summarize, but he describes himself as a radical conservative or a conservative radical. So what does that mean? Well, on the one hand, Schoenberg had an absolute veneration for the great artist of the past, and he was acutely conscious of his own role within that tradition. So this is a composer not just creating his own work, but also reflecting on who am I? What is the time period in which I'm born? What is my particular task as an artist? What is it that needs to be done? Where am I going to take music into the future? How am I going to do that? He's reflecting on all of these things. He's very conscious of his historical position.
- 7.23** So he's a conservative in the sense that he has this veneration for a tradition. He's conscious of the value of the Austro-German tradition within which he's working. He's rather chauvinistic about it, by the way, as were a lot of composers at that time. Debussy in France, for example, who is a rough contemporary of Schoenberg, absolutely hated German music. He's convinced that—he was convinced that he had to do the opposite. He had to make distinctly French music. He used very unflattering terms to describe Germans in his private letters. There's a sense in Schoenberg that he's similarly disdainful towards the French. They're both extremely nationalistic in their way and very chauvinistic about their own cultures.
- 7.24** Now, he had an extraordinarily refined technique and an absolute consummate mastery of harmony. That he arrived at that basically on his own is quite stunning. So he's a radical in the sense that he was determined to understand as thoroughly and as deeply as possible the technical and esthetic underpinnings of musical composition. You could argue that he understood those better than just about anybody else at that time. But he's a radical in the sense that he comes to feel that because this tradition is valuable, extremely valuable and fragile, and he wants to preserve it, the way to do that is not to slavishly imitate what's already been done. It's not to make a pastiche of Brahms. It's not to make a pastiche of Haydn or Mozart.
- 7.25** You have to keep a tradition alive by innovating within it. If you don't renew it, if you don't renew the language of music, it will eventually become desiccated, cliché-ridden, and trite. So this has to be a living tissue. It has to be something that can grow and change and development. And I think Schoenberg is right. I think that you can't simply produce copies of what's been done in the past. You can learn from what's been done in the past, and certainly you have to draw lessons from that, and you have to be aware of history and all of that is very important. But if your creative practice consists of

imitating the works that were done by previous people, then it's not going to go very far, and it's not going to enrich the tradition.

- 7.26** The consequences he drew from that were rather radical. And in that sense, you could argue that Schoenberg represents the end of this lineage of Austro-German composers that stretches back to Bach and to Schutz before him and to other figures. So I'm just going to end this preamble by saying that he's perhaps the most extreme point of development of this dialectical idea in Western music. We talked about with the sonata form idea, the idea that you would have multiple contrasting ideas or themes or whatever it might be in a composition, and you work them out dialectically.
- 7.27** That is the essence of Schoenberg's music, but he pushes it extremely far. Whereas Brahms, Wagner, Strauss, and so on, progressively reduce the amount of redundancy, the amount of repetition in their music, by the time we get to Schoenberg, the amount of repetition is virtually nil. So every instant of the piece is going to be different from what came before it. There is a clear line. He had a magnificent sense of dramaturgy, in a sense of forward momentum in his pieces. But once he started off on a path in his piece, he doesn't go backwards. We don't revisit material. Not literally. It's always changed. It's always changing all the time.
- 7.28** Let me give you a few elements of Schoenberg's life and music. Of course, we're going to listen to a few of his pieces, but I just want to fill out his biography first. He mentioned that he was born in 1874 in Vienna. Was not particularly precocious. This was not a Mozart-producing symphonies at seven years of age. He took a long time. He worked very, very slowly, and he didn't actually start to produce anything like a mature work until he was about in his mid-20s.
- 7.29** But when he did arrive at a style, he arrived at it rather remarkably quickly. The first piece of Schoenberg that has that is being retained in the repertoire, and that is still a very popular and commonly performed piece, is a string sextet called, *Verklarte Nacht*, Transfigured Night. And that was a piece that he wrote when he was, I think, 24, 25 years old. Now, his early compositions, although they slot into this late Romantic idiom, and you can very clearly see the continuity, and in hindsight, they're actually very easy pieces to listen to. They're very beautiful, they're very pleasant, and they're very expressive.
- 7.30** But at the time, it didn't take much to upset the Viennese public. They were very ticklish about anything that would upset their habits. They were very conservative. It's actually largely still the case today, incidentally, kind of funny. Even Brahms had a lot of trouble with the Viennese public. So Schoenberg, he starts to just push a little bit at the edges of what you can do in traditional harmony, just a little bit. Using chords that are a little bit unusual or using them in slightly unusual ways, unusual contexts.
- 7.31** And he gets into a little bit of trouble in *Verklarte Nacht* because although much of it, again, is indistinguishable, really, from the mainstream of the harmonic language of the

day, there's a few chords in that piece that are just a little bit strange. Dissonances that don't quite resolve in the expected manner. Chords that are a little bit more tense, perhaps, than what you would normally expect in this language.

- 7.32** It's not that other composers don't use dissonant chords. It's that in the language of tonality of traditional Western harmony, there's a protocol for the resolution of dissonances. If you have a dissonance, the technical explanation of what a dissonance is—I should probably get into a little bit here. A dissonance, we tend to think of dissonance as a harsher and unpleasant sound. I think that's probably, for a lot of people, the first idea that comes into mind when you hear this term. What a dissonance technically is, is a tension that has to be resolved or something that wants to move.
- 7.33** We make a distinction in harmony between consonances, which are said to be stable—stable, meaning that there's no impulse to move or to change, they're stable—and dissonances, which are unstable. They need to move. That's all. It's not that they're harsh necessarily. It's not that they're unpleasant necessarily. It's that they imply movement. Right, so Schoenberg starts using these sorts of chords, which in traditional harmony, have to move in a way that resolves the dissonance. But he uses them in a way that exploits their characteristic color, but without necessarily resolving them. And funnily enough, that's pretty much the same thing that Debussy was doing over in France, but in a different stylistic idiom.
- 7.34** So the idea is that the chords no longer have to adhere to this traditional logic, much as experimental poets at the time were breaking down syntax and imagining different ways of writing lines. So all of the elements of traditional music are there. It's just that the syntax is starting to change a little bit, and the way that these dissonant unstable chords are being used, well, they're being used for their autonomous qualities and for their esthetic qualities and not necessarily adhering to that traditional methodology of resolution.
- 7.35** These early pieces, while everybody basically recognizes his talent, they're starting to get a bit suspicious of him. What's this guy really up to? What's with these strange sounds? And he continues with that, and he gets more and more bold and more and more experimental with his pieces. And eventually, the relationship between Schoenberg and the audience in Vienna becomes downright hostile. He starts to see riots at his concerts. He starts to be openly mocked in the press, described as a madman. And his response to this, because he was absolutely convinced that this was something that he needed to do, that music needed to do. He had things to say, he had feelings to express, and that was that. There was, like Beethoven, an absolute faith in his own esthetic instincts.
- 7.36** But he has to survive professionally somehow, and he has to have his pieces played, and he has to maintain active as a musician. So after World War I, in 1918, he founds the Verein für Musikalische Privataufführungen, the Society for Private Musical

Performances. Now, that lasted for about three years. And what it did—this is not a footnote in history. This is actually a very, very significant event. It effectively ushered in an entirely new relationship between artists and their public.

- 7.37** The Society for Private Musical Performances was a way for Schoenberg to program concerts where the works would be performed multiple times. They would be extremely carefully rehearsed, performed in ideal conditions. But in order to hear these concerts, you had to be a member of the society. You couldn't just go. And these were not public concerts. And more to the point, the press was banned. There is a sign on the door saying that journalists were not permitted to attend. He didn't want to deal with the insults, with the pettiness and the musical politics of Vienna. So they just banned it: No journalists!
- 7.38** The other thing that they had at this was the idea that you shouldn't applaud. There should be no applause. There should be no sense of audience approval or disapproval listening to these pieces. You should just listen and not judge the works necessarily, not right away. Listen to them carefully, maybe listen to them multiple times, and then you can form an opinion. But he didn't want this gladiatorial type of situation where he would have these noisy audiences loudly proclaiming their approval or disapproval. He wanted a space within which the art could be heard in ideal conditions. So that attitude of wanting to keep the art somewhat at a distance, not necessarily be out there in the ring, so to speak, with this wild public. That was something that had rather profound consequences.
- 7.39** So in 1926, Schoenberg accepts a position teaching composition at the Prussian Academy of Arts in Berlin. He's starting to get well-known. He's respected as an artist, as a composer, even though he doesn't have any popular success with the audience, at least he's acknowledged as a master and also as a great teacher, which he was. So he takes this teaching position, moves to Berlin, and remains there until 1933, at which point he takes a vacation in France. And while he's there with his wife, he's told that returning to Germany would be dangerous for him. After all, Schoenberg is Jewish.
- 7.40** So he decides that the best course of action would be to move either to Britain or to America. He's unable to obtain a visa to come to London, so he goes to California eventually and settles there. So the last part of his life is spent effectively as an exile. He had this bitterness, this resentment towards both the Viennese, but also certainly towards the Germans for what happened during this period.
- 7.41** And although to the end of his life, he remained a Viennese through and through, and he was profoundly steeped in that culture and profoundly venerated the artists that it had produced, he had to live in the United States. And he eventually took a teaching position at the University of California in Los Angeles, UCLA, where he taught from the 1930s onward. And he became an American citizen in 1941. And throughout this period, the '30s and '40s, he writes some of his greatest works. He writes the Violin Concerto, the Piano Concerto, a vast opera, which he never quite completed, which is

nevertheless performed, called *Moses und Aron*, *Moses and Aaron*, and the *Variations for Orchestra*.

7.42 He's a figure that fascinates me, in part because he never stops developing. Schoenberg never settles into a style and then just keeps going. He's always moving forward. He's always progressing. He's always changing as an artist, and he's always trying new things. That was just part of his nature. He's a great inventor of music. He's a great thinker, a great imaginer of new musical possibilities. So he never moves—he never sits still. He's always moving. And he died in California in 1951 at the age of 77.

7.43 Now, I've had the opportunity to interview a couple of his children and to speak to them about what father he was. And one thing I find remarkable is that he insisted that they grow up as Americans, that they speak English, and he didn't want to speak German around them. And by all accounts, he was a fantastic father and a wonderful human being. So extremely controversial artist and one who, to this day, polarizes audiences, but one whose influence cannot be ignored. In fact, it would not be an exaggeration to say that the profile of music in the 20th century was altered forever by Schoenberg.

7.44 So I'm going to play you a little bit of his music. We'll get a sense of what all of this sounds like. So remember, we talked about the string sextet, *Verklerte Nacht*, *Transfigured Night*. So I'm going to play this for you. This piece is from 1899. Schoenberg was 25. And I think it's a very beautiful, expressive piece. And in hindsight, it's funny because we might listen to it today and think, well, what's all the fuss about? This sounds just very beautiful and very lyrical. But we'll listen to a couple of minutes of it and you can see what you think.

7.45 [musical piece]

7.46 I think one of the things that audiences may have found distressing about this piece is its extraordinary emotional intensity. It grabs you by the throat, and it doesn't let go. It's very, very, very strong. And a lot of Schoenberg's music, I think you would have to classify as some of the most expressive music ever written. It's intense. And it does make demands on listeners. There's a couple of things that emerge out of that.

7.47 So this is an early piece, but he doesn't stop there. He continues, and the music gets more and more chromatic, more and more harmonically complex. The directionality of the music becomes weaker also. You remember that in Mozart, we talked about the fact that there's this stability, there's this symmetry, there's this elegance to the music where you never really lose sight of a continuous line of development. You never really lose sight of what's called the tonic, the main tone or the main key of the piece. And that assures you of a certain equilibrium. You don't feel lost when you're listening to a Mozart piece.

7.48 In Schoenberg, this sense of direction, this teleology, this movement towards an ultimate point of resolution becomes weaker and weaker and weaker to the point that

it becomes very difficult at times, if you're not accustomed to this language, to follow the development of these pieces. It becomes very complex, very rapid, very dense, and in addition to that, extraordinarily intense.

- 7.49** And what this does is it pushes him towards a crisis point. The traditional tools of music, the traditional techniques of harmony, no longer are really functioning in the same manner in his music. If you pile up dissonances, if you pile up these chords that normally are meant to resolve, and you don't resolve them, and you have chains of them, and you modulate all over the place, and you're changing keys constantly, and you have lots of twisty, melodic chromatic melodies, then the orientation function that harmony has, or at least Classical harmony, starts to simply break down.
- 7.50** It no longer matters if a piece is in a certain key or not. It no longer matters if your piece is in C major, or D minor, or E flat minor, or whatever it is. It's not oriented around a single axis. It's not oriented around a single point of reference anymore in a way that is particularly evident to the listener. This is not something that started with Schoenberg. You already see this in Liszt, where the music is getting increasingly complicated harmonically and increasingly distant from that idea of resolution. And Wagner pushes it even farther in his operas.
- 7.51** So he's not coming out of nowhere with this, but what he senses, perhaps in a way that is maybe more prescient or more he perhaps feels it more intensely than other artists, is that I can't write in a key anymore. It doesn't make sense. There's no real functionality to these chords anymore. And the next logical step beyond that is to simply write music that isn't in any particular key. So we no longer have a symphony in C major or a D minor or whatever. There's no key anymore. And what that means, technically, is that any chord can follow any other chord. Any tone can follow in the other tone, in principle, the composer is guided only by their intuition.
- 7.52** Now, there are parallel developments in the other arts that mirror this phenomenon. The advent of expressionism, for example, in painting or symbolism in poetry, where you're no longer necessarily going to have a clear and straightforward narrative. You might have an extremely condensed, elusive form of expression, or you might no longer have any formal rhyme or metrical scheme whatsoever in the poetry. You might be writing free verse, for example, or verse that imitates the cadence of speech rather than the regular repeating metrical patterns of Classical poetry.
- 7.53** All of this is happening in this Viennese context, concurrently with developments like psychoanalysis. So there's a profound rethinking of what art can do, what art can express, and what tools it might need in order to do that. This pushes Schoenberg into a world of atonality, a world in which there's no longer a single point of reference in the harmony, and the harmony is increasingly diverging from any identified reliable functionality.

- 7.54** Functionality simply means that you can ascribe a function to the chord. You can say this is a tonic chord, this is a dominant chord, this is a subdominant chord, or in other technical terminology, you could say this is a one-chord, four-chord, five-chord, etc. This is the traditional language, the traditional classification, if you like, of courts in Western harmony. But that breaks down here. It no longer works because the functions, if they're there, are so complicated, they're so distant from anything that you can explain in a traditional harmony textbook that there's simply no point in classifying them that way anymore.
- 7.55** All right, so I mentioned that he's not the only one doing this, and Debussy is doing it in a slightly different way over in France. And then there are other artists such as Hugo Wolf, who's a composer of Lieder of German art songs, who's also really pushing at the edges of what you can do in harmony. But again, Schoenberg is the first to take this radical step of saying, well, we just won't write music in a key. We're going to see what happens if I follow my intuition. There are still certainly traces—I mean, you can't erase these old functions from music entirely. It's impossible. They're there. They're encoded in the very instruments that we use. They're encoded in our sense of melody, in our sense of phrase. If you play any tones on the keyboard, some residual harmonic function is going to be there. The difference is that it's dramatically sped up and the dissonances are not resolved.
- 7.56** So this again brings us to the advent of atonality in music, music that is not written in a particular key. If anything can be said to have caused challenges for audiences, it is this, atonality. And part of the reason for that is it's very difficult to hear patterns sometimes in these pieces. And patterns are a really big part of what we think of as providing a sense of order and a sense of relatability in a piece of music. But this is the crux of the matter. We talked at the outset of this lecture about the tension, if you like, between inner necessity and external pressures.
- 7.57** And so Schoenberg's idea is, well, I'm being compelled in this direction. It's not me. These are historical forces. The language of music itself is pushing in this direction, and my need for expression is pushing in this direction. It's not that he wanted to sabotage the great tradition of Western art music or anything like this. It's that there was a sense of compulsion. This is where it has to go next. Now, this advent of atonality is dramatized in a spectacular fashion in his second string quartet. This is a piece that dates from 1908. This is the precise point where you can see this structure, this way of organizing music, literally falling apart before your eyes and giving rise to something else in its place.
- 7.58** The first two movements of this piece, arguably the first three movements of the piece, are written in an extended tonal vein, which is to say they're still basically in this harmonic world, this Classical harmonic world, but really, we're right at the edge. And he's writing this piece, and it's going along, and he's trying to basically still write a

Classical string quartet, but it's breaking down. It's no longer working. And he has this intuition.

7.59 In the last two movements of the piece. He's reading a book of poems by a German symbolist poet called Stefan George. He gets really struck by the power of these poems and decides he has to set them to music. And the project he happens to be working on is a string quartet. So halfway through the quartet, suddenly a soprano is joining the string quartet and starts singing these poems of Stefan George. So it's quite an odd piece because you don't normally have a soprano in a string quartet, but he decided that that's what he needed to do. So now we have a string quartet plus soprano.

7.60 And in the final movement of this quartet, that's the point at which there's no longer a key and it breaks down. And the poem that he's setting, which I'm going to read to you, is called *Entrückung*, or Rapture. And the poem starts with a famous opening line, which exemplifies the spirit of the time, this advent of psychoanalysis, late Romanticism starting to spiral into early modernism and the breakdown of a lot of things that up to this point had ordered our perceptions.

7.61 The first line of the poem is, "I feel air from another planet." And it continues, "The faces that once turned to me in friendship pale in the darkness before me, and trees and paths that I once loved fade away so that I scarcely recognize them. And you, bright beloved shadow, summoner of my anguish, are now extinguished completely in deeper flames in order after the frenzy of warring confusion to reappear in a pious display of awe. I lose myself in tones, circling, weaving with unfathomable thanks and unnameable praise. Bereft of desire, I surrender myself to the great breath. A tempestuous wind overwells me in the ecstasy of consecration, where the fervent cries of women praying in the dust implore. Then I see a filmy mist rising in a sun-filled open expanse that includes only the farthest mountain retreats. The land looks white and smooth like whey. I climb over enormous ravines. I feel like I am swimming above the furthest cloud in a sea of crystal radiance. I am only a spark of the holy fire. I am only a whisper of the holy voice."

7.62 Here is the fourth movement of the String Quartet No. 2, Opus 10, by Arnold Schoenberg.

7.63 [musical piece]

7.64 "I feel the air of other planets." Perhaps no better phrase to encapsulate this direction in music. In a sense, once this had happened, it was as though Pandora's box had been opened. It was very difficult to go back. Of course, composers can write in any way they want, but suddenly there was this entirely new toolbox available. You could have a vastly expanded range of tones, harmonies, expressive gestures that were available. As you can see, there's much less outsourced to the wider culture in the sense that there's less obvious repetition, there are fewer recognizable figures from, well, things that you might recognize from other contexts.

- 7.65 So not all 20th-century music is that extreme or that expressive or that challenging or that radical. But you do start to see a very rapid expansion of the means, the expressive means, the technical means for artists. And whereas up to this point, you see this oscillation around a golden mean. There are composers that are more conservative in their orientation. There are composers who are more expansionist, trying to do new things and expand the language of music, but it always circles back to the middle, ultimately. Suddenly, in the 20th century, it just opens out into a vast ocean of possibilities.
- 7.66 We're going to stop there for now with Schoenberg, and we're going to talk in the second half today about Igor Stravinsky, who, in a sense, is the polar opposite of Schoenberg in many respects, but we'll look at that in a minute. But first, are there any questions/comments?
- 7.67 Thank you. My question's quite broad about classical music. When you see an orchestra, there's always a conductor. If each musician just has the sheet music, why is the conductor necessary?
- 7.68 Okay, that's an excellent question. In the Classical era, at the time of Haydn and Mozart, the conductor basically just gave a tempo. They were there just in order to—because you have a large body of musicians, and some are sitting at the front, some are sitting at the back, and you need someone to coordinate everybody and to give a tempo. In many cases, it actually wasn't a conductor at all. The first violinist would just nod and indicate the tempo, and then the other musicians would follow them. But in the time of Beethoven, that starts to change. And part of the reason it starts to change is that whereas in chamber music, music written for a smaller group of performers to be played, maybe in a more intimate setting, you don't need a conductor because there might only be four players, and they can just communicate amongst themselves, and that's fine.
- 7.69 But in the time of Beethoven, you start to see composers writing orchestral music that's more and more in a chamber music vein with these expressive subtleties, with changes of tempo. At that point, you can no longer just have somebody nodding their head. You actually have to have somebody to give the phrasing. You have to have somebody to rehearse the orchestra also to determine what are the things that we need to change, what are the things that need to be worked on.
- 7.70 What the audience doesn't see, of course, at a concert, they see someone waving their arms, but you don't see the whole rehearsal process because the conductor is responsible for that. The conductor comes in, knows the score extremely well, and will identify what are the difficult passages that we need to work on, what do we need to prioritize. And they'll also shape the interpretation. They'll have their own ideas about how the piece should be played, at what speed, what priorities you might have in the interpretation, what particular aspects or qualities of the piece do you want to

emphasize. But perhaps most of all, they want to take this body of performers and to unite them towards a common expressive purpose.

7.71 They want to rally the troops, so to speak, and get them to, well, bring out the absolute best of these players. But in a more strictly technical sense, what they're doing is if the music has to slow down or speed up, or if you want a little bit of flexibility in the phrasing, you don't want just [musical beat] like a motor all the time, like this automatic metronomic thing, which is actually how a lot of symphonies were performed in the 18th century.

7.72 But if you want something a little bit more expressive where the phrase can get a little bit faster, a little bit slower, you want to follow the cadences of speech a little bit more, not just some rigid metronomic precision, then you need a conductor for that. You need a conductor to control dynamics also, to make sure that the sound of the orchestra is balanced. You need somebody who's there who can hear everything that's going on and can say, "The brass are a little bit too loud there. I need a little bit more in the strings. This chord is not quite balanced. The second flute there is playing a little bit too loud. The intonation is not quite right between the third and the fourth horn." This kind of thing. There's a lot of technical, expressive, and purely musical considerations that go into it. That's really a 19th-century phenomenon, the advent of the conductor as an independent musician.

7.73 But I can tell you, I went to school in Paris for musical composition, and there was a conducting department there, and the entrance requirements for conducting were insane. I could not believe it, what they had to do technically in order to get into that class. Just absolutely flawless ability to sight-read. You have to be able to hear a hugely complicated chord and immediately identify if there's a wrong note in the second trombone part and spot it and say, okay, here's how we fix it.

7.74 You have to have perfect hearing, perfect ears, and just an incredible ability to rapidly assimilate a large amount of repertoire. So the technical demands made on conductors are extreme. Of course, if you go to a concert, you don't want to be thinking about all that. You just want to enjoy the piece. And naturally, you're not thinking about the weeks of rehearsal that went into it. So thank you for the question.

7.75 Is there a correlation between the structure of Mozart to what appears to be these more chaotic forms of music with the demise of Christendom and the course of history?

7.76 I think what we can say is that, well, there's quite a few factors that go into this. The Industrial Revolution is very considerable part of it. You have to remember that the audience for music in the 18th century was limited. These pieces of Mozart were played either in opera houses, but often in private circumstances for the nobility. There wasn't this vast middle-class audience for music the way we might understand it today.

- 7.77 The 18th century brings about this general improvement in living conditions, which gives people more leisure time, which means they have more time to listen to music, which also resulted in a vast expansion of the demand for music in all of its varied forms. And not only that, not just live music, but also recorded music and sheet music. And with any vast expansion of demand, you start to see an increasing micro-specialization. If you go into a contemporary supermarket, you won't have one toothpaste. You'll have 50 kinds, sometimes 100 kinds. It's maddening, actually, if you have to choose.
- 7.78 But there's something of that in the increased individualization, if you like, and specialization of artists and composers, where it becomes increasingly difficult to find a center, a center in the culture, this simplicity, I suppose. You get this increasing tendency towards individualization and increasingly idiosyncratic and individual forms of musical expression. There's a number of factors that go into that, but there's not a direct correlation between Christendom, and what is going on musically. Schoenberg was quite devout, for example. Most of these artists were.
- 7.79 There's a sense in which—see, some people would argue that music is a language that has its own internal codes. It's almost like you could view it as a science, perhaps, or something that has its own internal logic. And that internal logic, and our understanding of that internal logic can change and evolve. It's almost as though it's not the individual artist that's exercising their will and pushing things in this or that direction, but the very language of music that the music itself wants to expand and change and develop. Artists are simply going where they're bidden to go.
- 7.80 Schoenberg had this sense. A lot of the Romantics did that they weren't exercising their own individual will necessarily in doing this or that, but rather they were taking dictation in a sense. They were doing what was given to them to be done. There was this potential in the music. There was this thing that needed to be explored, and they had to go there.
- 7.81 Schoenberg himself had a very funny attitude about it. He was almost dismayed at the historical position he found himself in. But he really did have this sense that this was an inevitable thing, an inevitable historical development. It was his task to do this. So, these are very, very broad and complex historical forces. And that's probably the best five-minute resume I can provide. Thank you for the question.

Lecture 8: Igor Stravinsky

At a glance — Igor Stravinsky.

- 8.1 We've spoken about Arnold Schoenberg and the quite extraordinary trajectory that his work goes on from the early works written in a late Romantic idiom through to modernism and through to an increasingly intense and extreme form of expression, the influence of expressionism on his own music, his tendency to express himself in the most extreme emotions.
- 8.2 The life of Igor Stravinsky is extremely interesting in this sense because—we talked about the fact that the rate of change in music history starts to accelerate in the second half of the 19th century, the Industrial Revolution and other historical and social factors. Stravinsky is very interesting in this respect because his development is perhaps, in a sense, even more extreme than that of Schoenberg.
- 8.3 He's born in 1882 in St. Petersburg. Wagner is still alive at that point, 1882. He dies in 1971, outliving the Beatles. So his life spans Wagner and the Beatles. Well, possibly even disco. It's an interesting thing to contemplate. So he lived to be 88 years old, and his life spans most of the 20th century and a good part of the 19th century as well.
- 8.4 And Stravinsky is a fascinating figure. He's somebody that—I think every composer on one level envies Stravinsky because he had this incredibly glamorous lifestyle. He wrote this incredible music that got everybody's attention. It was very striking. He's very fascinating in his attitudes also. He had a similar intransigence to that of Schoenberg, but his music in many respects is—well, it has this aura of glamour to it. I don't know how else to describe it.
- 8.5 He's also a bit of an esthetic chameleon, like Picasso. You know that Picasso went through all of these different successive periods in his artistic career and worked in different styles and idioms and tried out different things and lived in lots of different places. He was an international artist living all over the world. And it's the same with Stravinsky. Stravinsky was Russian, born in Russia, but lived in Switzerland. He lived in France. He lived in America, traveled all over the world. He was an international celebrity, and he changed his style many times over the course of his life.
- 8.6 So he's a strange figure in a sense, because the "Russian-ness," I suppose, of him as an artist is somewhat difficult to pinpoint. You can see it relatively clearly in the early works, but he's also absorbing influences from all over the place. He's the archetypal cosmopolitan artist who's at home everywhere in the world and picking up influences from everywhere and synthesizing them into something new.
- 8.7 So I mentioned that all artists envy Stravinsky in a way. He's remarkable in the sense that he had this capacity to set his own conditions for how he would live his life and how he would go about doing his work. He had the charisma, I suppose, and the force

of character and the persistence to achieve those things. So whereas the composers in the past—we looked at this—how they were able to do their work, what their terms of employment were like. We looked at Haydn's contract with the Prince Esterhazy, and this gradual emancipation of the artist from that dependence, and the advent with Beethoven of a more individual independent figure of an artist.

- 8.8** Well, Stravinsky, I think takes that to perhaps its logical conclusion. He was very, very skilled at getting commissions for pieces that he'd already written, for example. This is something that it's hard not to admire if you're an artist. Most of the time, if you're a professional artist, you wait for somebody to give you a commission, and they'll say, I need this or that, I need a mural, or I need a sculpture, or I want this piece to be played in my orchestra in two years, and then you go about your work, and you try to adhere to the terms of the commission. But Stravinsky, he was so famous and so glamorous in his lifetime that he could write whatever he wanted, essentially, write a piece, and then he'd find the commission afterwards. He'd find someone pay for it, which is just astounding, really. Wish I could figure out how to do that.
- 8.9** So I'll give you a brief biographical sketch of Stravinsky. Like Schoenberg, he was not particularly precocious. Neither of these figures were child prodigies or anything like that. They had a slow, hesitant march towards mastery of their means. The early pieces of Stravinsky are astoundingly inept, in fact. He really did not have much facility in the earlier part of his creative life.
- 8.10** Eventually, he was taken under the wing of Nikolai Rimsky-Korsakov, who was a composer writing in a late Romantic idiom in Russia. Rimsky-Korsakov was a consummate master of the orchestra, of orchestration, the art of writing for large numbers of instruments. We mentioned that the orchestra as a thing, as what would you say, a possibility for composers to write for, is expanding and increasing all the time throughout the 19th century. It gets larger, the number of instruments that are available starts to expand.
- 8.11** The instruments are more and more perfected. They have more and more technical possibilities. There are more and more ways of combining different instruments. And, well, the orchestra becomes this enormously complex machine. And suddenly, it's not enough just to write a piano score and then say this part goes to the flutes and this part goes to the strings and so on. Writing for orchestra becomes a whole complicated task in its own right that has its own artistry, its own codes, its own particular technicality that have to be mastered.
- 8.12** And Rimsky-Korsakov is an absolute consummate master of it. He thinks in terms of the orchestra, he thinks in terms of this vast palette of colors and of sounds that you can write, and writes these beautiful architectural frescoes like Scheherazade. That was Stravinsky's teacher. And Rimsky-Korsakov really insisted upon this coloristic and orchestrational approach. And that is something that absolutely and utterly defines Stravinsky as an artist.

- 8.13** There's a sound to his music that is utterly distinctive. Nobody else sounds like it. You can identify a Stravinsky composition in two seconds. It's very obvious. He never thinks abstractly in terms of sound. He never thinks of a note, a C sharp or a D or an E flat. He's always thinking in terms of this particular tone played on this instrument at this dynamic level with this articulation in this context, and it has to be very specific. You can't switch it around very easily.
- 8.14** So in a sense, the music is becoming more and more based around tone color, a particular approach to sound. Now, that in itself is the product of a long historical process. If you look at Renaissance music or a lot of Bach's music, a certain fundamental level, there's a degree of abstraction to it. You can take—you can take Bach's keyboard works, you can take The Art of the Fugue, and you can play it on whatever you want. You can play it on organ, you can play it on harpsichord. It won't destroy the fabric of the music if you do that. On the contrary, it can work very nicely.
- 8.15** The reason for that is there are no specifically instrumental gestures in a lot of those pieces. What you have are lines, and lines can be expressed with a voice, they can be expressed with an instrument. That's fine. But in the 19th century, sound itself, timbre itself, the sounds of specific instruments playing in specific ways becomes more and more and more important. It becomes an autonomous component of the art of music.
- 8.16** It's perhaps best to think of music as a multi-dimensional art. There's a lot that goes into making a piece of music. You have, let's say, the horizontal dimension, the melodic dimension of music. You have the vertical dimension, which is the harmonic level when you have sounds that you hear simultaneously that form chords. There's the rhythmic aspect of music. There's timbre.
- 8.17** Some would argue that space itself is part of those different musical parameters. The fact that the sound can come from here or from there, it can be close, it can be from far away. If you go to a movie theater and you hear the sound projected in 5.1, then you'll have speakers all over the cinema, and the sound can be directional, and it can move in a circle, and it can move front and back, and so on. It's the same in orchestras. You can position instruments in the front or in the back. You can have them in the wings. You can have them scattered throughout the hall. You can have all kinds of spatial effects.
- 8.18** So the possibilities of music, the different parameters within which it can operate, are clearly expanding. Tone color itself becomes arguably as important as pitch and as rhythm. And certainly, Schoenberg knew how to exploit that because his orchestral music is extraordinarily colorful. But probably the consummate master of this new art of sound and this newly sophisticated approach to orchestration is Stravinsky. I don't think anybody has ever really done it better. So that's really, I think, where Stravinsky is at his strongest. But in sharp contrast to Schoenberg, he's not so interested in the art of development.

- 8.19** Schoenberg represents the most extreme endpoint of that logical process of taking ever smaller bits of musical material, musical cells, little motifs, and seeing what you can do with them, how they can evolve and vary and change over the course of the piece, and creating a whole complicated architecture out of a small number of individual starting points. Schoenberg is really following in that Beethovenian tradition of development. What can you do with the material? Where can you take it? How can you have it change and be varied over the course of the whole piece?
- 8.20** Not Stravinsky. A lot of Stravinsky's music is articulated in individual blocks that are not particularly dynamic in nature, which is to say they don't really move very much. They move rhythmically. There's a rhythmic articulation, but there isn't that directional tendency of the music always flowing forward and moving and changing all the time. That's not really his thing.
- 8.21** Instead, you have these static blocks. So you'll have a particular texture or a particular type of rhythm or a particular melodic gesture, and he'll vary it and he'll permutate it, and he'll do a few things to it. And once he's exhausted the potential of that, then he'll move on to something else. So a lot of his music functions really more on the level of contrast and opposition than it does on a large-scale continuity or a continual sense of development and change. He's not alone in that. Development, as such, stops being a predominant mode of imagining a musical continuity in the 20th century for quite a lot of composers. But he's perhaps the most glamorous and perhaps the most extreme example of that.
- 8.22** So he would make these pieces that are—you can think of them almost as being like a mosaic, a mosaic form, where you have these individual colored tiles set next to each other. And the way that the colors offset each other and the way they link up to form larger-scale patterns is the way the music is articulated. So this is music that is, in a sense, extraordinarily appealing because it's so colorful, it's so captivating, the sound is so distinctive, and it has this incredible rhythmic vitality and rhythmic energy to it. It's very tactile; it's very coloristic. It's hard to describe. Of course, you have to hear it, which we will do very shortly.
- 8.23** Now, Stravinsky achieved fame relatively early on in his life and a very particular type of fame whereas Schoenberg always had this very problematic relationship with his audience and was not necessarily what you would call a household name during his lifetime. Stravinsky became extraordinarily famous in his late 20s. He met a Russian impresario called Diaghilev, who was in charge of the Russian ballets, and was commissioned to write a series of ballets for this company that were premiered, among other places, in Monte Carlo and Monaco and other such worldly locations, and commissioned Stravinsky to write a ballet called *The Firebird*. And *The Firebird* is a massive success. And it is an absolutely amazing piece. It's astoundingly accomplished for a composer of 28 years.

- 8.24** The Firebird is rapidly followed by Petrushka, which is premiered in 1911. And then the icing on the cake is the Rite of Spring, which follows in 1913, immediately before the outbreak of the First World War. So this is a trio. This constitutes a trio of Russian ballets, all on themes derived from Russian folklore. And a lot of the music is also derived from folk music inspirations. And that's something that you see, in actually quite a few different composers. You see Bartók doing the same thing, Debussy certainly. Bartók is leaning heavily on Hungarian folk music in his own music. Janáček, who's deriving a lot of his ideas from Czech traditional music, and so on and so forth.
- 8.25** There's an increased sense of nationalism. Well, that arises concurrently with the rise of the concept of the nation state in much of Europe throughout the latter part of the 19th century. So composers identifying very strongly with a particular national tradition, as opposed to, let's say, the culture of a particular city, or they're thinking more in terms of their nation. You see Stravinsky using bits of Russian folk music and orienting his music to incorporate these things. It's in a very interesting and distinctive mix.
- 8.26** So whereas The Firebird and Petrushka were—it's not that they're easy listening exactly, but they're very colorful, they're very appealing pieces, and they were both very successful with audiences. The Rite of Spring—The Rite of Spring gives us the first really famous incident of a riot in music, of an extremely violent negative reaction to the piece, perhaps even more so than some of the concerts of Schoenberg, and it's certainly one of the most famous examples of this.
- 8.27** The Rite of Spring was premiered in Paris at the Théâtre des Champs-Élysées in 1913. It's not clear if this was drummed up by Diaghilev and by Stravinsky or if they wanted this riot to happen in order to generate publicity for the premiere. But there's something in the nature of this piece, The Rite of Spring, that is really quite fundamentally different somehow than the pieces that preceded it. It's violent. It's violent. It's strange. It's extremely repetitive. It has these harsh, brutal rhythms that repeat and repeat. It's rhythmically complicated. It's full of strange sounds. The piece opens with a bassoon, this giant bass woodwind instrument playing in the extreme upper end of its register. It's filled with all these novel tone colors, things that nobody had ever heard before. And it tells a rather dark story.
- 8.28** The story of The Rite of Spring is of a sacrificial ritual. People dancing in a circle, and then a group of elders selects the chosen one who must then enter the circle and dance herself to death. It's this pagan rite that expresses this extraordinary violence. But it's also an unforgettable piece. And The Rite of Spring, not only did that make Stravinsky internationally famous, there's absolutely nothing else in music history that sounds like this piece. It's completely novel, and you could not be indifferent to it. Everybody who heard this piece had an opinion, and it changed music forever.
- 8.29** Suddenly, the rhythmic possibilities of Western music were dramatically expanded. We talked about the fact that in Classical music, you have a relatively limited array of dense

patterns. You have rhythms in 2, rhythms in 3, rhythms in 6/8. We call them compound rhythms, where there's two beats per bar or three beats per bar, but they're subdivided into smaller beat units like 1-2-3, 2-2-3, 3-2-3, etc. There's a limited number of metrical patterns and dance types in that music. And for the most part, it's largely symmetrical and regular. But here's the thing. Eastern European folk music doesn't work like that. It doesn't fall into these simple repeating patterns.

- 8.30** The music of the Balkan countries, Bulgaria, Macedonia, music of Hungary, a lot of traditional Greek music also doesn't work that way. Instead, you have asymmetrical beat patterns. You don't have 1-2-3-4. You might have 1-2, 1-2-3, 1-2, 1-2, 1-2-3, 1-2, 1-2, 1-2-3, 1-2, 1-2, 1-2, 1-2, 1-2-3, 1-2-3, 1-2, 1-2. Irregular groupings of beats. Now, they would be actually quite a lot faster than what I just did.
- 8.31** But there's a particular rhythm that's associated with Turkey and other countries called the aksak, which is a limping rhythm or an irregular rhythm, where the beats are alternately long and short, and the patterns can be quite complicated. The beats are not exact multiples of each other. It's not [musical beat], it's like, [musical beat] it's like there's a short beat and a long beat, but they're not—it's very difficult to imitate that if you're not from that culture because it's a corporeal thing. It's a gesture. It's a thing that you absorb. It's very difficult to notate precisely how those rhythms work.
- 8.32** Anyway, so Stravinsky is interested in all of these different folk rhythm patterns that are not regular. And what he does in *The Rite of Spring* in a more extreme manner than he'd ever done before in his career is he bases a lot of the piece on these rhythms. You can imagine that for a contemporary orchestra, 1913 French orchestra that had never seen anything like this, that was going to cause some problems. The piece is extraordinarily difficult to play. The rhythms are complicated. The meter is changing all the time.
- 8.33** And not only that, but the rhythmic figures don't necessarily line up with the meter, which is to say that traditionally you have the first beat in the bar, which is called the downbeat, and that's an accent. That's an accented beat. One, two, three, four; two, two, three, four. And by and large, the phrasing lines up with that basic pattern of weak and strong beats.
- 8.34** But if you start displacing the accents and do that on a regular basis, where the strong beat doesn't always necessarily fall on the downbeat, but it might fall in the middle of the second beat or at the end of the bar. Then on top of that, you have constantly changing time signatures, constantly changing meter, and you've got 100 musicians who have to all do this at the same time somehow, then it becomes very, very challenging for the performers.
- 8.35** When this was new, when nobody had ever done it before, that in itself was enough to make the piece very, very challenging and problematic for the performers. Then you add this scandalous and very violent story of the opera, and you have certainly the

recipe for a riot to occur. But it worked out for him. It made him internationally famous, and it resulted in a piece that left nobody indifferent, and that you certainly can't forget. So let's listen to the opening section of *The Rite of Spring*, and this is called *The Adoration of the Earth*. This is a ballet that is written in a number of different scenes that each present us with different situations in the story.

- 8.36** This is an introductory movement for the piece. It's the first thing you hear, and it's intended to set the atmosphere. What is actually happening here is we start with a single voice in the orchestra, that high bassoon solo, playing this strange sound way up on a top C, which, by the way, it wasn't even clear that that could be technically done. It's right at the top of the bassoon's range.
- 8.37** And bassoonists don't normally have to play a difficult solo right at the start of an orchestral piece with 100 of their colleagues staring at them in front of a crowded concert hall in Paris. That is rough. So Stravinsky is a bit of a—yeah, that was not nice of him. And today, it's absolutely standard repertoire for a bassoonist. They all have to learn this solo. They all have to do it at orchestral auditions. And it's not anything out of the unusual anymore.
- 8.38** So this is the introductory movement of the *Rite of Spring*. It's setting the tone for the piece. And we start with that solo voice of just the bassoon, then gradually other woodwind instruments join in, and there's a chorus of these different sounds. You can sort of imagine a Russian woodland gradually waking up after the thaw of winter and all these different voices of different animals joining in gradually, and it piles up and builds and builds and builds. So, here's the first part of the *Rite of Spring*.
- 8.39** [musical piece]
- 8.40** I love that. It's so striking. It's so colorful. It's so fascinating. It's like I practically fall over backwards in admiration every time I hear the opening of that piece. There's just nothing like it. And it seems to come out of nowhere. It's just so shockingly original. It's just an amazing thing to have done. It's so deeply predicated on these incredibly interesting tone colors, the high register of the bassoon, the English horn, the E flat clarinet, this little piccolo clarinet playing these little birdlike sounds, the harmonics on the strings, all of these different coloristic touches in the piece that make it so distinctive.
- 8.41** The *Rite of Spring*, not only did it cause a riot at its premiere. I mean, it was difficult for the musicians. It was extremely difficult to dance to as well. You can imagine the sorts of dance steps that had to be learned by the ballet company. But it made an enduring and lasting impression on Western musical culture, and so much so that after Stravinsky eventually emigrated to the United States, like Schoenberg, he ended up in California. He met Walt Disney in the 1930s, and Disney decided to animate sections of *The Rite of Spring* for his movie *Fantasia*. So suddenly, Stravinsky is not only famous in artistic circles, he's a household name, an international celebrity of colossal

proportions. Everybody knows him as the composer of this famous piece, The Rite of Spring.

- 8.42** Now, that's an extraordinary thing. That doesn't happen very often in Classical music or in this tradition, where you have a coming together of this erudite, learned style, this music coming out of this Classical tradition with the popular, with the commercial world. It's very, very, very rare for that to happen. You could argue that Mozart was able to achieve that with his operas, that there's a coming together of a learned style and a popular style. And there's an exquisite perfect fusion of those two things. The most elevated, technically accomplished, sophisticated musical language and expression fused together with something that is popular in its orientation.
- 8.43** So weirdly enough, this radical work of musical modernism achieved that. And again, this is the thing that made Stravinsky really a lightning rod, both for criticism, but also for admiration amongst his contemporaries and colleagues, because it's very difficult to achieve that level of notoriety and fame as a composer, but he certainly had it in spades.
- 8.44** So just to resume his life trajectory. So he was born in Russia, but was very interested in achieving success in the West. And throughout the 1910s, he spends a lot of time, thanks to his collaboration with Diaghilev and his authorship of these different ballets that are being premiered in Western Europe, he spends a lot of time in France and Switzerland, and he eventually settles in France in 1920. So after about 1920, his style starts to change. He starts moving away from this initial Russian style into, well, quite a significant esthetic pivot. He starts writing in this Neoclassical style.
- 8.45** And first, I have to say that by Neoclassical, I don't mean that he was simply copying the style of Haydn or copying the style of Mozart. It's not that at all. But Stravinsky always needed some kind of a model, some kind of an external model to base his artistic intuitions around. In the case of the three Russian ballets, he's taking Russian folklore, he's taking Russian folk music, and he's transfiguring it. He's turning it into something else. He's using it as the basis for his esthetic intuition. In the neoclassical works, he's doing the same thing. It's just that he's no longer basing himself on Russian folkloristic sources.
- 8.46** Instead, he starts being interested in what can you do with the old Classical structures, what can you do with the Classical concepts of voice leading and so on and harmonies. But he very much orients them towards his own manner. So what he's always doing is taking something that already exists in some form or another and completely transfiguring it, completely transforming it and molding it into his own sensibility. And he does this better than just about anybody else.
- 8.47** So in this Neoclassical period, he's taking some recognizable elements, rhythmic elements, melodic elements, harmonic elements from Classical music, but refashioning them in his own style. And he does this for approximately 20 years. This was

problematic for some of his followers because they saw him as this radical revolutionary, writing *The Rite of Spring*, and writing *Petrushka* and the symphonies of wind instruments, all of these radical pieces that he wrote in the 1910s. And they see this as a bit of a regression. They see this as him looking backwards instead of looking forwards.

- 8.48** And this gives rise to a very odd, but nevertheless rather illuminating misunderstanding, I think, which is that Stravinsky represents a regressive tendency in 20th century art. He's looking backwards, whereas Schoenberg is always pushing forward. He's always innovating. He's always trying new things and experimenting. This is exemplified in a book of philosophy written by the German author, Theodor Adorno, called *The Philosophy of New Music*.
- 8.49** Now this, again, this is a lens through which many people still to this day view the music of the 20th century. There are these two polar opposites. There are these two directions you can go in. There's the direction of regression, in other words, of making music that's based essentially on the music of the past, or making music that is necessarily out of step with its time because it's looking into the future.
- 8.50** Adorno calls this the "message in a bottle" attitude, which is that "I'm going to make this thing, there's no audience for it, but I'm going to throw it into the ocean and maybe someday someone will find this bottle and receive the message." Maybe in 50 years, maybe in 100 years, maybe nobody will ever hear it. But the artist, says Adorno, is by necessity, because they're in the process of creating something new, they're going to find themselves without an audience.
- 8.51** So obviously, things look quite different from our present vantage point, but that was an enormously influential book. And for a long time in the 20th century, there was this attitude that you had to choose your camp. You were either in the Stravinsky camp or in the Schoenberg camp. You were either writing with musical elements that had an audible connection to the past, or you were doing something that was extremely novel. It's like you have to choose.
- 8.52** Now, that's certainly no longer the case. And one could argue that it was never really truly the case anyway because artists don't simply line up and adhere to these ideologies the way philosophers might like them to do. But in any case, you can nevertheless use that as a way of getting oriented, let's say.
- 8.53** So I want to play you an example of Stravinsky's Neoclassical music. This is a piece called the *Concerto in D*. It's a violin concerto. And already, just the simple fact that it's a violin concerto in D major tells you something. Well, that's obviously referring explicitly to a Classical form. It's a piece that was written in 1931, and it's in a very different style from *The Rite of Spring*, but it's still Stravinsky through and through. You have the same orchestral brilliance, the same novel tone colors, the same sense of

rhythm, the same sense of articulation, same sense of dynamism, but it's a very different idiom.

- 8.54** Now, when he calls his piece Concerto in D, it doesn't necessarily mean that the piece is in D major. This is a strange quirk of Stravinsky because he never wrote conventional harmony, ordinary Classical harmony. He always twists it, does something a little bit odd with it. He has very strange chord voicings, very strange note choices. I think the way to look at it is he's using a D major scale. He's using the notes of a D major scale in this piece, but he's not using them in the conventional way.
- 8.55** It's like you were to take a D major scale, the idea of D major, and use that as a lump of clay, but then mold it into something and twist it and turn it and do all kinds of things with it. That's more or less what he's doing here. There are fragments of the language of Bach in this piece. There are little melodic ideas and gestural and rhythmic ideas that certainly bring that to mind. But it's a piece I'm rather fond of, so let's listen to a couple of minutes of the first movement of the Violin Concerto in D.
- 8.56** [musical piece]
- 8.57** Stravinsky was actually quite a gifted pianist and went around touring as a performer for much of his life. And in the latter part of his life, he was very active as a conductor and traveled the world doing that, conducting his own pieces. Everybody who heard him play the piano said that he had an extraordinary electric sense of rhythm. It was absolutely riveting to hear. I think that comes across in these pieces.
- 8.58** Just in this excerpt of the Violin Concerto we just heard, it's extremely rhythmically vital and exciting. The rhythms are relatively simple. It's this [musical beat]. But he manages to turn it into something really quite infectious. So that's an example of that second manner of his, the neoclassical style. It's, I suppose, not as conspicuously revolutionary as the Rite of Spring, but it's still him.
- 8.59** But Stravinsky moves along in this idiom for 15-20 years and writes a series of works that are quite remarkable. He writes this octet for wind instruments. He writes a whole sequence of other ballets and various concertos. And he writes a massive opera in the 1940s called The Rake's Progress, which is the story, similarly, actually, to Don Giovanni, the story of a dissolute individual who meets his ultimate end.
- 8.60** After the premiere of this opera, which I think is a wonderful piece, it's extremely well written and very appealing. It's got a wonderful libretto. It's a great story, actually. But Stravinsky starts to be more and more anxious about the direction he's taking and worrying about how he's being perceived by audiences, how he's being perceived also by his colleagues, how he's being perceived as an artist, as somebody who's working in these refashioned Classical styles that are no longer particularly current.
- 8.61** And whereas Schoenberg was never troubled by that. He always had this sense that: It's my destiny. It's me. I have to do this. I have to go in this direction. If the audience

didn't follow him immediately, he had this sense that eventually, maybe not that everybody would like it, but that eventually everybody would acknowledge the greatness of what he'd done. So he was resigned to this idea that it's not going to appeal to everybody right away, but that doesn't matter because this is what I have to do.

- 8.62** Stravinsky, on the other hand, is a little bit more self-conscious, partly because he has such a massive public career. He's a huge public figure, and he's more acutely aware of the impact that his work is having and how it's being perceived by others. And he starts to develop this anxiety that he's being perceived as being backwards in a way. He's no longer moving with the times.
- 8.63** And in the postwar era, particularly after the Second World War, there's this new generation of composers that starts to emerge that finds themselves in a radically new world. This is the postwar world where the European order has been completely upset. Their cities have been absolutely leveled. The society has profoundly changed forever. A lot of the assumptions and attitudes that have been prevalent in the time before the Second World War were now being called into question.
- 8.64** And well, there was also a rapid technological development that started to occur around this time, in addition to the need to rapidly to rebuild all of these cities. And along with that came this new generation of composers that was similarly radical in its outlook, in its fundamental orientation. And along with the idea that, well, perhaps we could rebuild society in a very different manner, came this idea that perhaps we could rethink the whole language of music in a very different manner.
- 8.65** These composers, born in the 1920s and coming of age in the immediate post-war era, made quite a lot of noise. They made quite a big impression on contemporary audiences. And Stravinsky was not indifferent to that. He was aware of these figures, figures like the Italian Luigi Nono, the Frenchman Pierre Boulez, or the German Karlheinz Stockhausen. These are all names of composers that became well known in the 1950s. He's aware of this. He's aware of their—well, their tendency to explore entirely new territory, to rethink the very grammar of music, to rethink the possibilities of music in a profound manner.
- 8.66** And he's thinking, well, I'm still writing this neoclassical stuff that harkens back to an earlier century, and maybe I should reevaluate my own esthetic. And he starts moving in a very different direction. And to everybody's shock, he starts adopting some of the methods of Arnold Schoenberg in the later part of his life. Schoenberg had developed this method for dealing with this disordered chromaticism, this atonality that had formed a central component of his style from the 1910s onward.
- 8.67** He developed a method called the 12-note method or the dodecaphonic system—dodecaphonic, meaning 12 sounds or 12 tones. And what it is basically, if you take the 12 semitones, C, C sharp, D, D sharp, E, F, F sharp, etc., the 12 semitones of the

chromatic scale, that's all the white notes and all the black notes contained within an octave—and you set them in a fixed order of your own devising, so maybe your 12-tone row goes F sharp, A, E flat, G, etc. You determine an order, and you use this as a motif that runs through the entire piece. So all the materials in the piece will be derived from this fixed ordering of tones. So you can derive chords from that, you can derive melodies, and so on and so forth.

- 8.68** So that was Schoenberg's very idiosyncratic reaction to a very particular technical problem, which is, how do you write chromatic music, music in which there's no fundamental orientation point, there's no center of gravity, so to speak. The tones are related only to each other, and the composer is really just dependent on their own intuition. How do you find a way to create larger forms and to have some structure that you're basing yourself on so that you're not confronted every time you sit down to write with the totality of all possible worlds and no real rational basis upon which to make decisions? So he comes with this method in 1923.
- 8.69** For two figures that are as different as Schoenberg and Stravinsky, it was basically unimaginable that this would happen. But he was surrounded with a group of younger musicians and was increasingly concerned about his own work, and perhaps he just needed a change. Perhaps there was just an inner necessity that he needed to explore something new. In the mid-1950s, he starts writing music using this method developed by Schoenberg. And this inaugurates an entirely new esthetic chapter in Stravinsky's life. And it's absolutely remarkable that in this relatively advanced age, he's in his 70s at this point, that he completely changes. And it seems to have given him a new esthetic lease on life. And he writes this series of late pieces that are really quite extraordinary. They sound nothing like Schoenberg. They're definitely Stravinsky through and through, but it gave him a way to imagine his music in a fresh manner.
- 8.70** So I'm going to play you a short excerpt from a ballet that he wrote in 1954 called Agon, A-G-O-N. And Agon is a transitional work. There are still elements of his preceding language, and there's also elements of this new, very chromatic, twelve-tone approach in his work. And this is a very austere ballet describing a contest in ancient Greece, an athletic contest.
- 8.71** And you see all of his stylistic fingerprints here. You see these odd repeating rhythms. You see these metrical shifts, this wonderful emphasis on color. You see the bassoon come back. There's a nice bassoon line in this passage, and little coloristic touches like castanets. Anyway, I think this is a magnificent ballet, and this is this transitional work that comes later on in his life, Agon.
- 8.72** [musical piece]
- 8.73** So in many respects, these two artists, Schoenberg and Stravinsky, are really extremely different from each other, despite this late-stage rapprochement between the style of Schoenberg and that of Stravinsky. Nevertheless, their attitudes are fundamentally

different. Schoenberg is always red hot in his emotional intensity. It's intense, and you either love that or you hate it. It's not for everybody.

- 8.74** Stravinsky, on the other hand, has this coolness this detached, more objective quality. He doesn't seem to believe that the purpose of music is self-expression. He's got an attitude that's closer to that of Haydn, which is this more detached, more analytical ordering of materials of music in a way that is esthetically interesting, let's say. But he doesn't view it primarily as a vehicle for self-expression.
- 8.75** That's a very, very brief summary of the lives and achievements of these two artists. But I would certainly encourage you to look further. The 20th century is extraordinarily rich in artistic geniuses in every domain, of course, and music, not least of all.
- 8.76** There are so many figures that I would have liked to have gotten to in this course, but that's anyway a brief introduction to 250 years. It's quite a journey from the Leipzig Bach in 1720 to the Los Angeles in which both Schoenberg and Stravinsky died in 1951 and 1971, respectively. That's it. I, of course, invite your questions.
- 8.77** I had a question about something you spoke earlier on the terms of the conductor as well. Nowadays, obviously, any performer can go and use records for their first reading of a piece. How do you reckon that would come about in the beginning stages of these compositions or the commissions in those days, having an orchestra being brought this brand new piece with all these new sounds? How would the process of studying it and really mastering it for a concert be like?
- 8.78** It was much slower. For an orchestra to premiere a piece like *The Rite of Spring* in 1913, they had to have dozens of rehearsals. Any of these really radical new works had to be intensively rehearsed. Many of the key works of Stravinsky, we have stories about this, about as many as 40 or 50 rehearsals being required for the premiere of *Pierrot lunaire*, which is one of the great Schoenberg pieces, which seems unimaginable today because what's different now is that—well, first of all, we have musicians unions, and it's just become exponentially more expensive to run an orchestra than it was the case back then. Orchestral rehearsals are insanely, eye-wateringly expensive, and it's just not possible. No composer on Earth gets 40 rehearsals for an orchestral piece. It's impossible.
- 8.79** But in addition to that, the technical standards, the ability of orchestras to sight-read and to learn new repertoire rapidly has also increased quite considerably. By this point, we're now over 100 years past *The Rite of Spring*. This repertoire is familiar to all major orchestras. It's not going to frighten them. It's still difficult and it still requires careful preparation, but it's not coming out of nowhere.
- 8.80** So today, the process is a lot more efficient, I suppose, in certain ways. But that also brings with it a host of problems, which is that in many instances, if a composer is commissioned to write an orchestra piece today, they might have one rehearsal. They might have half an hour of rehearsal for their piece. And this is a huge problem because

while orchestras have a lot better and a lot faster at learning repertoire, half an hour is really pushing it.

- 8.81** The problem is that the audience just hears the performance. They don't read the score. They don't know what the composer has written. And if the orchestra doesn't have time to get familiar with the work, if they don't have time to enter into its world and try to figure out how they can interpret it, then you're going to get a very professional, but not necessarily the most exciting performance of the piece.
- 8.82** And part of the consequence of that, the part of the consequence of the colossal expense of commissioning and performing these pieces is that composers are increasingly just abandoning the orchestra altogether as a medium. It's just too complicated. Would you want to spend potentially a year of your life writing a piece that would be played maybe once and then maybe played again 35 years later and rehearsed for half an hour. You might not want to spend your time that way.
- 8.83** There are composers who do that, and there are composers who are very good at writing pieces in such a manner that they can smoothly work through that machine and don't cause a lot of problems that are relatively easy to play and relatively easy to rehearse. But not everybody wants to work that way. Today, increasingly, if you want to have more of an in-depth relationship with a performer and you want to go a little bit farther expressively and you want to really create something that can really speak to an audience, then you really have no other choice than to write chamber music, solo pieces, work with smaller formations.
- 8.84** That's not a new thing, by the way. There's an oscillation throughout music history between composers writing these grand public statement type pieces and then moving back more towards a more chamber music type of orientation. Schubert, for example, we mentioned, or Haydn, who were both arguably at their strongest in chamber music. Also in the period following the Second World War, there was a move away from those gigantic orchestras of Mahler and Wagner. It was just too expensive. It was too complicated. Composers writing more and more pieces for mixed chamber groups and smaller ensembles. Anyway, but whatever a composer decides to do, there's no getting away from those simple professional realities. You have to decide what you want to focus on and what it is that you can and would like to do.
- 8.85** Going on from there, how do film scores fit into the overall professional activity of the composer?
- 8.86** In the 1930s and 1940s, film scores were written largely by professional composers who were raised within this Classical tradition. There were a lot of Eastern European émigré Composers who moved to Hollywood in that period, such as Korngold and Bernard Herrmann and others, who basically were classically trained and were writing music that was very much in the vein of late Mahler and and Wagner and things like this. A lot of Hollywood film music from that time is very similar to late Romantic music.

- 8.87** Today, the situation is very different, partly because the worlds of art music and the worlds of commercial music have become divided like this. There are people who specialize in one or specialize in the other, but there are extremely few people who exist in both worlds or who can or who even want to. Now, that's something that ties in with the larger narrative of Romanticism and Modernism and our move through the 20th century, which is that the Classical era saw this braiding together of popular and savant styles. I mentioned earlier with respect to Mozart.
- 8.88** In the late 19th century, composers start getting a little bit more suspicious of popular culture and the advent of this new thing, which is mass culture, which had never existed before. Mass culture being things that can reach hundreds of thousands or potentially even millions of people through new technological means, such as mechanical reproduction of sound, television, radio, all of these new technologies. You start to see increasingly this divide between popular and commercial music and art music.
- 8.89** It's a simple historical fact. One can argue that it's not the healthiest situation because the savant styles traditionally were always nourished by and irrigated by the popular and vice versa, and it also filtered down into the popular realm. It may be that that will change again. I think it's a cyclical thing, but for the time being, you do have commercial composers whose professional network is utterly distinct from and different from the world of art music composers. There are some exceptions to that, again, but by and large, that's basically the case.
- 8.90** They are trained differently. For example, if you study composition at a university, you can study film music, you can study music for animation, you can study—there are even courses in theatrical music, or you can study composition per se, which is more in the classical tradition, I suppose. We separated these two things out, which I think is extremely unfortunate. My hope is that that will eventually change. And I think it is starting to change, actually. I think there's a recognition that composers can't remain off in a corner separate from the wider culture. We shall see.
- 8.91** Would you be able to let us know why is it that many of the greatest composers that we have in Classical music history all come from similar geographical regions in Europe and also within the same sort of time periods as well?
- 8.92** It's more a question for a sociologist or a historian because it's complicated, but there are political reasons for it. Part of it has to do with the support for music coming from the nobility, which was greater in some geographic locations than in others. Let's take the UK as an example. Britain actually had a very strong and very distinctive musical tradition in the 17th century, and there were a very large number of very important and brilliant composers coming out of England during that time—composers of the Tudor era, of the Elizabethan era.

- 8.93** That dries up, though, in the high Classical era. The composers that were the most prominent during that time were, in fact, German émigrés like Haydn and Handel. You don't really see a new flourishing of homegrown British composers until the early 20th century, again, with figures like Benjamin Britten, for example. Why is that? Well, it's partly that the nobility was simply not as interested in supporting artists, supporting musicians, and commissioning works from them. It was partly a change in fashion, a change in taste, and it wasn't a priority for them.
- 8.94** There are also some cultural reasons for this. I live right on the border between France and Germany, and so I'm very interested in the two countries and their differences. And one thing I've observed, many people have observed this as well, is that the Germans are extremely good at collective forms of music making. They're very strong with that. Anything that involves a group of people singing together in a choir or playing in an orchestra, they're extremely good at that.
- 8.95** The French, not so much. The French musical education system is much more geared towards producing soloists, but not so much producing orchestral musicians. Of course, there are orchestras in France, and there are some good ones, but they're not on the same level as the Austrian and German orchestras. It's just a cultural difference. On the other hand, there are more soloists coming out of France.
- 8.96** So some of these things are political, some of them are cultural, some of them are social. But it is true that you had all of these noble families in the Austro-Hungarian Empire, notably, but not only. And also in all of these different little duchies and principalities in what eventually became Germany. You had these noble families scattered all throughout this area that in many cases were prominent patrons of the arts. And this continued really up until about the Second World War. It changes after that point. We changed to other funding models, which we don't have to get into because it's a complicated topic.
- 8.97** The thing is, when looking at the history of music, you can't really get too far away from the question of who is paying for it because it matters. It's like, well, there was a prince or there was a count or there was a king who had resources at their disposal and an orchestra, and they wanted a lot of music. That created performance opportunities for composers and employment opportunities, and that created a necessity. But if nobody's asking for it, if there's no venue to play it, then that's how it goes.
- 8.98** What do you think is left to be explored in music nowadays, or essentially, what do you think is next as composers come up with new music today?
- 8.99** Well, I think that the inner world is vast. I think that it's unbounded. So human creativity is always expanding. It's always exploring. That's our nature as a species. We're explorers. The thing about creative types, generally, is they're compelled to explore. That's their nature. You cannot prevent artists from exploring. So that will continue. What form it will take, I can't say.

- 8.100** I think that music has always changed in response to changing social conditions, changing material conditions, changing technologies also. When you just look at the history of pop music and rock music and the ways that it's been changed by technologies, and that never changes. That never stops. That process is always ongoing.
- 8.101** I think it's like any art form, though. The fundamentals really basically do not change. We talked about photography on day one, the fact that photography is really about composition in light, and the technology of cameras and so on and lenses can change, but the basics never change. It's the same in musical composition. You're still dealing with the fundamental basic parameters of music, which are rhythm, pitch, or frequency, contrast, dynamism, change versus stasis, all of these fundamental polarities, all of these fundamental categories. Those don't change.
- 8.102** But styles change, our attitudes towards music change. And well, an artist will always want to try new things. So what's left to explore? God only knows. I don't know. But what I can say, because I'm an artist myself and a composer, is that you intuit things that exist in this ocean of potentiality, and you can grasp them as though there was a dark form down in the water. You can't see what it is. You can't tell what its contours are, but you can sense it's there, and you want to explore it, and you want to find out what it is, and you keep going. A lot of it is intuition. Sometimes that takes you into very new territory, and sometimes it doesn't. But I have no reason to think that process won't continue.